



THE  
SECRET ·  
CHART ·  
LIEVT·JAMES·K·ORTON





THE  
SECRET ·  
CHART ·

LIEV T·JAMES·K·ORTON

## **The Project Gutenberg eBook of The Secret Chart; or, Treasure Hunting in Hayti**

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: The Secret Chart; or, Treasure Hunting in Hayti

Author: James Otis

Release date: December 18, 2020 [eBook #64070]

Most recently updated: October 18, 2024

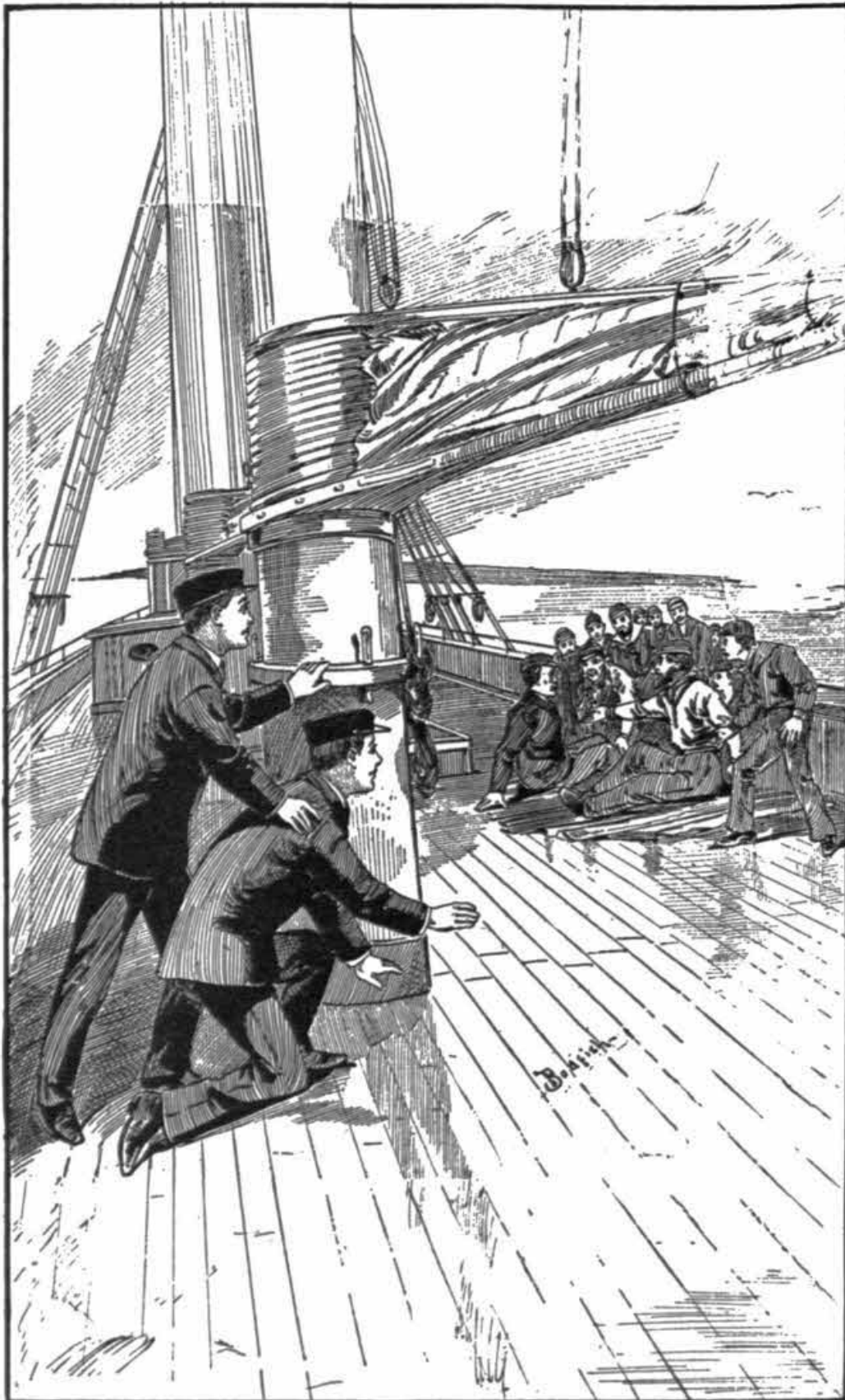
Language: English

Other information and formats: [www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/64070](http://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/64070)

Credits: Demian Katz, Craig Kirkwood, and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team at <https://www.pgdp.net> (Images courtesy of the Digital Library@Villanova University)

\*\*\* START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE SECRET  
CHART; OR, TREASURE HUNTING IN HAYTI \*\*\*





**“Gil led his cousin forward.” [See page 42.](#)**

---

# THE SECRET CHART

OR

## TREASURE HUNTING IN HAYTI

BY

LIEUT. JAMES K. ORTON

Author of "The Last Chance Mine," "Beach Boy Joe," etc.



PHILADELPHIA

DAVID McKAY, PUBLISHER

610 SOUTH WASHINGTON SQUARE





# THE SECRET CHART

OR

TREASURE HUNTING IN HAYTI

BY

LIEUT. JAMES K. ORTON

Author of "The Last Chance Mine," "Beach Boy Joe," etc.



PHILADELPHIA  
DAVID McKay, PUBLISHER  
610 SOUTH WASHINGTON SQUARE

---

Copyright, 1902  
By STREET & SMITH  
The Secret Chart

---

# CONTENTS.

| CHAPTER                     | PAGE                |
|-----------------------------|---------------------|
| I.—A Discovery              | <a href="#">5</a>   |
| II.—At Sea                  | <a href="#">13</a>  |
| III.—A Message              | <a href="#">21</a>  |
| IV.—The Castaways           | <a href="#">29</a>  |
| V.—Mischief                 | <a href="#">37</a>  |
| VI.—Mutiny                  | <a href="#">45</a>  |
| VII.—Set Adrift             | <a href="#">53</a>  |
| VIII.—Turning the Tables    | <a href="#">61</a>  |
| IX.—Bound South             | <a href="#">69</a>  |
| X.—Hayti                    | <a href="#">77</a>  |
| XI.—Conjectures             | <a href="#">85</a>  |
| XII.—A Strange Spectacle    | <a href="#">93</a>  |
| XIII.—In Trouble            | <a href="#">101</a> |
| XIV.—The Cave               | <a href="#">109</a> |
| XV.—A Discovery             | <a href="#">117</a> |
| XVI.—Andy                   | <a href="#">125</a> |
| XVII.—A Successful Scheme   | <a href="#">133</a> |
| XVIII.—Treasure Hunting     | <a href="#">141</a> |
| XIX.—The Wreck              | <a href="#">149</a> |
| XX.—The Underground Passage | <a href="#">157</a> |
| XXI.—A Trap                 | <a href="#">165</a> |
| XXII.—Run to Cover          | <a href="#">173</a> |
| XXIII.—Secret of the Cave   | <a href="#">181</a> |
| XXIV.—The Treasure Chamber  | <a href="#">189</a> |
| XXV.—To the Rescue          | <a href="#">197</a> |
| XXVI.—A Pitched Battle      | <a href="#">205</a> |
| XXVII.—Under Cover          | <a href="#">213</a> |
| XXVIII.—A Second Alarm      | <a href="#">221</a> |
| XXIX.—In the Tunnel         | <a href="#">229</a> |
| XXX.—The Story              | <a href="#">237</a> |

|                            |                            |
|----------------------------|----------------------------|
| XXXI.—An Opportune Arrival | <a href="#"><u>244</u></a> |
| XXXII.—The Departure       | <a href="#"><u>252</u></a> |

---



# THE SECRET CHART.

# CHAPTER I.

## A DISCOVERY.

Near the mouth of Spuyten Duyvil Creek the yacht *Day Dream* lay at anchor on a certain day in September, two years ago.

The driving rain only served to give her white hull, with its trimmings of gold, an additional luster, bringing into yet bolder relief the polished mahogany and walnut inboard woodwork.

Two sailors and an old colored steward remained below to escape an unnecessary wetting, and the fifty-ton beauty tugged at the cable as if trying to escape from her moorings before her caretakers should be aware of the fact.

On the river bank, half-hidden by a clump of trees, was the old stone house owned by Henry Mansfield, formerly a captain in the China trade, but now retired. Having accumulated considerable wealth, he believed it would be more pleasant to remain ashore permanently; but, after a short time of idleness, his love for the sea returned with redoubled force, and, as a result, the *Day Dream* was purchased.

On her the captain spent considerably more than half his time, and now the little craft was provisioned for a long southern cruise, much to the delight of the owner's son Gilbert, and his nephew, Nelson Duncan, who had, after no slight difficulty, succeeded in gaining permission to make the voyage.

The boys were on shore overhauling their traps, preparatory to leaving early next morning, and having considerable trouble in deciding just what should be left behind.

"We've laid out a big pile of stuff," Gilbert said, as he surveyed the guns, fishing tackle, clothes, and a general assortment of odds and ends, which both he and his cousin had thought would be necessary to their comfort and pleasure during the voyage; "but if we throw anything out, it will be just what we may want most when the yacht is at sea."

"But how are we to get so much aboard?"

“In case your trunk and mine won’t hold it all, there’s an old chest in the attic, which will be the very ticket. If it doesn’t stop raining pretty soon, we’ll have to get a piece of tarpaulin to cover them while going out to the schooner.”

That the old chest would be needed was learned very soon, and Gil said, with a sigh:

“There’s no question but that something must be left. We’ll pack the most important, and then decide as to the rest. Come on, it won’t take long to overhaul what is in the attic.”

The only idea in the minds of the boys was to secure that which would serve as a receptacle for their goods until the same could be carried to the schooner, and, on finding the well-worn chest, it was only natural to first make sure that it was empty.

The rusted lock was fastened, and, eager to complete the work as soon as possible, Gil knocked the hasp off by kicking at it, after which the lid was thrown open.

At first glance one would have said that it contained nothing, but on turning it upside down several articles rolled out.

Idle curiosity, rather than a belief that anything important would be found, caused the boys to pick up the contents, and Nelse cried, as he went toward the window:

“Say, Gil, here’s a piece of an old newspaper, containing what appears to be an old story. Where did the chest come from?”

“I don’t know. Read what you have found, if it is interesting.”

“There is a long account here, but if you can keep quiet a few moments, I’ll make it out, in spite of the many creases and the dirt.”

Then Nelse began the following:

“North of that wild promontory which projects itself into the tropic waters of the Mexican Gulf at the northwestern extremity of Hayti, and four miles to seaward of the ancient town, lies a rocky inlet known as Tortuga de Mar. In size and aspect it is insignificant. Yet, lilliputian and unfamiliar though it

now is, it gave birth to the most merciless and picturesque class of marine cutthroats known to history.”

“Keep that until we start,” Gil said, impatiently, as his cousin paused to take a long breath. “Just now we want to get our traps aboard, instead of reading some musty tale.”

“Wait a moment, and find out what it means. We’ve got plenty of time,” Nelse said, and then he continued:

“Back in the opening decades of the seventeenth century adventurous criminals from throughout the Antilles began to collect on the islet, and in a few years Tortuga became the recognized headquarters of the Spanish Main. From it as from a fever germ went out a fire of blood, piracy, and lawlessness which spread over the waters of the Western World.

“Tortuga was settled in the first years of this century by Spanish pioneers from the island known as Hispanola, or ‘Little Spain.’ It was given the fanciful name of Tortuga de Mar, ‘The Sea Tortoise,’ from its resemblance in shape to that amphibian. The settlers were a worthy and simple folk, for the most part fishermen, who, for a few months in the twelve, varied life by hunting the wild cattle which fed in the wooded coast lands.

“Scarcely had they become well established on the Tortoise, when, one morning in May, 1632, they were mystified at the sight of a pinnacle load of strange seamen landing on the key which faces the mouth of their harbor. Fifteen restless spirits from the French colony of St. Christopher had, with the adventurous recklessness which marked that day and those waters, set out for the best location which fortune and a west wind should put in their way. They were allowed to put up sapodilla shelters at the harbor mouth, and also to shoot their French bullets into wild bulls on the opposite coast.

“In a few weeks it became evident that the rascally strangers could slaughter and *boucan* more beeves in a day than the entire Spanish community could in three. *Boucanning*, by the way, was a peculiar process of curing flesh by jerking, salting, and drying in the sunshine, the term being derived from an aboriginal word applied by the cannibal Caribbes to the curing of human flesh. Such was the skill of the intruders in converting the bulls into a superior, merchantable product by means of the *boucan* that the Spanish derisively applied the native word to them.

“As Tortuga lay directly in the path of European vessels bound for Mexican ports, the fifteen Frenchmen immediately built up a thriving business in *boucanned* beef. Doubloons, pieces-of-eight, and moidores became to them as shells or seabans to the Spanish fishermen. Word went back apace to St. Christopher, throwing that island into such an uproar that the craze to go *a-boucanning* carried its most unruly seamen to the Tortoise.

“Frenchmen came down upon the islet like a swarm of mosquitoes, and overran it before the simple Spanish folks could recover from their astonishment. Ominous growlings were heard among the original settlers, but for such trivial matters as round Spanish oaths the intruders cared never a whit. Just before dawn, December 1, 1633, the Spanish islanders met at the plaza of their little town, and descended headlong upon the intruders at the *boucanning* beaches. Then began a massacre, during which the intruders were cut down wherever found.

“Immediately after this the *boucanning* foreigners formed themselves into a band composed of a collection of couples. Each two hunters made common property of all possessions of either. They bound themselves by every oath to an imperishable brotherhood. Each swore to avenge with death any insult offered to the other. The two hunted and lived together by day, slept together by night, and were as one flesh; and always as the band ranged the coast valleys, grew the purpose of avenging the Tortuga massacre.

“A few months later the Frenchmen took the islanders by surprise. A carnival of butchery ensued. When it was completed the village was burned. The most lawless of the murderers was one Pierre Le Gros, a sailor of oxlike frame and weight, hailing originally from Dieppe, who, with twenty-seven fellow spirits, stole a small sloop from a Tortugan skipper, and started on a nautical foray on whatsoever Spanish merchantmen fate might cast in his course.

“The act was of sufficient gravity to daunt even the chosen crew of cutthroats captained by Pierre, had the proposed prey been anything but Spanish, since it was plain piracy. For two days the sloop ran on before a northerly wind, swinging down into the Caribbean Sea, but sighting no craft. On the third afternoon out Pierre spied a galleon, one of the Panama pearl fleet, which had been separated from its sister vessels in a recent hurricane. Until night shut down, he craftily kept away toward the

windward horizon. Then, under cover of the darkness, he swiftly and silently approached, coming alongside at daybreak. The entire twenty-eight buccaneers boarded the galleon, leaving their sloop adrift.

“Six men rushed headlong to the gunroom, taking immediate possession. Six more went to the clumsy steering apparatus, while Pierre, with the remaining fifteen, hove the morning watch overboard and made for the cabin. On bursting into the captain’s room, Pierre found the worthy Don playing at cards with his officers, and discussing a goodly measure of Madeira.

“Before the captain could speak, the pirates swarmed into the apartment, and covered the group with their pistols. In less than three minutes the prize was theirs. The crew were marooned, and the galleon taken to France, where, she and her cargo quickly disposed of, the buccaneers left with all speed to rendezvous at the Tortuga.

“When the intelligence of this exploit reached the Tortoise, the entire island was thrown into a hubbub. Nothing was thought of but to go buccaneering for galleons. Brig after brig and ship after ship were fitted out, and in a year this species of piracy became a recognized business. Ten years later the Spanish commerce in these waters had been almost entirely destroyed. The sea was forsaken for the richer prizes on land. The rich capital of Campeche was sacked, to be, in turn, followed by Panama, and the curers of beef had become such a power as to attract the attention of every nation.”

“Is that all?” Gil asked, as Nelse ceased reading.

“Every word, and it isn’t such a bad sort of story, except that there’s not more than half enough. I wonder why your father has been keeping it in the chest?”

“I don’t believe he knew it was here. But look at the rest of this stuff! Do you suppose these have anything to do with the piece of newspaper?”

As he spoke, Gil picked up the other articles, and he and Nelse were gazing at them in perplexity when Captain Mansfield entered the attic.

---



## CHAPTER II.

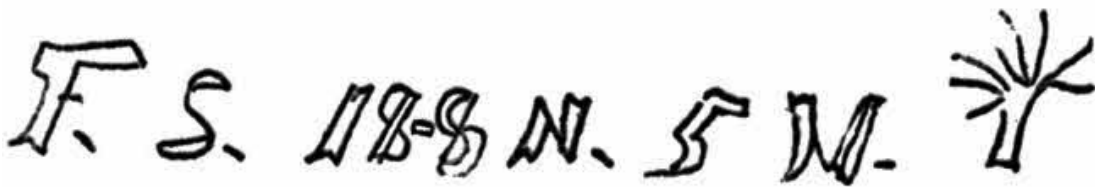
### AT SEA.

“Well, what are you boys hunting for? Pirates’ gold?” Captain Mansfield asked, with a hearty laugh, as he looked over Gil’s shoulder.

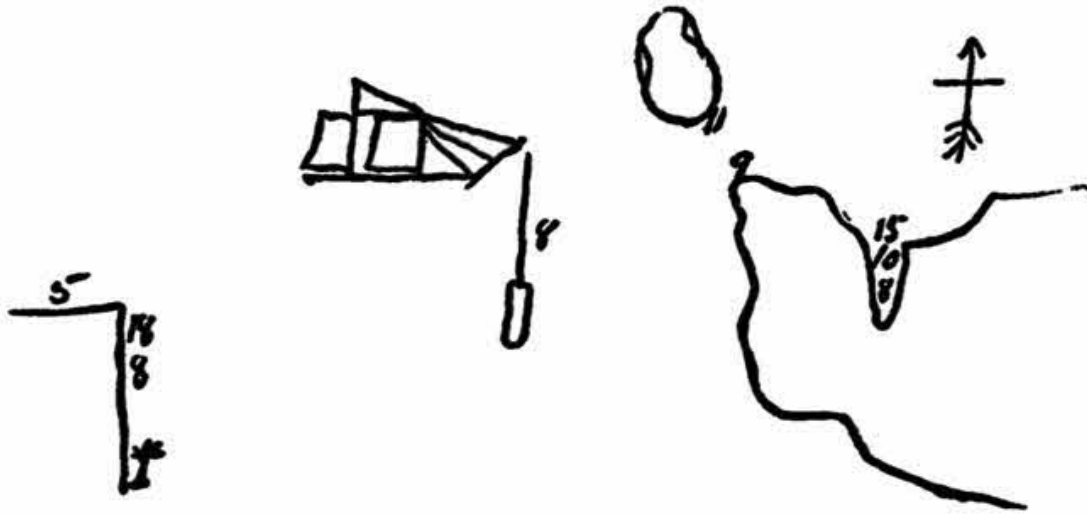
“We came here for this old chest, because our trunks won’t hold all we want to carry, and in it found these things, which I don’t suppose amount to anything; but I can’t make out why you or any one else would want to keep them.”

As he spoke, Gil laid on the lid of the box the different, apparently useless, articles which had fallen out when the hasp was broken. They all had that peculiar musty, salty odor, which tells of months spent in the forecastle, while the good ship plows her way across this or that ocean, one day aided by favoring winds, and on the next battling for life with the spirit of the tempest.

First the newspaper story was placed before Captain Mansfield; then a small coil of thin, well-waxed cord; then a piece of hard, dark-colored wood about four inches long by two wide, with the following marks rudely cut, as if with a sheathknife:



A fragment of an old British admiralty chart, showing a portion of the northwestern end of the Island of Hayti, was next examined, and then Gil unfolded a rough drawing, of which the sketch below is an exact copy:



“Do you know where these things came from?” Gil asked, after his father had gazed at the odd collection for several moments in silence.

“I never saw them before.”

“Wasn’t this your chest?”

Captain Mansfield examined the outside of the box intently, apparently more interested in the find than the boys, and then said, slowly:

“It belonged to an old sailor whom I found in Hong Kong many years ago. He was in the last stages of consumption, and begged me to bring him to this country. I advised him to remain in the hospital, for it seemed certain he would die at sea; but he persisted, and on the fortieth day out we were obliged to give him a sailor’s burial. The night he died we were doing our best to save the ship, she having been partially dismasted in a typhoon, and when he asked for me, I was needed on deck. He sent word by one of the men that I was to keep his chest, which I did, although it seemed nothing more than a dying man’s whim. It was probably brought here with my dunnage, and I have never thought of it since. Now I can fancy what sort of a yarn he wanted to tell me.”

“Do you suppose these things refer to buried treasure?” Nelse asked, excitedly, remembering what had been read.

“He probably thought he knew where some of the buccaneers had hidden their booty. Take ten old sailors together, and it is safe to say that five of them believe they can find gold which has been hidden by pirates.”

“Is what we read in the newspaper true?” Gil asked.

“There can be no question about it. There have been several reliable histories of these sea robbers written, and by looking in an encyclopædia you will learn how fragmentary this article is. New Segovia, in Honduras, was sacked by them. Maracaibo and Gibraltar, in the Gulf of Venezuela, were plundered by the buccaneers under the command of D’Ollonois. Morgan, with two thousand men, crossed the Isthmus to lay siege to Panama, and destroyed it. Coxon ravaged the coast of Peru, and I might go on telling of their crimes until next week without finishing the story. All this doesn’t prove, however, that your find contains a clew to buried gold.”

“But why not try to learn if these things really amount to anything?” Gil suggested, eagerly. “You have said you didn’t care where we went, and this would give us a purpose.”

“Yes, and one involving no end of hard work; but if you boys want to make the venture, and can decide where this particular spot is located, I’ll head the *Day Dream* for the place, and give you a chance.”

Nelse and Gil began to express their gratification; but the latter’s father interrupted them by saying:

“Don’t thank me. Treasure hunting is very different from what you fancy, and one day’s work, under a tropical sun, no matter how promising your clues may be, will result in a most intense desire to leave such jobs to other idiots. It is time now to get your traps on board, for the storm gives promise of clearing away, with a favoring wind, and the *Day Dream* will be under way before sunrise.”

Then Captain Mansfield left them, and the boys set about obeying his orders by first wrapping the supposed guides to a large amount of wealth carefully in brown paper, after which the remainder of the work was quickly accomplished, for their minds were so filled by belief in their ability to unearth a pirate’s hoard, that many things were left behind, which, under less exciting circumstances, would have been thought absolutely indispensable.

An hour later the two were sitting in a snug corner of the yacht’s kitchen, talking with the old darky who was “de captin ob dis yere place,” and who rejoiced in the name of Andrew Jackson Washington Storts.

“De skipper am pow’ful fond ob loafin’ ’roun’ in de schooner,” Andy said, by way of opening the conversation.

“But this time it’s to be a regular cruise,” Gil replied. “We’re going for gold, and, unless a regular hurricane strikes us, there’ll be no shortening of sail until we make a harbor on the coast of Hayti.”

“Wha—wha—wha’s dat?” Andy asked, in mingled surprise and alarm, and turned suddenly to face the boy.

“It’s nothing to be frightened about; we’re only going to Hayti.”

“After pirates’ gold?”

“We shall make a try for it, although father don’t think the venture will be success——”

“Don’ do it, honey, don’ do it. Yo’ neber was dar, an’ yer ain’ got any call fur to go.”

“You’ll think we’ve had a call when you see what was found in the chest of a sailor who died aboard uncle’s ship,” Nelse said, laughingly.

“You’s gwine kase ob wha’ a dead man tole yer?” and now Andy exhibited every sign of fear.

“Of course a dead man couldn’t tell us anything,” Gil replied, impatiently. “We don’t believe in ghosts.”

“But yer will, honey, ef dis yere craft anchors anywhere ’roun’ Hayti near the gold wha’s got blood on it.”

“So you’ve heard about treasure being buried there?” Nelse cried, excitedly.

“I’s done more’n hear ’bout it, chile. Ef I should go fur to tell yer all I’s seen, de berry hair would tumble away frum yer head.”

“Tell us about it, and we’ll risk our hair,” Gil said, coaxingly.

“Yer doesn’t know wha’ you’s askin’, chile. I’d done gone die dead ef I should splain half I’s seen in dat hole ob de debble. Does yer hab any idee who’s libbin’ dere?”

“The natives of the island, I suppose.”

“Jes’ listen to me, chillun, an’ den go ashore same’s I’s gwine fur to do ef de captain ’sists on headin’ dis yere schooner to dat place. Dere’s voodooos ’roun’ de coast,” and the old man looked over his shoulder, as he spoke, as if believing some horrible punishment would be meted out to him for so much as mentioning the dreaded name.

“What are they?” Nelse asked, surprised at the exhibition of fear.

Andy looked at the questioner as if in pity because of the ignorance displayed, and after a short, impressive pause, replied, solemnly:

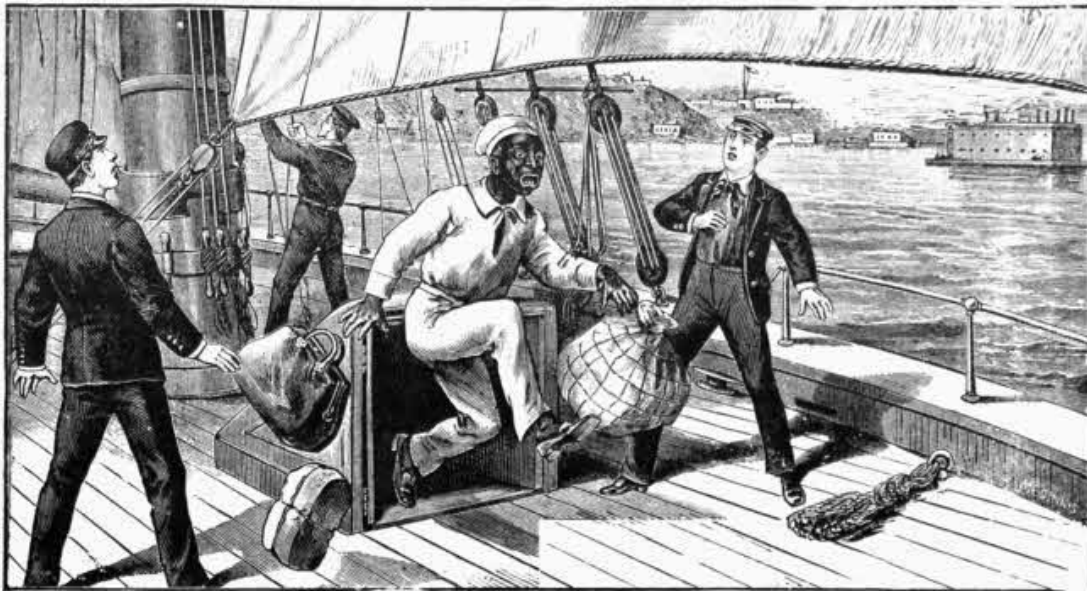
“Ef yer doesn’ know, honey, Andy Storts ain’ de one wha’s gwine fur to put yer in any trubble. Dem as goes to dat ar place ain’ nebber gwine ter cum back, an’ yer better foller me ashore, kase I don’ hanker arter bein’ dead.”

As he spoke, the old darky began gathering up such of his belongings as were in the galley, literally trembling with fear meanwhile, and the boys regarded each other in silent amazement until the trampling of feet overhead caused Gil to dart up the narrow companionway.

An instant later he shouted:

“Come here, Nelse! The storm has cleared off, and we are under way.”

An exclamation of dismay burst from Andy’s lips, and, dropping the articles from his arms, [he rushed to the deck](#).



“Andy rushed to the deck.” [See page 18.](#)

The *Day Dream* was already several miles from her anchorage, sending the spray up from her glistening cut-water as she glided swiftly, with every inch of canvas drawing, toward the sea.

The exhilaration of the sail caused the boys to forget Andy and his fears temporarily, and they watched the graceful craft threading her way in and out among the many vessels and steamers, now apparently about to be run down by some iron monster, and again threatening a saucy tug with a blow of her fore foot.

Captain Mansfield was standing near the helmsman, watching over the safety of his yacht, when the old darky approached him in the highest state of excitement.

“I’s done gone altered up my mind, captin, an’ carn’ go on dis yere cruise,” Andy cried, forgetting, in his terror, that he had no right to speak to the master of the schooner under such circumstances.

“Hold your tongue and go back to the galley! I’ll listen to you when we are outside.”

“I’s gwine ter be set ashore, sah.”

“You’re going to be thrown overboard, if you don’t stop that noise and get away from here,” was the stern reply, and, fearing present danger rather than that in the future, the steward beat an undignified retreat, but at the same time firmly resolved he would not allow himself to be carried to sea in the *Day Dream*.

Gil and Nelse had heard the short conversation; but there were so many things to occupy their attention, that they dismissed it for the time being, as something too trivial to require a second thought.

And each moment the *Day Dream* was drawing nearer and nearer to the entrance of the harbor. The wind was favoring, and Captain Mansfield, true to the instincts which had animated him while in command of a ship, thought only of showing his celerity in leaving port.

Down through the narrows the little craft speeded, leaving behind a wake of silver to show her course, and from there to the lower bay, still holding the wind at its best drawing point, until she was finally bowing and courtesying to the long swell of the Atlantic, while in the galley old Andy remained on

his bended knees, praying that stress of weather might force her into some port before reaching Hayti, at which he could make his escape from the terrible dangers which he firmly believed threatened all who should attempt to recover the buried treasure which had been gained only by the shedding of blood.

---

## CHAPTER III.

### A MESSAGE.

It is not to be supposed that the boys escaped a severe attack of seasickness when the *Day Dream* was tossing about on the Atlantic swell.

Both had indulged in a certain amount of yachting in the river and sound; but the violent leaps and plunges of the schooner were something so entirely different from what they had been accustomed to, that all power of resistance was lost immediately giddiness and nausea seized their victims.

Therefore it was that the first two days out were not particularly enjoyed by the boys; but, at the expiration of that time, even the suggestion of fried salt pork failed to disturb them, and once more they were in a condition to speculate upon the possibility of finding a buried treasure.

That old Andy had not succeeded in going ashore they knew, because of having seen him several times; but his fears had not been allayed, as could be told by the expression on his face. He had the appearance of one who fancies he is menaced by a sudden and immediate danger, and glanced from time to time over his shoulder, looking, as Nelse expressed it, "as if he believed half-a-dozen pirates were trying to sneak up on him."

Half-an-hour after their first appearance on deck since the yacht left Sandy Hook, the boys paid the cook a visit, and hardly were they inside the galley when he broached the subject uppermost in his mind by asking:

"Has you'se done gone tole de captin 'bout wha's gwine ter happen ef dis yere schooner fools 'roun' de shore ob Hayti?"

"We haven't done much of anything else than attend to our stomachs for the last two days, Andy," Gil replied, with a laugh. "Why don't you speak to him about it?"

"I'se had ernough ob dat kin' ob work. De night we done lef' port I tole him as how dis nigger wouldn't stay aboard, an' by jes' de po'est kin' ob luck dere was a rope's end handy fur him to grab."

Andy rubbed his back, thus preventing any necessity for further disclosures, and the boys laughed heartily, thereby causing the old man to lose his



temper.

“Dere ain’ no fun in dem tings, an’ de captin’s gwine ter fin’ out de se’rus side ob life ef he keeps dis yere craf’ headed like she am now.”

“It’s foolish for you to trouble your head about what we may find in Hayti,” Nelse replied, earnestly, “for even in case we should touch at the very spot where these voodooos hang out, you needn’t go ashore.”

“Dey kin cum at yer anywhere,” Andy said, with an ominous shake of the head, and then he turned so suddenly, in order to look over his shoulder, lest the phantoms of the pirates should be pursuing him, that he nearly toppled headlong.

As a matter of course, the boys enjoyed this hugely, and their mirth only served to kindle his wrath anew.

He closed his thick lips tightly, as if to say he would not allow himself to be coaxed into speaking again, and Gil was on the point of trying to soothe him, when a shout from above caused him to remain silent.

“The captain says the boys are to come on deck and see what we have picked up.”

Gil and Nelse obeyed hurriedly, and were not a little surprised at seeing nothing more than a dead bird lying on the main hatch.

“Did you shoot it?” Gil cried, in surprise, wondering how it happened that they had not heard the report of firearms.

“It was dead, floating, and we picked it up,” Captain Mansfield replied.

“What for?”

“I saw something red had been tied under the poor thing’s wing, and wanted to find out what it meant. By doing so, we shall be able to rescue several unfortunate men from considerable suffering, if not death.”

“What do you mean?” Gil asked, in astonishment, and in reply his father held up a small piece of brown paper.

“This was what we found wrapped in a tarred cloth, with a bit of red flannel to attract attention. The cord was a piece of gut, which has swelled until the messenger choked to death.”

Gil took the paper almost reverentially, and, as Nelse looked over his shoulder, read the following:

Shipwrecked men on Walker Key at the northern slope of Little Bahama Banks, dying from thirst.

This message from the sea, brought by a bird, and discovered only by the merest chance, caused the boys the most intense astonishment, and Gil asked, breathlessly:

“Do you believe it can be true, father?”

“People do not do such things for sport. It must have cost them considerable labor and ingenuity to catch this gull, and if they are yet alive, we’ll soon relieve their sufferings.”

“Are you heading for there now?”

“Yes, and it is very nearly a true course for us. We had only to shift the helm a couple of points.”

“When shall we arrive?”

“To-morrow noon, if this wind holds. Go into the cabin, and by looking at the chart which is spread out on the table, you will learn exactly where the sufferers were when this gull was set free.”

The boys went below, after looking once more at the bird which had performed its mission, even in death, and then it was not difficult to ascertain very nearly the position of the schooner, for the course had been traced in pencil on the chart up to that morning.

“We can’t be delayed very long,” Gil said, after they had gratified their curiosity, “for if the men are yet alive they’ll be ready to leave the key at a moment’s notice; but I suppose it will be necessary to put them ashore somewhere before we go to Hayti.”

“You are talking as if we knew exactly where to find the place marked out on the paper we found.”

“Well, don’t we?”

“I wouldn’t like to say that I do.”

“It doesn’t seem as if there could be any question about it. The piece of newspaper referred to what had taken place on the Tortuga de Mar, and the fragment of chart showed that island——”

“Yes, and a portion of Hayti as well.”

“But the drawing represents a small body of land.”

“Look at it again, and you’ll see that only a part has been shown. How do you know it does not represent the end of some other key?”

“The newspaper shows that.”

“I don’t think so,” Nelse replied, firmly. “What we read was the story of how buccaneering first came about, and, of course, it was necessary to speak of the small key where it had its birth.”

“If that was its only use, why did the owner of the things we found keep it so carefully?”

“Probably to show his shipmates that at least a portion of his story was true.”

Until this moment Gil had had but little time to speculate upon the supposed treasure, owing to the fact of his having been taken sick so soon after the discovery in the attic was made, and now a very unpleasant doubt came into his mind.

It no longer seemed such an easy matter to find the place designated, and he began to fear the treasure hunting would be brought to an end before it had really commenced.

“I shall believe the Tortuga de Mar is the place until we have searched over it pretty well,” Gil said, after a long pause. “Then, if nothing is found, we’ll say the drawing must refer to some spot on the island of Hayti.”

“But what about the voodooos which are causing Andy so much alarm?”

“What’s that?” a voice asked from the companionway, and an instant later Captain Mansfield was in the cabin. “Where did you boys ever hear anything about voodooos?”

“Andy says they’ll kill us if we attempt so much as to anchor near where any pirate hoard is supposed to be hidden,” Gil replied, with a laugh.

“So that is why he insists on being put ashore?” the captain said, half to himself.

“Is there any real reason why he should be afraid?” Nelse asked.

“Certainly not. It is true that there are a large number of negroes, more especially in Hayti, who believe in that sort of mummary; but you can hunt for the treasure just as long as you please without fear of being molested by any of them.”

“And you are willing we should make the attempt?”

“Dig away as much as you please; but I fancy a couple of days’ work will give you all the searching that’s needed.”

“Will you help us find the spot as shown by the drawing?”

“I’ll spend a short time at it, providing we have safe anchorage for the schooner.”

This was even more than Gil had dared to hope, and his spirits revived wonderfully.

“Then we shan’t have any trouble in bringing away a lot of gold,” he cried, and from that moment until it was time to retire, save when they were eating, he and Nelse studied the tracing on the piece of brown paper.

When the boys “turned in,” the wind was blowing steadily from the same quarter as when the message from the shipwrecked ones was received, and there appeared to be no doubt but that the *Day Dream* would make the key at the time set by Captain Mansfield.

Even the idea of the treasure did not prevent the boys from thinking very much of the sufferers, whom they hoped to be able to relieve, and on awakening next morning, the first question was as to whether the necessary rate of speed had been maintained.

“We’ll be there on time,” Captain Mansfield replied, cheerily. “Before twelve o’clock we shall have performed a good deed at the expense of but little trouble, or have the satisfaction of knowing we did all that was possible, under the circumstances.”

Old Andy seemed to have resolved that he would find cause for fear in everything which happened.

“We’s gwine straight to de debble,” he grumbled, when the boys spoke with him about the shipwrecked men. “Dere’s no use ter try an make me tink a bird knowed enuf after he was dead, to float alongside dis yere schooner so’s we could get de writin’, kase it don’ stan’ to reason.”

“That part of it was chance, of course,” Gil replied, “and I can’t see that there is anything strange in the men doing all they could to attract attention.”

“Wha’ men?”

“Those who have been shipwrecked.”

“Dere’s sumfin wrong ’bout de whole bizness, kase where’s de sailor man what kin ketch a gull? I’s tellin’ you, honey, dat de voodooos hab foun’ out whar we was gwine, an’ am beginnin’ to——”

He did not have an opportunity to finish the sentence, for at this point the boys literally roared with laughter, and he turned away indignantly, refusing to speak again until some one from the deck shouted:

“The key is in sight. If you boys want to get the first glimpse of the shipwrecked sailors, it is time you were tumbling up here.”

---

## CHAPTER IV.

### THE CASTAWAYS.

Gil and Nelse, who had expected to see an island of fair proportions, were considerably disappointed on reaching the deck at the scene before them.

A long, low stretch of sand, hardly rising above the level of the ocean, could be distinguished directly ahead, and was about as uninviting a place as one could find. Toward the eastward the surf broke with considerable violence, and this it was, rather than the key itself, which attracted attention to the spot.

Already preparations were being made to lower one of the boats, and Gil asked his father:

“How near can we go to land?”

“It isn’t safe to venture very far across. It is all shoal water to the westward of us, and I shall hold the schooner off about a mile.”

“Do you see any signs of them?”

“The smoke is enough to show they’re keeping a pretty sharp lookout,” and Captain Mansfield pointed to a thin thread of blue, which had been unnoticed by the boys until this moment. “That is a signal which they started the moment we hove in sight; but it’s dying down, now we’ve shown our intention of running toward them.”

Ten minutes later the boys could distinguish, by aid of the glass, a number of figures on the beach, and Nelse said, with a laugh:

“Andy will be more certain than ever that the voodooos have had a hand in this business when he finds out how many extra men he is obliged to cook for. It looks to me as if there were at least a dozen.”

“Fully as many as that,” Captain Mansfield added, “and we shall be crowded uncomfortably for a while; but, fortunately, Nassau isn’t so far away that we need worry very much about lack of room.”

At this moment the old darkey came on deck, and Gil shouted:

“There’s a whole crowd of them! The voodooos have sent us lots of company.”

Andy looked from the captain to the key in a sort of bewilderment, and one of the sailors, who stood near him, said:

“You’ll have your hands full now, cookee, for we’re likely to add twelve or fifteen to this schooner’s crew.” Andy raised his arms above his head, as if in despair, and then turning suddenly, ran below to the galley, from which place he did not emerge again until it was time to serve dinner.

The schooner was hove to, when it seemed to the boys as if she was a very long distance to the eastward of the key; but, as a matter of fact, she was on the edge of the bank, and as near in shore as it was safe to venture.

One of the small boats was lowered, and two sailors rowed toward the shore.

The mate of the yacht—Job Jenkins, a young man not more than twenty-five years of age—was leaning over the rail near where Gil and Nelse stood, and after watching the men as they pulled the tender around to the western shore of the key, to avoid the heavy breakers, he said, petulantly:

“I ain’t a-sayin’ but what it’s our duty to take that crowd off; yet it’s bound to use up the rest of this day, and by sunset there won’t be so much as a breath of air stirring.”

“Better a calm than a hurricane,” Gil replied, with a smile.

“I’m not so sure of that. The yacht can hold her own under considerably more than a capful of wind, and I had rather see her driving through the worst kind of a smother than lying here with that mob on board.”

“Mr. Jenkins, can you make out any wreckage hereabouts?” Captain Mansfield asked, lowering the glass which he had been using.

“No, sir, and that is just what has been puzzling me. I don’t understand how so many could have reached the key without some kind of a craft, and if any vessel large enough to carry such a crew had gone ashore within the past three weeks, the hull should be held by the sand.”

“It has an odd look,” the captain replied, as he walked farther aft to get a view from another point.

By this time the tender had gained the shore, and the shipwrecked party, after quarreling among themselves, made a rush for the boat.

“At least four trips will be necessary in order to get them all on board,” Jenkins suggested, and Captain Mansfield replied:

“Unless they are in a bad condition, which doesn’t appear to be the case, let them do a portion of the work. One man is enough to take the boat back, and the strangers can pull out to us.”

Gil and Nelse watched eagerly as the first load approached the yacht, and a scrutiny of the newcomers was not at all favorable to them as good specimens of sailors.

They were a thoroughly disreputable-looking set, bearing no evidences of hardship, and the boys fancied all were more or less under the influence of liquor.

“Well,” Captain Mansfield said, as the first one, a bushy-whiskered man, who appeared to be the leader, came over the rail; “you don’t seem to be in as desperate straits as I fancied would be the case when I found the gull.”

“So you got the writin’, eh?” the man replied, with a laugh. “I thought Johnson was wastin’ his time when he laid ’round a couple of days tryin’ to catch the bird; but it has turned out mighty lucky for us, after all.”

“[What vessel are you from?](#)”





**“What vessel are you from?” [See page 32.](#)**

“The brig *Mary and Jane*, from Savannah for Nassau, with an assorted cargo. There must have been a fire in the hold when we left port, for we fought it from the second day out until it got the best of us, and we had to leave the old hooker.”

“Were you the captain?”

“Not much. He and the mates took the only boat that would swim, and left us to shirk for ourselves.”

“Do you mean to say that they deserted the crew?” Captain Mansfield asked, watching the man sharply:

“That’s jest the size of it. My mates and I made shift to get to the key, an’ there we’ve been ever since.”

It was some seconds before Gil’s father spoke again, and the sailor shuffled about uneasily under his searching gaze.

“You said you were without water.”

“We haven’t had a drop since we landed; but a couple of casks of rum come ashore, an’ we’ve managed to get along with that.”

“Did you scuttle the brig before leaving her?”

“There was no chance to do anything of the kind. We kept her headed for the key till the fire got the best of us, and she was in a light blaze when we saw her last.”

“How many are there of you?”

“Fourteen all told.”

“It’ll be snug stowing; but we’ll run for Nassau, and land you as soon as possible,” and Captain Mansfield turned as if to intimate that the interview was at an end.

“You’ll have to take deck passage, for there are only four bunks in the forecastle, and they are all filled,” Mr. Jenkins said, as he motioned the men forward.

“All right. Of course, we’re willin’ to stand our share of the work,” the man replied, as he slouched along the deck with a swaggering air.

“We’ve got crew enough, and in a small craft like this, you would only be in the way.”

Then the mate gave orders that the sailors should return with the boat, and the little craft was headed for the shore once more, while the newcomers covertly examined the yacht, as if they had a personal interest in her sea-going qualities.

The captain appeared to be so disturbed in mind that neither Gil nor Nelse ventured to ask him any questions relative to the men whom he was taking off the key; the boys stood amidships, where they could see all that was going on, and as Captain Mansfield paced to and fro, only stopping now and then to exchange a few words with Mr. Jenkins, Nelse whispered:

“I don’t think your father is any too well pleased at having so many people aboard.”

“I’m certain he isn’t, and can’t wonder at it. They are a tough-looking set, and could make no end of trouble, if they were so disposed.”

By this time the second load had come from the key, and were no more prepossessing in appearance than the first arrivals.

Captain Mansfield questioned them sharply, receiving in substance the same replies as from the others, and when the boat was headed for the shore again, he called Mr. Jenkins to him.

Eager to know what was said, Gil motioned Nelse to follow him, and the two went aft where the conversation could be overheard.

“What do you think of the story they tell?” Captain Mansfield asked his mate.

“It isn’t reasonable, and I believe it has been cooked up for our especial benefit. That all the officers of a brig should abandon the crew doesn’t sound reasonable.”

“I am of the same opinion. They have either deserted from their vessel, or mischief has been done.”

“In case it was nothing more than desertion, they would have had a boat.”

“The same argument holds good under other and more desperate circumstances.”

“Very true, sir.”

“We may never learn the truth; but we can take every precaution against trouble. Keep your eyes open, Mr. Jenkins, and don’t give them an opportunity to play us any game.”

“I will see to it that they haven’t much rope aboard this craft,” the mate replied, and then the conversation was interrupted by Andy’s announcement that dinner was ready.

The third boatload had not come off when the boys went into the cabin, and there saw the old darky looking thoroughly distressed.

“What’s the matter?” Gil asked, while they were waiting for his father to come below.

“Say, honey, does you know how many ob dese yere sailors am comin’ aboard?”

“Fourteen.”

“An’ am all ob dem gwine ter stay on de yacht?”

“There’s no other place for them until we can make Nassau.”

“Den you hark to wha’ de ole man am tellin’ yer,” and Andy looked cautiously around to make sure no one from the deck could hear him. “Dis yere cruise am boun’ ter end in trubble, an’ ef de captain keeps de yacht pinte for Hayti, we’s nebber gwine ter git back.”

“Is this another case of the voodooos?” Nelse asked, with a laugh.

“Now, don’ make fun ob wha’ de ole man tells yer, honey, an’ ef dere’s a chance to ’swade de captin ter turn ’roun’ when we strikes Nassau, go fur him lively.”

“It isn’t likely father would put the schooner about, simply because of what the voodooos might do, and if we should say anything, it might only make matters worse.”

At this point Captain Mansfield came below, and Andy, looking decidedly distressed, began to serve the meal.



## CHAPTER V.

### MISCHIEF.

Mr. Jenkins' predictions regarding the time necessary to bring the castaways on board, and the weather, were verified.

Not until nearly sunset did the little tender make the last trip to the key, and by that time the calm was "raging." There was not air enough stirring to lift the thread of blue at the truck, and the atmosphere had suddenly grown so hot as to be almost stifling.

If Captain Mansfield had reason to distrust those whom he was trying to aid, during the first interview, he had good proof of their evil natures before the wind sprang up again.

All the castaways were under the influence of liquor to a greater or less degree, and those who came latest must have contrived to bring an additional supply to their companions.

Andy had prepared a substantial meal, which was served on deck, and, instead of being grateful for the same, there was more grumbling than might have been expected from sailors whose only food for many days had been "salt horse."

The bushy-whiskered fellow, who acted as the leader of the party was particularly aggressive, and, when Andy had set out a well-cooked, generous amount of corned beef, potatoes and cabbage—such a spread as they would not have received anywhere, save on a pleasure yacht—he asked, in a surly tone:

"Is this the kind of stuff you're willin' to put afore shipwrecked men?"

"It's de same as our own crew gets, an' I 'lows as how you'se kin make out ef yer berry hungry," the cook replied, angrily, turning to re-enter the galley.

"Don't answer me back, you black villain, or I'll break every bone in your body!" and the man sprang to his feet with a show of rage.

"I'se gwine ter say wha' I wants ter," Andy replied, angrily. "I'se de cook ob dis yere craft, an' ef yer spectin' ter git grub, dere ain' no call fur yippin'."

“Hold your tongue!” the fellow cried, seizing his tin plate of food and hurling it at the old darkey’s head.

Andy dodged the missiles, which, striking the companionway, were scattered over the clean deck, and the infuriated man ran toward him with the evident purpose of inflicting bodily injury.

It so chanced that Captain Mansfield came from the cabin at the same instant the plate was thrown, and, before anything more could be done, he shouted:

“Hold on there! What is the meaning of all this?”

The words were sufficient to cause the man to halt suddenly, and, turning around, he replied, in a sullen, insolent tone:

“I don’t reckon on taking lip from any nigger, no matter who he is.”

The cook was still standing in the companionway, and going forward quickly, the captain asked him what had been said.

The sailor would have given his version of the affair, attempting to prevent the old darky from speaking; but Captain Mansfield said, sternly:

“Hold your tongue, unless you want to be set ashore again, and I’m not certain I should take the trouble of using the boat.”

Andy gave a truthful account of all that had occurred, and concluded by saying, as he pointed to the food on the deck:

“Dere it be, capt’in, de same as I send to de cabin.”

By this time all the alleged shipwrecked men had laid aside their plates to gather around the leader, standing very near the captain in threatening attitudes, and, attracted by the noise, Mr. Jenkins came on deck.

Captain Mansfield looked squarely in the fellow’s face fully half-a-minute before he said:

“There is your supper. You will get no more to-night, and you are either to eat or throw it overboard. In addition, you will clean the deck at once.”

The man stood in an attitude of defiance, glancing now and then at his companions, but making no move toward obeying the orders; and Gil’s father, turning to the mate, said:

“Mr. Jenkins, if my instructions have not been carried out properly at the end of five minutes, throw this man overboard. Call all hands, including the boys, if you need assistance.”

Then the captain walked aft again, and the castaways began whispering among themselves as if trying to decide whether it would be safe to defy him.

Gil and Nelse stood near the wheel, where they could hear and see everything. Both wanted to go forward, but the former's father checked them by saying, in a low tone:

“Remain where you are, unless Mr. Jenkins should call; in which case, you are to obey his orders implicitly.”

The mate was evidently making ready to carry out his instructions. All the men, save the man who had thrown the food, were sent back to the main hatch, and the young sailor was looking at his watch in an ominous manner.

The castaway muttered something which the boys could not understand; made a series of gestures to his companions, but, without receiving any reply, and then in a sulky manner began throwing the food overboard.

“Bring a swab here,” Mr. Jenkins called to one of the crew, and the shipwrecked man used it vigorously until the stains had been removed from the white planks.

“Now, where am I to get my supper?” the fellow asked, sullenly.

“We don't serve two meals at the same time on board this craft, and, in case you want to be carried to Nassau, I advise that you keep a civil tongue in your head, for the captain is no fresh-water sailor, to allow an old barnacle like you to back him down.”

Then the mate walked aft, and the rescued party began to discuss the situation in whispers.

“That's a fine crowd to ask honest sailors for assistance,” Mr. Jenkins said, in a low tone, when he stood by Captain Mansfield's side. “If this calm lasts very long, we are bound to have trouble with them.”

“Keep your weather eye lifting, and they can't do much mischief. They are all a little the worse for liquor now, but when that wears off things will



straighten out.”

“It would be serving the whole boiling lot right to set ’em ashore.”

“That would be inhuman, and, besides, neither you nor I care to say that we’re afraid of a lot of sailors.”

“You would be warranted in trying to avoid trouble, more especially when there are so many aboard.”

“We won’t discuss the matter any further, Mr. Jenkins. Keep them well under your eye, and we’ll soon run down this bank.”

Both Gil and Nelse understood that the captain, as well as his mate, felt a trifle uneasy because of the strangers, who outnumbered the available force of the yacht more than two to one; but forcing them to return to the key was not to be thought of for a single moment, and it only remained for the officers to be on the alert.

Owing to the heat, and, possibly, because of the alleged shipwrecked mariners, the boys found it impossible to close their eyes in slumber at a very early hour on this particular night.

Before retiring, Nelse had proposed that they pay Andy a visit, but Gil objected on the score that it would only be to hear his croaking relative to the visit to Hayti, and, feeling decidedly disturbed in mind because of other reasons, time spent in the galley promised but little pleasure.

When the boys went below, the rescued party were stretched out amidships, more comfortable there than they would have been below, and, so far as could be judged by their respective positions, intent only on seeking repose.

Two hours later, after Gil and Nelse had tossed and turned in their bunks, unable to sleep because of the almost stifling heat, the latter said:

“Let’s go on deck. There’s no chance we shall close our eyes to-night if these mosquitoes continue so industrious, and we may as well be where it is possible to get the benefit of whatever air is stirring.”

“I’m ready to go, but we must move softly, in case father happens to be asleep.”

Because of this caution, the two gained the deck in nearly perfect silence, and the night was so dark that they could not be seen by those who might be

on watch, save from a very short distance.

On the starboard side aft Mr. Jenkins was pacing to and fro, the sound of his footsteps alone disturbing the silence, and from the other side came a subdued murmur, which told that the strangers were yet engaged in conversation.

Without knowing exactly why he did so, [Gil led his cousin forward](#) until it was possible to distinguish what the rescued men were talking about, and then that which he heard was sufficient to attract his closest attention.

The bushy-whiskered fellow appeared to be the chief speaker, and he said, just as the boys drew near:

“There are only five, counting the skipper and mate. The cook and the cubs don’t amount to anything. This yacht is a clipper, and, with her, we could soon find a market for what has been left on the key.”

“Don’t you think we’ve done enough already?” a voice asked.

“Yes, if all hands have turned cowards. We shall not get any deeper in the mud by taking what has come to us, and, with a craft like this, everything is possible. I wouldn’t want a better berth than to sail such a schooner around the keys, stopping whenever we wanted two or three days ashore, and going wherever we took a fancy.”

“You know what that means,” the same voice said.

“Supposin’ I do, haven’t we done the same thing already? We can go ashore at Nassau, and then it may be a good many months before we dare take what we’ve earned. I’m for making the most of a good chance.”

“But how can it be fixed?”

“Come nearer an’ I’ll tell you; there’s no need of yelling when there are so many to hear.”

The doubter moved across the deck, and Gil pressed his companion’s arm in token that they should retire.

“There’s no need of listening to anything more,” Gil said, when they were so near the wheel that there was no danger the words would be overheard. “Those fellows are plotting mutiny, and it is necessary father should know it.”

“Why not speak with Mr. Jenkins?” Nelse whispered.

“Then we would be obliged to repeat the story twice. Come below!”

Nelse followed without further remonstrance, and a few moments later Captain Mansfield had learned sufficient to convince him that his guests were not the most honest people in the world.

“Are you certain no mistake has been made?” he asked, when Gil concluded the narrative.

“We heard everything very distinctly, and I am positive the words have been repeated correctly.”

“Call Mr. Jenkins, but do not let any one hear you,” and Captain Mansfield sprang from his berth as Gil went toward the companion-way.

---

## CHAPTER VI.

### MUTINY.

To find the mate and tell him he was wanted in the cabin did not occupy many moments, and the rescued party, who had turned mutineers almost at the same moment their appeal for help had been answered, apparently paid no attention to the boy's movements.

Captain Mansfield repeated to Mr. Jenkins what Gil told him when the two were alone and the companion-hatch drawn to prevent the possibility of the conversation being overheard, and the expression which came over the mate's face showed how serious he believed was the situation.

"I am not surprised," he said, thoughtfully. "After the row with Andy, we had good reason to look for anything in the way of rascality. What do you propose to do?"

"I hardly know."

"Although my opinion has not been asked, I should say we had better set them ashore as soon as possible."

"To do that we would be precipitating the trouble, and, besides, I hardly see how it can be done. When the first boatload was landed, they might refuse to let the tender be brought back, even in case they left the schooner willingly. It is not going to be an easy matter to enforce obedience while they so far outnumber us. What is the look of the weather?"

"I think we shall have a fair sailing breeze by midnight."

"Then it will be best to make an attempt to land them at Nassau. Arm yourself, and we will both remain on duty. At the first sign of insubordination use your weapons promptly."

It could be seen that Mr. Jenkins was not pleased with this decision, but he was too good a sailor to find fault with the commands of his superior officer.

He entered his cabin, reappeared a moment later with bulging pockets, and went toward the companion-ladder, stopping there only long enough to say:

“You will not be needed on deck, captain. I’ll answer for that crowd until daylight.”

“It can do no harm to take excessive precautions, more especially when they involve nothing more serious than the loss of sleep. If you see the slightest sign of trouble, call me.”

The mate went out into the gloom, and Captain Mansfield said to the boys:

“There is no particular reason why you should be frightened, but, at the same time, it is well to be prepared for any emergency. Keep your revolvers where they can be used at a moment’s notice, but do not make any move toward using them without an express command from me to that effect.”

“Do you think the men will attempt to seize the schooner?” Gil asked, in a tremulous voice.

“Not a bit of it; but yet almost anything is possible, and that is why I want you to be prepared. If we get a good sailing breeze at midnight, we shall be in Nassau before those scoundrels can form a plan.”

Then the captain went on deck to have a look around, and the boys discussed the question of “turning in.”

“I don’t believe it would be possible for me to close my eyes while knowing those men are ready for mischief, and there can be no mistake as to what we heard,” Nelse said, in a whisper. “Why can’t we sit here in the cabin all night?”

“Father wouldn’t like it, and, besides, if that crowd should see us, they would know we had discovered their secret.”

“Do you intend to lie down?”

“Yes; but there is no necessity of undressing, and, in case anything does happen, we shall be ready to do our share.”

Nelse would have preferred to remain on deck, but he knew Captain Mansfield would not agree to such a plan, therefore he followed his cousin to the tiny room which adjoined the one occupied by Gil’s father.

However uneasy they might be regarding the intention of the alleged shipwrecked crew, it was impossible to remain awake very long after lying down, and in less than half-an-hour the two were sleeping soundly.

They were still in the very heart of slumber-land at midnight, when the looked-for breeze sprang up, and, therefore, remained in ignorance of the fact that the dainty white cloths of the yacht had been spread, causing the beautiful little craft to heel coquettishly, as, with a bone in her teeth, she darted over the black waters on a true course for the Northeast Providence Channel.

“She is looking up into it well now,” Captain Mansfield said, in a tone of satisfaction, as the *Day Dream* glided across the waves, “and we can count on getting rid of our passengers before another sun sets, for I believe this wind will continue to freshen until morning, when we shall have all she needs to induce her to show her best pace.”

The captain and his mate were standing well aft, with a trusty man at the wheel, as the schooner gained headway, and Mr. Jenkins replied, in a tone of relief:

“If your predictions are correct, sir, there’ll be little to fear, for as yet this crowd are without any plan of action. Why don’t you go below for a while?”

“I believe I will. Keep your wits about you, and don’t hesitate to call me if anything looks wrong.”

As he spoke, the captain went to his room, and in a comparatively short space of time the sound of his heavy breathing could be heard, even by the man at the wheel.

The mate paced to and fro more than an hour, and then, fancying he heard a movement among the men, who were supposed to be sleeping on deck, he went forward to investigate.

The rescued party appeared to be wrapped in slumber, as he made his way among the prostrate forms, and, blaming himself for being unduly suspicious, Mr. Jenkins continued on to the fore-castle companion-way before turning to retrace his steps.

The sailor who should have been on the lookout was nowhere to be seen, and the mate stood for a moment expecting him to come from below, when suddenly a hand was clapped over his mouth, preventing him from uttering the slightest sound.

At the same instant he was lifted bodily from his feet and carried to the main hatch, where the mutineers had no difficulty in binding and gagging him without any more noise than might have been caused by one of the men turning in his sleep.

Now that it was too late, Jenkins saw the missing sailor lying close beside him, unable to move hand or foot, and he understood that the castaways had formed a very well-considered plan, which was already more than half successful.

“It’s time now to tackle that fellow at the wheel,” the leader of the party whispered. “I’ll lounge back there; he’ll think I’m the mate until it is too late to make any disturbance, and the minute I get him by the mouth you must close in.”

“Why not call up the captain first?” one of the crowd asked.

“Because then we should have two on hand at the same time, and there’s no knowing what them boys might succeed in doing. The easiest plan is the best, and so far you’ve got no call to kick at the way I’ve managed this business.”

“Go ahead; I won’t say another word until the schooner is in our possession.”

Mr. Jenkins struggled hard to make some noise, which would serve to alarm the man at the wheel, but his bonds and the gag had been tied too skillfully to admit of the slightest movement, and he was forced to remain inactive while the mutineers carried out their vile plot to the end.

In less than five minutes the helmsman was also a prisoner, and one of the scoundrels took his station at the wheel, but careful not to change the yacht’s course, in case the captain should chance to be awake watching the tell-tale.

Ten minutes later the leader of the mutineers, after ordering his men to creep aft, where they would be hidden from view by the deckhouse, entered the cabin and knocked lightly on the owner’s door.

“What is the matter?” the captain asked, awakening at the first sound.

“Mr. Jenkins wants to know if you will come on deck for a moment, sir,” was the whispered reply. “The wind is freshening, and he would like to haul

around more to the westward.”

Without waiting for an answer, the fellow went on deck; but he stood close by the companion-way, after whispering to the man at the wheel:

“Have that belaying-pin ready to knock him down, if he doesn’t give me a fair chance of cutting off his wind.”

Then the sound of footsteps told that the captain had left his room, and twenty seconds later he appeared at the top of the ladder.

Coming suddenly into the darkness as he had, and unsuspecting that the summons was a false one, the work of making him a prisoner was exceedingly simple.

Struggle as he might, nothing could be effected, for half-a-dozen of the scoundrels were upon him instantly the leader made the first move, and now there was no longer any necessity of preserving such perfect silence.

“Three of you tackle the cook, and when that has been done, I’ll attend to the cubs,” the leader said, in an ordinary tone, while Captain Mansfield was being carried to the hatch and laid beside the mate and sailors.

“It’s all done, and the nigger is lashed in his berth,” one of the men reported before the prisoners thought sufficient time had elapsed for the villains to reach the fore-castle.

“Did he give you any trouble?”

“Not a bit, but acted as if he expected something of the kind. How long will it take you to fix the boys?”

“That part of it doesn’t amount to anything. Bring some rope down, and I’ll end this business mighty quick.”

Nelse and Gil were sleeping soundly when the mutineers opened the unlocked door. Beside them were the revolvers, and these the ringleader took possession of, as he said to his followers:

“Now truss ’em up; but there’s no need of using the gags, for they can’t do any harm, no matter how loud they yell.”

The first intimation the boys had that anything out of the usual course had happened was when the men began roughly to tie their hands and feet, and



then only a single glance was necessary to tell exactly what had been accomplished.

“Turn them out on deck, and we’ll make ourselves comfortable here for a while before doing the rest of the work,” the leader said, and, as if they had been so many bundles of merchandise, Gil and Nelse were conveyed to the main hatch, there to be flung roughly down.

From this time until fully an hour had passed the mutineers paid no attention to their prisoners. Two men were all that were needed on deck, and the others proceeded to make free with the cabin stores, as could be told by the sounds of revelry.

With sufficient wind to keep the canvas full and drawing, the little yacht sped on over the long swells, while her rightful crew could not so much as enjoy the poor consolation of conversation.

---

## CHAPTER VII.

### SET ADRIFT.

The orgie in the cabin was continued until nearly daylight, and during all that long, weary time the boys could talk to, but not with, their companions.

They were the only ones who had been left ungagged, and were free to discuss the matter, but without being able to elicit a single answer.

“It isn’t hard to fancy how the whole thing has occurred,” Gil said to Nelse; “but the question is, what do they propose to do with us?”

“We shall find out mighty soon, I reckon, and the part which has the most interest for us is whether they will cut our throats or content themselves with simply making us walk a plank, after the fashion of oldtime pirates. I counted on finding the buccaneers’ treasure when we started, but I didn’t suppose we should find the buccaneers themselves.”

While the boys indulged in this rather mournful style of conversation, the other prisoners writhed to and fro in the vain effort to slip their bonds, and at each useless attempt Gil would look around, wondering if it were not possible to aid them in some way.

“Because we can speak, it seems as if we should be able to do something,” he said, after his father had literally exhausted his strength trying to get his hands free. “I’ve read in stories of fellows who could chew ropes apart, but I don’t know how to set about it.”

“That’s because such a thing isn’t possible,” Nelse replied, very decidedly. “We can’t so much as move, and, as for getting our heads where it would be possible to bite at the bonds, it is simply out of the question. After this I shall never believe in those yarns.”

“It might be done, if I could raise myself sufficiently to get at the ropes.”

“That is a great, big ‘if’ under these circumstances, and I shall put all those stories down as foolish lies after this night.”

It was as if the desire to aid tired the boys, for before this conversation had been continued half-an-hour both were perspiring profusely, while they felt

weary, although having remained inactive.

It was a relief for all hands when the golden shafts of light which came over the water proclaimed the rising of the sun, and the revelers emerged from the cabin to complete their act of piracy.

The leader lost no time in acquainting his prisoners with the fate in store for them.

Coming toward the hatch with unsteady movements, which told only too well how his time had been occupied, he first ordered that the gags should be removed, and then said to Captain Mansfield:

“I ’low it seems kinder rough for us to turn you out, but that’s what we’ve decided to do, an’ there’s no use in kickin’ up rusty about it.”

“Do you mean that we’re to be set adrift after doing all we could to relieve your distress?” the captain asked, huskily, for the gag had been in his mouth so long that it was difficult to speak with sufficient distinctness to make himself understood.

“That’s about the size of it,” the man replied, with a drunken leer. “There’s jest a chance we might get into trouble at Nassau, because the *Mary and Jane* was lost——”

“Then you are responsible for the destruction of that craft, eh?”

“Hold your tongue, or you may be askin’ questions that’ll get you into trouble, for my mates won’t stand any nonsense.”

“Then cut your own talk short. You have committed a deed which will eventually bring you to the gallows, and there is no reason why there should be any delay in finishing the job like the pirates that you are,” Captain Mansfield said, impatiently.

“That’s exactly what we’re goin’ to do. Search the crowd for fear they may have revolvers with them,” the man said, with an assumption of authority, which would have been comical under less desperate circumstances.

But few moments were required in order to execute this command, and when the work was concluded the helpless men had been robbed of everything valuable upon their persons.

Captain Mansfield no longer attempted to speak; it was as if his anger was too great to admit of words, but he watched jealously every movement made by his enemies.

The sun was flooding the sea with a golden radiance when the mutineers lowered one of the boats, put into her a small cask of water and some provisions, and then stood as if waiting for the rightful crew of the *Day Dream* to take their departure.

At such a time resistance would have been worse than useless, and, when his bonds had been removed, the captain said, as he walked toward the rail:

“I warn you that the time will come when this high-handed proceeding must be atoned for, and, if you have any regard for your own necks, you will give us more of a show for life.”

“What do you want now?” the leader asked, with an oath.

“Two boats, and something to serve as sails. With eight people on board one of these little tenders the first strong puff of wind will send her to the bottom. Give us as good a show as you would want for yourselves.”

“It’s a precious sight better than you deserve,” was the brutal reply, as the helpless ones were hurried over the rail, their united weight loading the craft down to the gunwales.

From the time the gag had been removed until he clambered into the boat old Andy had not spoken; but when the painter was cast off and the schooner began to draw away from them, his anger burst forth in a torrent of threats and reproaches.

He called down all manner of curses on the heads of sailors who would turn pirates immediately after having been rescued from such a desolate spot as the key, and predicted the result of these high-handed proceedings in language so energetic that Captain Mansfield said, sharply:

“Be quiet, Andy. You are doing them no harm, and couldn’t better our condition if you talked all day.”

“I’se gwine ter let sich low down trash know wha’s ercumin’ to ’em.”

“They’ll know it soon enough without any assistance from you. Just now we’ve something more important to think about, for unless we can make

harbor on one of the keys which lie hereabouts before a heavy blow comes on, our chances for living will be pretty slim.”

“Isn’t there any hope we can get our things back?” Nelse asked, ruefully. “The thieves have even taken my watch.”

“I don’t fancy we shall see even the smallest portion of our property again,” the captain replied, with what was very like a sigh. “They will get to fighting among themselves, and wreck the little craft before long, unless, which is not likely, a war vessel happens to overhaul them.”

“Shall we get out the oars?” Mr. Jenkins asked. “We should be near Spanish or Powel Key, and by rowing to the eastward it ought to be possible to run the land down by sunset.”

“You are right, and it’s to be turn and turn about for all hands. Unfortunately only two can work at a time, because we have no more oars, and the tricks shall be an hour for each man.”

From this moment until nearly nightfall but little conversation was indulged in; each occupant of the boat had been robbed of all his effects, and this, in addition to the outrage, was well calculated to make them feel the reverse of cheerful.

The wind, which had so much weight in it at sunrise, died away entirely about ten o’clock, and the heat was most intense. Not even the lightest breath of air came off the glassy water, and one hour was quite as long as the strongest could remain at the oars.

At three o’clock in the afternoon a well-wooded key was seen dead ahead, and two hours later the victims of their own charitable act were on shore.

“We will stay here twenty-four hours,” Captain Mansfield said, as the boat was pulled up into a narrow cove which extended some distance inland, and terminated in a veritable thicket of mangroves. “Then we’ll work our way down the bank in the night, when we sha’n’t be so nearly prostrated by the heat.”

It was a great relief to the boys to be able to stretch their legs on shore, and when a spot was cleared that all might lie down without fear of being disturbed by centipedes or similar disagreeable things, they began to think the situation was not as grave as it might have been.

A hearty meal of ship's bread and canned meat was followed by a desire to sleep, and the entire party lay down to rest, for it was not necessary to stand watch.

Toward midnight the wind sprang up from the eastward, but only to die away again a few hours later, and Captain Mansfield said to the mate, in a tone of satisfaction, as the two arose just as day was breaking:

"If there were any vessels nearby last evening we should get a glimpse of a sail when the sun rises, for that breeze must have given them a slant toward this key."

"By swarming up one of the largest trees we can have quite a range of vision, and something ought to be heaving in sight before night. I'll stand the first trick."

"With nothing else to—— Hark!"

As the captain spoke a creaking sound was heard, and he finished the sentence by saying, joyfully:

"It seems that we sha'n't have long to wait. There is some kind of a craft becalmed within a quarter of a mile of the shore."

"There can be no question about that. Shall we hail her?"

"It isn't necessary. She can't get away until the breeze springs up, and we may as well know who we are asking for assistance. I am not putting as much faith in my fellow-man as I was before our experience of yesterday."

The two walked down the bank of the cove to the beach, where a full view of the seaboard could be had, and there waited for the rising sun to show them the newcomer.

The shaft of radiance soon came out of the sea, gilding each crestless wave with a glory of brightness, and revealing to the watchers the spars of a jaunty-looking schooner so near the land that it seemed as if one could have tossed a pebble on her deck.

Mr. Jenkins stood staring at the little craft in open-mouthed astonishment as if doubting the evidence of his own senses, until Captain Mansfield pulled him roughly back into the shelter of the foliage, as he whispered excitedly:

"It's the *Day Dream* herself."

“For a moment I thought my eyes were playing me a trick,” the mate said, with a long-drawn breath of bewilderment. “What are we to do? Show ourselves?”

“Not yet. We must form a plan of action, for if this calm holds until noon the little craft shall be in our possession again.”

---

## CHAPTER VIII.

### TURNING THE TABLES.

The first thing to be done was to warn the remainder of the party that the mutineers were close at hand, lest some incautious noise might betray the fact of their being on the key, and to this end Captain Mansfield hurried to the head of the little cove.

Old Andy was the only one awake, and to him the captain whispered:

“The villains who seized the *Day Dream* are becalmed within twenty fathoms of the shore. See to it that——”

The darky looked up in alarm, his eyes seemingly starting from their sockets, and he was on the verge of giving vent to a cry of fear when Captain Mansfield seized him by the throat.

“Don’t you dare so much as wink, or I’ll choke the breath out of your body,” he whispered, angrily, and the old man sank to his knees the very personification of terror. “Now listen carefully, and see that you do as I tell you. See to it that there is no noise made here. When the others awake tell them to remain quiet until I return.”

There was no longer any danger that Andy would betray the secret by an incautious move. The threat terrified him even more than the knowledge of the mutineers’ whereabouts, and Captain Mansfield retraced his steps to the point where he had left the mate.

During the short time he had been absent the general condition of affairs on the schooner’s deck was changed considerably.

The mutineers had come from below, probably after a night’s debauch, and the sound of angry conversation told that a quarrel was imminent.

“What has happened?” the captain asked Mr. Jenkins, in a whisper.

“I don’t know. They came out of the cabin a few seconds ago, and this row appears to be a continuation of what started below.”

“It will be a fortunate happening for us, if they get into a fight.”



“Possibly,” the mate replied, hesitatingly; “but I fail to see how it is going to be possible for us to accomplish anything without weapons when that crowd are well armed, if they have taken the trouble to search the cabin, which I reckon has been done long before this.”

“We shall find a way out of it, if the calm continues. Give me a chance to get over the bow before they know we’re in the vicinity, and I’ll take the risk of their weapons.”

The discussion on the yacht was fast degenerating into a regular row. The men were talking so loudly that a reasonably good idea of the condition of affairs could be gained by the listeners.

Several of the mutineers were insisting on making this particular key a sort of rendezvous, and demanding that a certain lot of goods (probably something they had saved from the *Mary and Jane*) should be brought here.

Another faction, and among them the leader, wanted to run for the Florida Straits, in order to remain hidden among the keys until search for the yacht should be abandoned. They believed, and with good reason, that Captain Mansfield would not tamely submit to the loss of his vessel, and, since the weather had been favorable for navigation in a small boat, it was more than probable those who had been dispossessed would succeed in reaching Nassau.

Greatly to the disappointment of the two concealed among the foliage on shore, the men did not come to blows, although each instant it seemed as if such would be the case. After squabbling for twenty minutes or more the mutineers appeared to have come to some kind of an understanding, and a quantity of the cabin stores were brought on deck for breakfast.

Each one appeared to be his own cook, and the wastefulness displayed would have brought tears of vexation to Andy’s eyes. A tin of beef, which one fellow opened, was tossed overboard after he had taken out two slices.

A box of biscuit was left on the house that each might help himself, and the greater portion used in firing on a wager at a floating bottle.

This kind of horseplay came to an end finally, and then the half-drunken crew began lowering one of the boats.

“It is possible that our opportunity is near at hand,” Captain Mansfield whispered. “It looks as if some of them were coming ashore, and it is time the rest of our party were ready for action. Creep back softly, and send them to me. Then pole our boat as near the mouth of the cove as is safe.”

By a chance as fortunate and unexpected as had been the coming of the *Day Dream*, all the mutineers but two prepared to go on shore, and, as nearly as Captain Mansfield could judge, each man had armed himself either with a rifle or revolver, thus exhausting the supply of weapons on board.

“It will be nothing more than child’s play now, provided they do not land too near here,” he whispered to himself, and just as the boats pushed off from the schooner, Gil and Nelse crept close to the watcher’s side.

“Is there any chance of our getting the yacht again?” the former asked; but his father motioned for him to be silent.

The remainder of the party came up before the mutineers were half-a-dozen yards from the vessel, and a few moments later Captain Mansfield saw, to his dismay, that the men intended to land directly in front of his hiding-place.

It seemed as if this must be a deathblow to all his plans, and the boys mentally braced themselves for the struggle both believed to be at hand.

The men rowed leisurely, singing and laughing, evidently fancying themselves the only human beings in the vicinity, and the little tender struck the beach not more than a dozen feet from where the anxious ones were concealed.

The bows of the boats were pulled up on the sand to prevent them from drifting away, and then the mutineers pushed straight on into the thicket, probably bent on exploring the key to learn if it would serve them as a rendezvous.

They were making so much noise that the watchers might have conversed in ordinary tones; but Captain Mansfield did not take any such chances, when he whispered to Gil:

“You and Nelse go back to where Jenkins is waiting with the boat. Send him to me, and get on board. Move cautiously down to the very mouth of the cove, and stay there, with oars in the rowlocks, until you see us push

one of these crafts from the shore. Then row for the schooner the best you know how."

This was no time to ask questions, and the orders were obeyed instantly.

Mr. Jenkins was but a short distance away, and when Gil had repeated his father's instructions the mate hurried off, leaving the boys to carry out their part of the programme unaided.

"Father is probably going to try to get hold of the other two boats," Gil whispered, as he clambered inboard, "and if the mutineers see us while we are pulling out to the schooner we shall have the chance of learning how it seems to be shot at."

"I'd rather receive a pretty serious wound than let those scoundrels go off with the yacht again, now there's a possibility of our gaining possession once more," Nelse said, and by the time he ceased speaking both were in the little craft, each with an oar ready to pull at the first signal.

The voices of the mutineers now sounded from a distance, and it was not likely they could have a view of the water because of the intervening foliage; but yet Captain Mansfield's party gave no sign of action.

Ten minutes passed, and Gil was beginning to grow alarmed lest his father should wait too long, when a light splash of water was heard, and one of the tenders shot out from the shore with the two sailors rowing and Andy at the helm.

"Now bend to it," Gil whispered, hoarsely. "Watch to see that one doesn't pull the other around, for there mustn't be any wild steering."

The boys were out of the cove just as the captain and Mr. Jenkins launched the last boat, and all three crafts were dashing over the glassy sea in fine style, sending tiny showers of spray up from their bows, when a loud yell was heard.

The two fellows on the schooner had caught a glimpse of the captain's party, and were shouting for their friends.

"It's a question of reaching the other side of the yacht before they heave in sight, or we may come to grief," Gil said, grimly, as he bent his back to the oar until the ashen blade bent under the vigorous strain.

“Board her over the rail amidships, boys!” Captain Mansfield shouted, and glancing around for the merest fraction of time, Nelse saw that the sailors were steering for the schooner’s bow, while the other boat was being sent toward the stern.

By thus dividing the force, the mutineers would be beset both from front and rear, while Gil and Nelse created diversion on one side, and the struggle could not be long protracted.

The men on the yacht were yelling at the full strength of their lungs, and stood near the bow with handspikes raised ready to fell the first who should attempt to come on board; but they could not guard the stern at the same time, therefore the captain and mate succeeded in clambering over the rail before the fellows were fully aware of their purpose.

The boys had just pulled around the *Day Dream* when the main body of mutineers burst out of the bushes, and the shower of bullets which they sent, without waiting to take accurate aim, did no injury to any one.

Mr. Jenkins had opened the battle by hurling a handspike with such good effect that the taller sailor was knocked over like a ninepin, and the other, realizing how useless it would be to contend against such odds, leaped into the sea, swimming for dear life as those on the shore continued to discharge their weapons.

“Keep under the rail as much as possible,” Captain Mansfield shouted, as he set the example by crouching where he could get a view of the shore without exposing too much of his body. “They can’t have any very great amount of ammunition, and it isn’t likely either of that crowd has got the nerve to swim out here.”

Andy was the only one who did not follow this suggestion instantly. The old darky was so elated at the complete turning of the tables that it seemed absolutely necessary to give vent in some way to his joy.

He danced around the deck in full view of the angry men on shore, shouting in a sing-song tone:

“Wese done got de bes’ ob dem villyns! Glory to de Lam’! Wese ’board de yacht once mo’! Glory to de Lam’! Wese gwine—— Hi, yi, yi!”

These last exclamations were by no means a portion of his song of triumph; but just at that moment a bullet from one of the rifles had grazed the top of his ear, causing more pain than a really serious wound would have done, and, with a howl of terror, he flung himself down by Captain Mansfield's side, where he alternately moaned and continued to cry:

“Glory to de Lam’!”

---

## CHAPTER IX.

### BOUND SOUTH.

After having fired four or five rounds of ammunition without other effect than the grazing of Andy's ear, the mutineers appeared to have grown tired of such useless work, and ceased to waste their cartridges.

The calm was still "raging." There was not wind enough to have caused any perceptible motion in a feather, and those who had taken possession of their own again could not do otherwise than remain idle, waiting for that which, by filling the white sails, would carry them far from their enemies.

On the shore the mutineers sat watching the schooner, unable to do anything toward regaining her, and, as Jenkins expressed it, "eating their hearts out" with anger, because they had been so foolish as to take all the weapons ashore, leaving the ship-keepers virtually defenseless.

The man who had been bowled over by a belaying-pin recovered consciousness after the firing ceased, and, with a very disagreeable sensation in his head, sat on the main hatch, probably wondering what was to become of him.

"Are you going to keep that thing?" the mate asked of Captain Mansfield, pointing over his shoulder with his thumb at the disconsolate-looking mutineer.

"Let him swim ashore when there's a chance of our crawling away from this key."

"Why not use him first?"

"How do you mean?"

"If a breeze should spring up now those fellows on the beach would amuse themselves by making targets of us while we were raising the anchor and making sail."

"I have thought of that; but do not see how it is to be avoided."

"Make this fellow do such work as he can, with our assistance, while we remain under cover. Give me the word and I'll guarantee to have the little

craft ready for the first cat's-paw which comes over the sea, and without exposing myself."

"Act as you please, Mr. Jenkins. It is no more than fair that he should do something to repay for the trouble and loss which his crowd have cost us."

The mate could have asked for no more congenial task, and Andy was in an ecstasy of delight as the mutineer was forced to play the part of a barricade for the others.

At first the man appeared disposed to rebel against doing the work demanded of him; but Mr. Jenkins said, sternly, brandishing a belaying-pin to give greater emphasis to his words:

"You ought to have a pretty good idea by this time that we shouldn't feel very bad to be obliged to break your head, and that's exactly what will happen if you don't step lively. It may be well to tell those scoundrels on the beach who it is doing this work, otherwise they might put a bullet into your hide."

The fellow began to realize that his captors were not to be trifled with, and very meekly went to the rail, where he shouted:

"Hi! Mike! This crowd have got the drop on me, an' I'm bound to do as they say; so don't shoot, will yer?"

"Why not swim ashore? They can't do anything, if you only show a little nerve, 'cause we've got all the shootin' irons."

"My leg's about the same as broken, 'an I couldn't swim a stroke."

Mike was silent for a few seconds, and then he asked:

"Is the captain countin' on leaving us here?"

"You have brought it on yourselves, and can be mighty certain that we wouldn't raise a finger to help you now, if the whole gang was starving," Captain Mansfield shouted from his place of vantage under the rail.

The mutineers began to understand that a speedy punishment was about to overtake them, and the leader cried in a whining tone:

"We'll die for the want of something to drink, if you leave us."

“There’s little chance the world will be so lucky as to get rid of you. I shall notify the authorities at Nassau of your whereabouts, as well as of the likelihood that at least a portion of the brig’s cargo will be found on Walker Key, and I reckon you’ll not be left alone very long.”

This acted like a douche of cold water upon the mutineers, who were also, probably, wreckers, and they exhibited every symptom of uneasiness.

“It is time for you to go to work,” Mr. Jenkins said to his prisoner. “Get into the boat with me, and we’ll pull the schooner’s head around so your friends won’t have so good a chance to interfere with us while we weigh the anchor; but remember that if you attempt to give me the slip, I’ll split your head open with this,” and the mate flourished the belaying-pin savagely.

Sheltered from those on the shore by the yacht herself, this portion of the task could be done in comparative safety, and while one of the sailors payed out on the cable the craft was swung around stern on.

Then the men managed to rig up the quarter-deck awning as a screen, without exposing themselves very much, and all hands could now work while hidden from view of the angry scoundrels on the shore.

After this had been done the anchor was weighed, and then the two in the boat pulled and tugged at the oars until the *Day Dream* was fully a mile from the shore.

This had not been accomplished without some show of remonstrance from the mutineers. When the yacht first began to move through the water, and they understood what was being done, a volley of bullets was discharged at random, many finding their way through the canvas screen; but finally this useless evidence of rage ceased, probably because the ammunition had been exhausted.

Not until they were beyond range did Mr. Jenkins allow his prisoner to cease his efforts, and then, wiping the perspiration from his face, he said:

“Now there is nothing to prevent your going ashore, if you feel so disposed.”

“Will you let the men pull me in to that point?”

“Not much. What is to prevent your swimming?”



“I couldn’t do it, even if there were no sharks hereabout, as there are sure to be. My leg feels as if it was broken.”

“You got off cheaply, and that’s more than can be said for the rest of the gang, since they will have to answer to the authorities for what has been done. If you don’t want to swim, get on board, for I sha’n’t give you the chance of stealing one of these boats.”

The man obeyed without another word, and once on the schooner he crouched under the rail forward as if anxious to escape observation.

Meanwhile, as soon as the yacht was at a reasonably safe distance from the shore, Gil and Nelse went below to learn what the mutineers had done there, and the scene which met their gaze was well calculated to fill them with mingled feelings of anger and dismay.

One would have said that a hundred men had been amusing themselves with trying to see how much mischief could be done in a given length of time. The contents of the staterooms were dragged into the cabin, where they might be examined leisurely, and left lying on the floor. Food of all kinds was scattered in every direction, and as much wasted as would have served the rightful crew of the yacht for many days.

“We ought to be thankful we have got the *Day Dream* back in any condition,” Gil said, with a long-drawn sigh; “but it is more than provoking to think we gave that crowd the opportunity of destroying things.”

“All the weapons, watches and money are gone,” Nelse added; “but from what your father said I don’t fancy the amount of cash is enough to make them very rich, and we’ll soon repair damages, so it won’t pay to mourn a great deal. Let’s do what we can toward setting things to rights.”

While the boys were engaged in this work, Andy was surveying his quarters, and if harsh words could have injured the mutineers, not one would have been left alive five minutes after he saw the condition of his kitchen.

They had not spent so much time in the galley as aft; but the same scene of wanton destruction met the cook’s gaze, and he attributed the greater portion of it to the voodooes, whose especial domains the boys had threatened to invade.

“Dere’s gwine ter be de berry debbil raised on dis yere cruise, ef de captain consists in runnin’ to Hayti,” he muttered, while trying to repair the damage. “I’s done gone boun’ ter tork ter dem boys ag’in, kase dey mus’ know wha’s sartin ter happen, ef dat pirates’ gol’ ain’ got out ob dere min’s.”

During this time those on deck had not been idle. Every inch of canvas belonging to the yacht was spread to catch the first breath of air which should come over the sea, and the captain and mate amused themselves by watching the mutineers, who still remained on the beach as if unable to understand that they had lost the little craft so suddenly.

“There comes what we are waiting for,” Mr. Jenkins said, as he pointed toward the west, where a faint ruffling of the water into a deeper blue betokened the rising of the wind. “Now, what is to be done with the fellow forward?”

“Call him aft, and let him decide the question.”

The man obeyed Mr. Jenkins’ summons in a slouchy, shamefaced manner, touching his hat when he reached the quarter-deck, and standing there as if expecting punishment was about to be meted out to him.

“We hope to be under way in a short time,” Captain Mansfield began, “and you are to say what is to become of your precious self. I should be warranted in taking you to Nassau in chains; but it will be too much trouble.”

“I would like to be set ashore, sir.”

“You can leave at any time; but I don’t propose the men shall exert themselves in your behalf by so much as pulling an oar.”

“I can’t swim,” the man said, piteously.

“That may be; but if we row you ashore your precious friends will probably gain possession of the boat, considering the fact that they are well armed, while we would be helpless.”

“I can rig up a sort of raft on which he could manage to reach the land,” Mr. Jenkins ventured to say, observing that the captain hesitated.

“Very well; if he chooses to go in that manner, I have no objection,” and Captain Mansfield turned away, for he was eager to be rid of the mutineer, but did not propose to take any risks.

Two empty casks, with a plank from one to the other, formed quite a seaworthy raft for one man, and ten minutes later, just as the oncoming breeze filled the yacht’s sails, the mutineer was paddling for dear life toward the key.

There was no time to watch his movements, for the *Day Dream* began to draw away from the land in a manner which told that the run to Nassau would be quickly an accomplished fact, providing the wind held.

Once more the yacht was bound south, and, despite all the misfortunes which Andy persisted in believing were caused by the voodooos, Gil and Nelse allowed themselves to dream again of the pirates’ gold.

---

## CHAPTER X.

### HAYTI.

One could easily fancy how much the mutineers must have been punished by seeing the schooner moving swiftly away from the land, knowing as they did that the officers of the law would soon come in search of them, and more than one on board the *Day Dream* was satisfied with this as atonement for all the discomforts suffered during the last thirty hours.

It was impossible to say whether the fellow who had just been released ever reached the shore, although all the chances were in his favor. The last that could be seen of him through the glass was when the schooner rounded the point of land which marked the eastern-most extremity of the key, and then he was paddling for dear life.

It surely seemed as if the wind had come to stay for some time. It continued to increase in weight until nightfall, when the yacht had as much as she needed in such waters, and Mr. Jenkins confidently announced to Gil and Nelse that they would be at Nassau before sunset on the following day.

Time proved this prediction to be correct.

By six o'clock on the same day the yacht had been recaptured, all evidences of her late unlawful crew were wiped out both fore and aft, and when the boys retired the thought of their slight losses, as compared to what might have been, went very far toward consoling them.

"Father will buy us such things as we may need when we get into port," Gil said, confidently, to his cousin, "and if he doesn't think it necessary to replace our watches, no great harm will be done, if we are obliged to look at the cabin clock in order to learn when the meals should be served."

"I'm not worrying about the stuff those fellows took from us," Nelse replied; "but am only afraid uncle won't allow us to hunt for the treasure because of what has already happened."

"That will be all right, as you will see, so let's try not to think any more of what has happened."

At noon on the following day, the boys almost forgot the disagreeable adventures with the mutineers when they landed at Nassau with Mr. Jenkins, and made a tour of the sponge yards, while Captain Mansfield went to inform the authorities of those whom he believed were responsible for the loss of the *Mary and Jane*.

It was a particularly pleasant day which they spent ashore, viewing the many wonders wrested from the bed of the ocean, and on returning to the schooner neither thought to ask what had been done until Captain Mansfield was speaking with the mate about the officers of the ill-fated brig.

“There can be no question but that those fellows had a hand in the wrecking of the *Mary and Jane*,” he said. “The captain and mates landed here last week, and told me to-day there could be no doubt as to the facts. On three different occasions it was found that the brig was many points off her course, and I fancy the men knew exactly where she would be foundered.”

“Will the authorities send to arrest them?” Gil asked.

“Certainly, and the officers of the brig intend to urge it; besides, they propose to start at once for Walker Key in the hope that some of the cargo may be there.”

“Were the men really deserted?”

“Not a bit of it, according to the captain’s story, and after what we have experienced I would believe him against a thousand such as tried to run away with the schooner. It seems that when the brig struck, the men were ordered into the boats; but they refused to leave until the spirits had been divided. The crowd we met insisted on using the gig, and, holding her fast alongside, proceeded to get drunk. A heavy sea was running, and after the officers had expostulated with the men for some time, they believed there was nothing left but to look out for their own lives. The vessel was fast breaking up, and the crew in a drunken condition, when the captain’s party finally put off to try to reach this port, which they did in four days. A schooner was sent out from here; but nothing could be found either of the crew or of the craft, and it was generally believed that she slid off into deep water and sank.”

“Now what will happen?” Gil asked.

“I think it is safe to say the fellows will find themselves in a very disagreeable position before many days have elapsed,” Captain Mansfield replied, and then he was summoned on deck by the arrival of the goods which he had purchased to replace those stolen by the mutineers.

From this time until they were ready to “turn in” the boys had plenty to occupy their attention. The new weapons, additional stores, and such other articles as the captain had bought, were inspected. The things were stowed in their proper places, and then once more the question as to whether the treasure could be found came up for discussion.

Not until a very late hour were the boys ready to retire, owing to the many exciting topics of conversation, and both were awakened next morning at sunrise by Mr. Jenkins, who said, cheerily:

“Turn out lively, lads, for there is a good deal to be seen from here until we are well through the channel, and the yacht is already under way.”

When they came on deck the *Day Dream* was opposite the southernmost point of Great Abaco Island, and the singular formation of rock known as the “Hole in the Wall” was in full view.

The schooner was gliding slowly along under the influence of the gentle morning breeze, and Gil and Nelse had a good opportunity of seeing the odd sights, foremost among which was Spanish Wells, the name of the town on St. George’s Key, at the extreme northwest point of the Island of Eleuthera, where the houses are built on raised platforms, like many in the Malay Archipelago.

The mate explained that this singular style of architecture was adopted because of the hermit-crabs, which sometimes come ashore in vast numbers, ravaging the land and entering every building not on stilts.

Then the cocoanut groves, two miles farther along the coast, were seen, the flame-colored and scarlet blossoms serving to form a most gorgeous picture.

A hasty breakfast, and the boys were on deck again to see the “Glass Window,” a curious and perfect arch of limestone eighty-five feet above the surface of the sea. Not many years ago, so Mr. Jenkins said, a pleasure party were dining there, when suddenly a great tidal-wave came rushing in from

the ocean, dashed up under the arch, and swept the greater number of the merry-makers away.

Such waves, coming without the slightest warning, are frequent here. The natives call them “rages,” and believe they are caused by storms some distance off on the Atlantic.

Still farther down the coast is New Gregory’s Harbor, where the wonderful cave, extending more than eleven hundred feet under the ground, is located; but, of course, this could not be seen from the schooner.

There were, in fact, so many wonderful things to attract the curious during this run down the chain of islands that the boys actually grew tired of the variety, and in sheer weariness turned their attention to what both seemed to think was the true purpose of the voyage.

“Will it be many days before we arrive at Hayti?” Gil asked the mate, and the latter replied:

“If the wind favors we shall wind this portion of the cruise up in short order. The captain intends to run down as far as Silver Key Passage, and then we can head nearly due west.”

“Let’s go and tell Andy how near we are to the home of the voodooos,” Nelse suggested, and the two went at once to the galley, where the information was imparted without loss of time.

The old darky looked at them pityingly for some seconds, and then, shaking his head mournfully, he said:

“You’se rushin’ on ter destruction, dat’s wha’ you’se doin’, an’ when de time cums dat dere’s no help fur you, I’s sartin nobuddy won’t call Andy Storts er fool.”

“What are you going to do when we land?” Gil asked, trying hard to prevent himself from laughing.

“I’s done gone ’range up a plan ob my own.”

“And decided not to desert us?”

“Dere’s no kin’ ob use tryin’ ter run away frum de debbil, kase it carn’t be did. Ef de captain’s boun’ fur ter git hisself in trubble, an’ you boys won’t

try ter dissuade him from it, I'se gwine ter take keer ob myself. Don' dat stan' to reason?"

"You are right, Andy," Nelse replied, laughingly; "but please tell us what your plan is."

"It carn't be did, honey, kase de voodooos wud git hol' ob it, an' den whar'd de ole man be? I'se bin studyin' an' studyin' sence we got de schooner back, an' now I'se feelin' toller'bly easy in my min'."

"Then by not telling us the secret, you show yourself willing that we shall come to grief."

"Honey, dem as rushes 'roun' whar dey don' b'long mus' take de chances, an' ole Andy couldn't dissuade yer ter took his advise."

With this sage remark, spoken in the most sepulchral of tones, the cook turned his attention once more to the savory dish he was preparing for the cabin table, and it was all in vain that the boys tried to prolong the conversation.

From this time until the schooner finally came to anchor off the northern shore of the Tortuga de Mar, nothing of especial interest occurred to vary the monotony of the voyage.

The wind favored them in the most satisfactory manner, and the little craft glided among the many keys in perfect safety until on a certain night about ten o'clock the longed-for spot was reached.

The boys had been on deck in a perfect fever of excitement during the entire day; but, owing to the darkness, it was impossible to gain any idea of the small body of land where they believed so much treasure would be found by them.

"We must curb our impatience until morning, I suppose," Gil said, with a sigh; "but I would have liked a chance to compare the conformation of the land with our chart."

"Are you going to bed now?" Nelse asked.

"What would be the use? I couldn't close my eyes in sleep yet awhile."

"Then let's slip into the galley, and see if Andy is putting his wonderful plan into operation. I am eager to find out how he proposes to assure his own



safety while the debbil is getting hold of us.”

Gil was more than willing to act upon this suggestion, since it would serve to help pass away the time until they wished to “turn in,” and the two went below to the kitchen, where, to their great surprise, the door was found securely locked.

They knocked again and again without receiving a reply, and as one of the sailors passed, Gil asked:

“Do you know where Andy is?”

“In there, and he don’t mean to open the door for anybody. I reckon he’s up to some of his funny business, ’cause he’s so afraid of what may be found on the island.”

The boys tried again to make the old darky answer; but he steadily refused, and they were finally forced to return to the deck.

---

## CHAPTER XI.

### CONJECTURES.

During this evening Gil and Nelse could do no more than speculate as to whether it would be possible to find a conformation of the coast similar to the one shown by the rude chart, and since this question was to be settled definitely in such a comparatively short space of time neither Captain Mansfield nor Mr. Jenkins would so much as take part in the conversation.

Even the exciting thoughts of discovering pirates' treasure were not sufficient to prevent them from feeling sleepy after a while, more especially when all save the watch had turned in, and at midnight they crept into the little stateroom.

Both the boys lay down with the determination to be on deck at the first sign of dawn, and yet the sun was half an hour high before either opened his eyes.

Nelse was the first to awaken, and he cried, in a tone of deepest anxiety, as if believing the delay might in some manner result to their injury:

"Get up, Gil! If this is the way we set about hunting for gold there won't be a very good chance of finding any. We should have been on deck two hours ago."

This summons was sufficient to bring Gil to his feet instantly, and, after a hurried toilet, the two were leaning over the rail aft, with the well-worn and enigmatical piece of brown paper spread out where it could be studied at their leisure.

When they first gained the deck Andy was coming from the galley to the cabin with the morning meal; but both the would-be treasure seekers were in such a high state of excitement that they actually forgot their curiosity of the previous night, and did not even think to ask what steps he had taken to insure his safety against the dreaded voodooos.

"If that was intended as a chart of the Tortuga de Mar the schooner is in the best possible place for you to go ahead with the work," Mr. Jenkins said, as he approached the boys. "There's the point of land, with a rock or bit of

coral to the nor'ard of it, an' dead as the bowsprit shows is the cove with what I take to be soundings; but have you fellows figured out the meaning of the other things?"

"We think the drawing of the schooner with a lead-line on which is the figure eight, hanging from her bowsprit means that only a small craft with a draught of not over eight feet can get in there," Gil replied.

"I reckon that's right, though it was a waste of time an' lead pencil to make the craft after showing the soundings."

"Then the letters and figures on this stick, and the straight lines on the side, refer to the same thing, which is that from a certain tree—for those scratches must have been made to represent foliage—at a distance of eighteen feet and eight inches north, then five feet west, the treasure will be found."

"Well, you've figured it out better than I expected," Mr. Jenkins said, approvingly; "but how do you know whether the measurements are in feet, yards or fathoms?"

"That part of it is guesswork, of course. I don't think it can mean fathoms, because of the fraction eight, therefore it will only be necessary to try the feet and yards, which can't be such a great amount of work."

"No," the mate replied, slowly and thoughtfully, "not if this is the place, or if you find the right tree, or if there's any treasure buried on the island; but according to my way of thinking it'll be a decently hard job to decide exactly where the sights should be taken from, considering the fact that this part of the island is fairly well wooded."

Then Mr. Jenkins walked away, for the cook had announced that breakfast was served, and the boys were again plunged into a disagreeable state of uncertainty because of the difficulty they would undoubtedly have in trying to decide which was the landmark referred to on the supposed chart.

Andy did not so much as look at Gil and Nelse when they came into the cabin. It seemed as if he tried to avoid meeting their eyes, and during all the time they were talking with Captain Mansfield relative to the finding of the tree, he stood just inside the pantry making some of the most extraordinary gestures possible.

“There is nothing to prevent your going ashore with Mr. Jenkins, if you feel so disposed,” Gil’s father said, as he finished his meal. “I am not inclined to any such exercise, but can manage to pass the time with some degree of comfort while the search is made.”

The boys had hoped the captain would become interested in the proposed work when they were where an investigation could be made; but this last remark showed that he did not intend to have anything to do with the decidedly mythical treasure.

Mr. Jenkins, however, was not only ready but eager for a trip ashore, and, without waiting for orders, he caused one of the tenders to be lowered.

If there were any inhabitants on this end of the island they had kept well out of sight, and to guard against a possible attack by wild animals the boys armed themselves with revolvers as well as rifles.

There was plenty of work aboard for the sailors, therefore the treasure-seekers were expected to do their own rowing, and, with all hands except Andy watching from the rail, they started, heading directly for the cove.

Gil suggested that, in order to make certain the narrow strip of water was the one they were anxious to find, soundings be made. If the depth of water should coincide with the fifteen, ten and eight of the chart it would afford a certain degree of proof, but to this Mr. Jenkins objected.

“It would be only a waste of time,” he said. “The bottom so near inshore shifts every year, and you couldn’t even rely on a Government chart.”

“I thought from what we read in the newspaper clipping that the island was small,” Nelse said, as the boat neared the shore. “It looks pretty big from here.”

“Twenty-two miles long and five wide, according to the geographies,” the mate replied, with a laugh, “so you see there’s plenty of room for adventure in case Andy’s voodooos really make this place their headquarters.”

“Do you believe in anything of the kind?”

“That the negroes of Hayti practice the rites of voodooism there can be no doubt; but of course the cook has exaggerated matters.”

By this time the little tender's bow had been run up on the sandy beach, and, after looking carefully around to make certain no one was lurking in the vicinity, the party landed.

The boat was made fast, and Gil led the way on what now seemed a hopeless task, that of finding a tree so old as to give promise of being the one from which the proper bearings might be taken, if indeed there was anything proper or positive in the document they had discovered.

The foliage was dense; so matted in places as to render it difficult for the travelers to force a passage through, and thus they were obliged to go blindly on, passing near perhaps the very object for which they were searching.

There were many birds to be seen and heard, but no other form of animal life was found during the tramp, except once when a hog, probably a descendant from those brought to the island by the original buccaneers, dashed out of the thicket, almost overturning Nelse, and disappearing again before either of the party had an opportunity to fire a single shot.

At the end of an hour, when they were three miles from the beach, as nearly as could be judged, the mate threw himself on the ground as he said, impatiently:

"It is foolish to keep on in this manner. We haven't come across a tree of any size after walking this distance, although we know there were very many to be seen in the immediate vicinity from the schooner's deck."

"The undergrowth is so dense that we shouldn't know it if one was a dozen feet away," Nelse replied, fanning himself vigorously, for the heat at this point, where the cooling breezes from the sea could not penetrate, was almost stifling.

"Then there's all the more reason why we should go back, mark out a course, and follow it by a compass."

"But I counted on finding what we wanted straight across from the end of the cove," Gil said, disconsolately.

"It isn't yet certain that it can't be discovered," the mate replied, laughingly. "We are not woodsmen enough to travel a beeline without anything to guide us."

“It’s positive we’re wasting time roaming around in this manner, so let’s go back.”

“Hold on a little while. I am so nearly roasted that there will be nothing left of me but perspiration if I am forced to take any exercise right away,” Nelse cried, in affected distress.

Each member of the party was more than willing to indulge in a *siesta* just at this time, and, following the example set by the mate the boys stretched themselves out at full length, regardless alike of snakes or the worshipers of voodoo.

Everything was conducive to slumber, save the winged pests which were particularly active, and, despite even these, all three were soon sleeping soundly; so much so, in fact, that two half-naked negroes passed within three feet of where they were lying without arousing them.

This was possible owing to the fact that the strangers walked with exceeding caution, finding an open way through the foliage where seemingly none existed, and circling around the sleepers without so much as a rustling of the leaves.

These men must certainly have been aware that the schooner had come to an anchor off the island during the night, for they evinced no surprise at seeing the whites, but scrutinized them carefully, as if trying to judge of their character.

For fully five minutes the fellows continued the silent examination, and then they glided through the thicket toward the direction where the yacht was lying.

A quarter of an hour later Mr. Jenkins awakened, and called cheerily to the boys:

“Come, it’s time to turn out if we want to get back without running the risk of losing our way. When the sun gets behind the trees we shall be all at sea so far as direction goes.”

The short nap had refreshed the boys wonderfully, and they were on their feet at once, ready for the tramp.

“Father will laugh when we tell him that, after being on shore so long, we haven’t seen the kind of a tree we were searching for.”

“You may have better luck to-morrow,” the mate said, cheerily, as he led the return march, and the little party traveled so rapidly that in a trifle more than an hour they were pulling toward the *Day Dream* from the cove, all unconscious of the half-a-dozen black forms concealed in the thicket near the water’s edge watching their every movement.

---

## CHAPTER XII.

### A STRANGE SPECTACLE.

Although Andy had paid no attention to the departure of the boys and the mate, he was watching eagerly for their return, and Gil said, laughingly, as he saw the old darky's woolly pate just outside the forward companionway hatch:

"I suppose he thought we would never come back; that the voodooes were sure to catch us. We must ask him how it is he feels secure now, when a short time ago he was confident we should not live to get home again."

"He has probably conjured up some kind of a charm," the mate replied, as he leaped aboard the yacht, painter in hand, and at that instant the cook disappeared very suddenly.

Captain Mansfield was taking his ease under the awning aft when the boys came over the rail, and from the expression on their faces he knew the forenoon's work had produced no satisfactory results.

"Treasure-hunting in such a climate isn't what it is cracked up to be, eh?" he cried.

"We haven't found what we wanted yet, but we may be more successful to-morrow," Gil said, just a trifle sheepishly.

"Take your time about it, but let me know when you begin to grow discouraged, for this isn't the safest anchorage I have seen, in case the wind comes from any northerly quarter."

It really seemed as if Mr. Jenkins had been seized with an attack of the treasure-hunting fever, for, without waiting to eat dinner, which was already prepared, he produced his glass and began searching the thicket.

"Are you looking for an old tree?" Nelse asked.

"Yes; we may as well get our bearings at once, and save just so much time to-morrow morning."

"Do you see any?"



“No less than three. I’ll mark out a course to each, and neither of them are so far from the shore but that we can visit all in half a day.”

At this moment Andy came from the galley on his way to the after pantry, and, motioning to Gil to do the same, Nelse followed him.

“Well, you see we went on shore and escaped being devoured by the voodooos,” he said, when all three entered the cabin.

“Don’t say nuffin ’bout it, honey,” the cook whispered, imploringly. “Dis yere schooner ain’t outer de reach ob dem debbils till she’s boun’ home.”

“Tell us what you did to protect yourself?” Gil asked. “We tried to get into the galley last night in order to learn the same thing, but you wouldn’t open the door.”

“You’s crazy, chile, ter tork so loud when we’s in dis yere place. I couldn’t tole yer nuffin ’bout it, kase den de charm would spile. Ef yer don’ go ashore ag’in there’s er chance ob gittin’ off wid our lives.”

“Then it is a charm you’ve got!” Nelse cried, gleefully. “Let us see it, Andy.”

“I’s done gone ’bliged to keep cl’ar ob you chillun ef dar’s any mo’ said ’bout it,” the cook replied, angrily. “We’s in a mighty bad scrape, an’ I’s got my han’s full takin’ keer ob Andy Storts widout tryin’ fur ter bring mo’ trubble by torkin’.”

This ended the conversation, so far as the old darky was concerned, for, after placing certain additional dishes on the table, he betook himself to the seclusion of his galley.

Mr. Jenkins could apparently think of nothing but the supposed treasure, and during a greater portion of the remainder of the day he pored over the rude chart, discussing with the boys the possibility that it might refer to some other island.

Andy took great pains to stay out of the way all this time, and they saw nothing of him until supper was served; but even then he refused to speak.

That evening Gil and Nelse slung hammocks under the awning, intending to sleep on deck because of the excessive heat which rendered the cabin

suffocatingly close, and the mate ensconced himself in a folding-chair which could be stretched out in the semblance of a bed.

It was nine o'clock. Save for the low, musical murmur of the sea on the sandy beach, not a sound could be heard, and the boys were fast sinking into the arms of the dream-god when Mr. Jenkins whispered, excitedly:

"Look there! I reckon there's considerable in Andy's yarn about voodooos."

This was sufficient to cause the boys to leap from their hammocks very suddenly, and, gazing in the direction pointed out by the mate they saw nothing more remarkable than the glow of a fire about half a mile to the eastward of where they had landed during the forenoon.

"There's not much startling about that," Gil said, in a tone of disappointment.

"It shows there are human beings ashore near here, although we failed to find any traces of them."

"But it doesn't prove that they are other than honest fishermen or planters," Nelse added.

"I'm not so sure," Mr. Jenkins replied, in a musing tone. "If there was nothing out of the ordinary run going on over there why should a fire have been built?"

"It won't take us long to learn," Gil cried, for his last remark had aroused his curiosity. "What is to prevent our rowing over that way? The tender hasn't been taken out of the water, and, although we've had plenty of exercise to-day, a little more won't do us any harm."

"I'm with you if the captain makes no objection," the mate said, as he sprang to his feet, and Gil's father, who had overheard the conversation, replied:

"Do as you please, but don't stay away too long, for at this season of the year it is impossible to say when a breeze may spring up which would make our anchorage a dangerous one."

"It isn't likely we shall want to land," Gil said as he went to the cabin for his and Nelse's revolvers, and five minutes later the little party were rowing

toward the reflection of the fire, Gil and Nelse at the oars, and Mr. Jenkins steering.

“Be careful,” the mate had said, in a low tone, as they left the side of the yacht. “On such a night as this sound travels a long distance over the water, and you don’t want to splash about much.”

This admonition was unnecessary. The thought that they might be on the brink of some wonderful discovery rendered both the boys cautious, and he who could hear anything as the little craft glided toward the shore would need to have a very acute sense of hearing.

Perhaps half-an-hour elapsed before they were near that portion of the shore from which the light had been reflected, and then it was learned that the blaze was some distance inland.

It was possible to distinguish voices in an unmusical song or chant, but nothing could be seen, and Mr. Jenkins whispered:

“We might just as well have stayed on the schooner, so far as learning anything is concerned. Shall we go back, or do you boys want to creep up on those fellows?”

It was evident that the mate wished to land, but preferred to have it appear as if he was doing so simply to oblige his companions.

“I would like to see what is going on in there,” Nelse said, and Gil added, after a moment’s thought:

“There can be no harm in trying it. Those who are making that noise would hardly dare to raise a row in case we betrayed our whereabouts, and, besides, armed as we are, it should be possible to hold our own against quite a crowd.”

The boat’s bow was run gently on the sand, and Mr. Jenkins stepped softly over the side to hold her while the boys got out, after which she was carried a full length up on the shore.

“I’ll go ahead,” the mate whispered, “and you take good care to keep close to me, for it would make a bad mess if we should get separated in the darkness.”

“Go on; we’ll take care of that part,” Gil whispered, and the advance was begun slowly, for it was no easy matter to make one’s way among the dense foliage with the necessary degree of silence.

As the party advanced the sound of voices became more distinct, and finally it became positive that some odd sort of a performance was being given in this wild place.

When about three hundred yards had been traversed the mate came to a sudden halt, and, as he pulled aside a cluster of saw palmettos the boys had a full view.

Instinctively they had crouched to the ground when Mr. Jenkins’ movements told that the journey was ended, and, screened by the underbrush, it seemed positive they were hidden from that strange party.

The fire had been built in a small cleared space at the foot of a huge palm tree, and over the flames was suspended an iron pot, from which a most disagreeable odor arose.

For the time being, however, the spectators had no thought for anything save the actors in this strange spectacle.

No less than twenty coal-black men, naked, save for a cloth about the loins were dancing to and fro near the blaze, bending their bodies in every possible position, and making the hideous noise with greatest energy. Now and then one would circle around the pot several times in succession, howling yet louder, while his companions remained silent, and at the end of the dismal song would throw something into the boiling mass, after which the uproar increased until another member of the party performed the same ceremony.

Gil was very positive he saw first a snake and then a toad thrown into the pot, and it hardly seemed possible the cooking would be followed by eating.

The faces of the dancers were painted with vivid red lines, as if the coloring matter was blood, and two of the eldest members had the same kind of ornamentation covering their entire bodies.

When the crowd had apparently exhausted themselves by this sort of exercise, they crouched around the fire, looking more like gigantic frogs

than human beings, and the old fellows stirred the contents of the pot, making the most uncouth gestures meanwhile.

Then it appeared as if the “broth” was done.

The performers began to dance and sing once more, and Gil had just thought that it was time for them to retrace their steps, when the two highly-decorated performers set about ladling the disgusting-looking stuff into cocoanut shells.

A dozen portions were taken from the pot, and handed to as many men, each of whom immediately started through the thicket in a different direction, one passing so near Nelse that it seemed as if he leaped directly over the boy, and the remainder of the crowd redoubled their howls and contortions.

Mr. Jenkins pressed the hands of his companions to intimate that it was time for them to leave, and the boys rose to their feet, following him at a comparatively swift pace, to the spot where the boat had been left.

“We must have missed our way somehow,” the mate whispered, when they finally emerged from the thicket, and saw no signs of the craft. “I could almost swear that this is the place where we landed.”

“So it is,” Gil replied, in dismay. “Here is the imprint of her keel in the sand. Some of those fellows who left with the soup have stolen her.”

---

## CHAPTER XIII.

### IN TROUBLE.

Not until Mr. Jenkins examined the beach in every direction for a distance of ten or fifteen yards from where they came out of the thicket, would he be convinced that the tender had been stolen.

Then, when he saw the imprints of bare feet, showing that the thieves had carried the little craft thirty or forty feet toward the eastward before launching her, and even found the spot where her bow had rested on the sand, probably while the negroes got on board, he was almost beside himself with rage.

"I ought to be kicked every hour in the day until we get home again," he said, angrily. "Anybody, except a fool like me, would have had sense enough, when those fellows left the fire, to realize that the boat might be in danger; but I never gave her a thought."

"Neither did Nelse nor I," Gil added, "consequently we rank quite as high in the fool scale. There's no way out of it, but admit to father that we allowed the tender to be stolen, and try to look pleasant when he makes sport of us."

"I wish we were where we could tell him," the mate said, half to himself.

"That can be easily arranged. It will only be necessary to discharge the revolvers three or four times, and I guarantee father will send some one ashore to learn if there is any trouble."

"I don't think it would be just safe to do that. The crowd we saw back there would most likely prove to be ugly customers, if they had any idea we saw their capers, and it might not be pleasant to bring them down upon us by reports of the weapons."

"Do you believe they are voodooos?" Nelse asked, in a voice which was not remarkable for its steadiness.

"There can be no question about it."

"But what are they doing?"

“I reckon old Andy is the only one of our folks who can answer that question.”

“It begins to look as if we had good cause to be afraid,” Gil said, gloomily.

“Not a bit of it,” the mate replied, cheerily. “We have only to loaf around here two or three hours, and then some one will come ashore to look for us. The most serious portion of the whole business is that the captain is bound to haul us over the coals for losing the boat and putting him to so much trouble.”

Owing to the darkness and the distance, it was not possible to see even the outlines of the yacht; but the forlorn party knew in what direction she lay, and they seated themselves on the sand just outside the fringe of bushes, straining their ears to hear the first sound which should tell that friends were coming.

Half an hour elapsed.

Mr. Jenkins had just ascertained this fact by looking at his watch, when the sound of oars caused all three to leap to their feet in joy.

Surprise and delight that the time of waiting had been so short prevented them from noticing that the craft was coming from a direction opposite the location of the schooner, and as they went to the water’s edge, Gil hailed:

“Boat ahoy! Here we are! Our craft was stolen, and to save ourselves from possible trouble, we didn’t try to attract your attention.”

Then he paused for a reply; but none came. The light splashing of water told that the boat was still approaching, and Mr. Jenkins cried, impatiently:

“Ahoy there! Where are you from?”

Now even the sounds of the oars ceased, and the little party were so engaged in trying to distinguish the craft amid the gloom, that they failed to hear the light patter of naked feet directly behind them.

“It must be——”

Mr. Jenkins did not finish the sentence, for at that instant he was seized from behind and dragged backward on the sand before he could make the slightest outcry.

Gil and Nelse were served in the same manner at the same time, and when either of the three realized what had happened, they were powerless to move or speak.

Two negroes held each of the prisoners as in bonds of iron, while a third covered the captive's mouth with an enormous hand to prevent any outcry.

The mate attempted to show fight; but struggle as he might, it was impossible to do more than render his own position painful, and this he understood in a very short time.

The *Day Dream's* boat, which had played such an important part in their capture, was now rowed to the shore, and from her leaped two other negroes, who, after assuring themselves that the white strangers had been secured, lifted the tender from the water, carrying her straight up from the beach.

When they had disappeared in the thicket, the prisoners were raised to their feet, and one of the captors, who appeared to be the leader of the party, spoke harshly in a tongue which neither the mate nor the boys understood.

From the tone, it was easy to guess that he was warning them of the consequences in case they should make any outcry; but this seemed superfluous, in view of the fact that the black hands were still held firmly over their mouths.

Half-led, half-dragged, the little party was forced through the thicket, in the direction from which they had just come, and not a word was spoken until all were within the circle of light cast by the fire around which the negroes had been dancing.

Here the black men held a very lively conversation, all talking at the same time, and pausing now and then only to examine more closely the prisoners.

Gil believed they were discussing the question of what should be done with their prizes, and this seemed yet more probable when the two highly-decorated old men spoke at great length, while the others listened, all nodding their heads in token of approval when the speeches were brought to a close.

Meanwhile, Mr. Jenkins appeared to be more alarmed than were the boys; but his fear came from other sources than the present disagreeable situation.



The sighing of the wind among the trees told, to his experienced ear, that a breeze was springing up from the northeast, and if it increased to no more even than what might be expected at this season of the year, he knew it would become necessary for the yacht to put to sea, or run down the other side of the island for a harbor.

In either case they would be left comparatively alone among those who could be considered in no other light than as enemies, and the prospect was not cheering.

The negroes had not yet decided what should be done, when the report of a musket was heard in the distance, and the prisoners looked at each other meaningly, for they knew it was a signal for them to return at once.

This noise caused the black men to come to a speedy conclusion, and after the old fellows had given what were evidently very minute directions as to future movements, the fire was extinguished.

The prisoners, guarded as before, were marched through the thicket on a course nearly at right angles with the one by which they had come from the beach, and had not proceeded more than a quarter of a mile when shouts were heard from the shore.

“Gil! Mr. Jenkins! Shipmates ahoy!”

Captain Mansfield had sent a boat ashore in search of the missing members of his crew, and one can fancy some portion of the prisoners’ mental distress at knowing friends were so near and they unable to make their whereabouts known.

Again Mr. Jenkins attempted to free himself; but after receiving several warning pricks from the point of a knife, in token of what might follow in case he persisted in fighting, he gave up the struggle.

Again and again did the cries come to their ears, borne on the wind, which was steadily and rapidly increasing, and then another report of a musket told that this last boat had been recalled.

Gil and Nelse were almost frantic. Both realized that the negroes would not have dared to commit such an outrage, unless they were so strong in numbers as to resist an attack, and the thought of what might be their fate

on this island, which had already been the scene of so many bloody dramas, was ample excuse for any display of weakness or terror.

The negroes marched rapidly on for at least half-an-hour, and then, coming suddenly, as if from the very bowels of the earth, a bright flame appeared directly in front of the leaders.

As their eyes became accustomed to the gloom, the boys saw that the blaze proceeded from half-a-dozen torches, held by as many men, who had come out of what appeared to be a cave in the side of a hill.

Here quite a lengthy conversation ensued, and then the prisoners were led through a passage sufficiently wide for three men to walk abreast, to a small cave situated about fifty feet from the opening.

Further on, the glow, as of a fire, could be seen, thus showing that beyond their halting-place was another and a larger underground chamber, where, probably, those who had been performing the uncouth antics near the beach found a shelter.

The prisoners were thrust into the small cave, or excavation, without ceremony, and the others went on, apparently indifferent as to what might be done by the whites.

The place was so dark that no idea could be formed of its size, or what it might contain, and even if it had been light, Mr. Jenkins would hardly have given it any attention at that moment.

He stood near the entrance watching until the men had entered the cave at the end of the passage, and then he ran toward the entrance.

Before he had taken twenty steps, a blow from a club brought him to his knees, showing that sentinels were on the alert, and he crawled back, dazed and bleeding from an ugly cut on the head.

The boys had not followed; but they understood from the noise what had happened, and, aiding their companion to enter the underground prison, seated themselves beside him.

“What a fool I was to fancy we were left unguarded,” the mate said, as he felt the warm blood trickling down his face. “Strike a light, Gil, and see what condition my head is in.”

Fortunately, the boys had a small supply of wax matches, and one of these burned long enough to examine the wound.

A single glance was sufficient to show that it was not serious, although it would probably cause considerable pain, and Nelse tied his handkerchief around it to stay the flow of blood.

“I hope we shall have a chance to dress it better before twenty-four hours have passed,” Gil said, with a vain attempt to speak cheerfully. “Father will surely come on shore in search of us when the sun rises, and he should be able to follow such a broad trail as we must have left in coming here.”

“Your father is at sea by this time,” Mr. Jenkins replied, almost sharply. “Didn’t you notice that the wind was blowing half a gale before we arrived here? To save the yacht, he had to get up anchor, and it may be a week before he can get back.”

---

## CHAPTER XIV.

### THE CAVE.

Neither of the boys had thought that it might become necessary for the *Day Dream* to leave her anchorage; but as the mate spoke, both remembered what Captain Mansfield said shortly before they left, and the knowledge that their friends had been forced to abandon them brought with it the deepest despair.

They could hear the wind, as it swept across the mouth of the underground passage, and this told plainly that if the schooner had not left this particular portion of the coast, she would probably be a wreck before morning.

During a long while the mournful party crouched upon the damp earth silent, each occupied with his own gloomy thoughts, and then Gil said, as he arose to his feet:

“We mustn’t give way in this manner! Other people have been in worse scrapes and come out all right by keeping a stiff upper lip, and watching for some chance to help themselves. We are acting like babies.”

“You are right, lad,” and Mr. Jenkins stood erect, clasping Gil’s hand. “Let’s see what kind of a place we are in, and then, perhaps, matters won’t appear quite so desperate. I’d give all the wages due me if I knew why these black villains have brought us here.”

“It can’t be to kill us, for that could have been done without any trouble when we were on the beach,” Gil replied.

This remark seemed to give Nelse courage, and he said, joining the others:

“There’s no use speculating about what can’t be found out until they choose to tell us. Let’s do as Mr. Jenkins proposed, and find out where we are. I’ve got a box full of matches, and they ought to give light enough to show how the place looks.”

While speaking, he had ignited one of the tapers, and all three gazed around eagerly.

There was but little to be seen. An excavation, evidently formed by the hand of man, about twelve feet deep and eight wide, with nothing in it, save a pile of charred wood, where a fire had once been built, made up a complete description of their prison.

“It isn’t the most comfortable-looking place I ever saw,” Gil said, trying hard to appear cheerful; “but we might at least kindle a small fire, since the materials are so near at hand. If our friends make any objection to the plan, they can’t do much more than put it out.”

A blaze, however small, would be better than the profound darkness, and the boys raked the fragments of wood together, partially covering them with sand to prevent a too rapid consumption of fuel.

It was necessary to use three matches of their now precious hoard, before the flames fastened upon the blackened sticks; but the outlay seemed none too great when the dispiriting gloom was thus partially dispelled.

The one question uppermost in the minds of all was, why they had been made prisoners, and, after gathering around the fire, this thought would have caused another painful silence, but for the mate, who said, briskly:

“The darkness will seem all the more intense when this wood has been burned, and what little we have won’t last a great while.”

“I don’t see how we can help ourselves,” Gil replied, with a sigh.

“I am going out through the passage on a hunt for more.”

“And get another blow on the head? Tied up as you are in that handkerchief, which is covered with blood, you look sufficiently like a pirate without trying to add to your peculiar beauty.”

“But this time I’ll go toward the big cave, where our particular friends are probably enjoying themselves. Light enough comes from there to show if any one is on guard, and I’ll guarantee that these villains don’t get a second chance to hit me with a club.”

As if fearing his companions might try to dissuade him from his purpose, Mr. Jenkins crept on his hands and knees to where he could have a view of the passage.

While it was impossible to distinguish anything distinctly, he was able to satisfy himself that there was no one between the two caves, and he rose to his feet as he whispered:

“I’m bound to have some idea of what them chaps are doing, whether I get any more wood or not. Stay here, and I’ll be back in five minutes.”

“We had rather go with you,” Gil replied, as he approached the mate.

“It wouldn’t be safe. If they should happen to see me, and kick up a row, the passage is so small that the three of us would get all tangled up. You can watch from here, and have some idea of what I am doing.”

He started as the last word was spoken, and the boys could see his form outlined against the faint light until he reached the entrance to this second chamber, when he apparently disappeared in the gloom.

“Where has he gone now?” Nelse asked, in a whisper.

“I reckon he’s simply leaning against the side, out of the range of the fire, watching those who are inside.”

Gil’s surmise was correct. Jenkins was standing where he could get a fairly good view of the interior, and that which he saw caused him mingled feelings of surprise, bewilderment and fear.

In the cave, which was circular, and about twenty feet in diameter, were seventeen negroes, seated back against the wall of earth, thus leaving the greater portion of the floor space free. Four small fires were burning, as if to designate the points of the compass, and between these stood the most repulsive-looking old negro the mate had ever seen. His wool was gray, and hung in matted locks nearly to his shoulders. His toothless mouth appeared to be the focus of a mass of wrinkles so deep as to destroy all semblance of a face, and gave his head the appearance of a bag with one end puckered by a drawing-string.

The skin of some animal served as a sort of petticoat for the old fellow, and around his neck was wound an odd sort of necklace, seemingly composed of small bones, the ends of which reached nearly to the ground. His feet were bare, as was the upper portion of his body, and in each hand he held a long knife, the blade dripping with blood.

When Jenkins first saw the hideous creature, he was standing silent and motionless, as if wrapped in deep thought; but after a few seconds he aroused himself, began walking around each fire in turn, muttering in guttural tones, and drawing the blade of the knife across his chest, causing the blood to flow in tiny streams with every stroke.

The spectators watched him as if spellbound. No one so much as moved, and Jenkins could have sworn that they were literally holding their breath.

Weaving his way in and out among the piles of burning wood, the old fellow continued to hack and cut at himself until the entire upper portion of his body was covered with blood, and then, crouching upon the earth, he gazed steadily into the flames for several moments.

Jenkins was about to turn away, believing the performance had come to a close, when the negro sprang to his feet with a quick, agile movement, and looked around upon his companions like one just awakening from a dream.

Now it could be told from the expression on the black faces that all believed they were about to hear some wonderful revelation, and after a certain length of time, probably made as long as possible in order to render his words the more impressive, the old man began to speak, slowly at first, but increasing in vehemence until it sounded more like the snarl of an angry animal than the result of a human voice.

He spoke in a language which Jenkins did not understand, but, under the circumstances, it was not difficult to fancy the long harangue had especial reference to the prisoners.

During at least fifteen minutes he continued in the most impassioned strain, and then ensued the same scene the mate had witnessed near the beach.

All present began the apparently meaningless dance and song around the fires, and Jenkins, thinking he had seen enough of this mummary, made his way back to those whom he knew were awaiting his return.

There was no thought of gathering wood as he crept cautiously through the passage, and when he reached the place allotted to the prisoners, all was dark and still.

“Are you here, boys?” he asked, in a low tone.

“Yes, you almost stepped on us. What are they doing over there? We heard the same kind of a chant that attracted our attention when we landed to begin this foolish trip which has ended so disastrously.”

“They are cutting those silly capers over again. This is what I saw.”

Then Jenkins gave a detailed account of all that had taken place in the chamber, from the time of his arrival, and when he had finished, Gil asked:

“What do you suppose they are up to?”

“I reckon Andy could tell you, for there can be no doubt but that these are a lot of voodoo worshipers, and the fellow with the knife must be a priest, or something of that kind.”

“Do you suppose they could know that we were in search of pirates’ treasure?” Nelse asked.

“Not unless some of them understand English, and heard us talking when we came ashore this morning.”

“That might be,” Gil said, half to himself; “but so long as we hadn’t found any, I can’t imagine why we should have been made prisoners.”

“Perhaps it was because we saw them at their dances,” Nelse suggested.

To Gil this did not seem a very plausible explanation, but since he could advance nothing better, it was accepted as the true reason.

“We have got to get out of here somehow,” Mr. Jenkins said, after a long pause. “They may not intend to do us any harm, but we won’t take the risk, if it can be avoided. Toward morning I’m going to make one more effort to find out how many are on guard at the entrance. If we could only get hold of our revolvers! I know who has them, and it is certain he isn’t with the mummers, therefore he must be outside.”

“With his eyes wide open, to prevent you either from escaping, or trying to get your own again.”

“We will see about that. We won’t make any move until nearly morning, therefore it’s a good idea to get some sleep, if possible. Lie down, and I’ll call you before daybreak.”



The conditions were not favorable for slumber, but yet the boys were so tired that in a very short time both were sleeping quietly, and the mate, seated near the entrance to the excavation, was keeping strict watch, with apparently not the slightest idea of closing his eyes.

He could hear the discordant chant from the inner cave, now rising high, and again dying away until it was lost in the distance, and this was continued so long that, despite his will, the unconsciousness of sleep came upon him.

---

## CHAPTER XV.

### A DISCOVERY.

While Mr. Jenkins slept, the fantastical worship in the inner cave was brought to a close; the party separated, each man going in a different direction across the island, as if to ascertain the general condition of affairs, and before they were reunited, the sun had risen.

The wind continued from the same quarter with unabated fury, and one needed only to see the trees bending before the blast to understand that the *Day Dream* could not come to an anchorage near that portion of the coast for some time to come.

The prisoners were not disturbed until nearly two hours after daybreak, and then the mate was brought to his feet very suddenly by a vicious kick from a burly negro, who had evidently been selected to act the part of guard.

Just for an instant Jenkins was disposed to show fight; but before he could do anything so rash, the thought of the consequences prevented him from raising his hands.

The situation was sufficiently grave without his making it worse by a useless show of resistance.

"Get up, lads!" he cried, wishing to arouse his companions before the brutal guard could deal them a blow, and the boys sprang to their feet instantly, not understanding where they were for several seconds, and then, as the unpleasant truth came slowly back to them, Gil asked:

"What's going on now?"

"I don't know, my boy; but this dark-complexioned gentleman has been trying his toes on my ribs in such an energetic fashion that I fancy we are to make some kind of a move. Whatever happens, keep close to me, and don't provoke the crowd by turning rusty when we're where we can't help ourselves."

"How is the weather?" Nelse asked.

“About the same as when we arrived here. There’s no chance of seeing the yacht to-day.”

This brief conversation was interrupted by the remainder of the black party, who now came from the outside, and the prisoners were made to understand by signs that they were to leave the cave.

With the boys on either side of him, Jenkins marched out, the huge black walking close behind the three, and the others clustered around in a manner which precluded any possibility of an escape.

The captors were evidently making their way back to the sea once more, and to both Gil and Nelse this fact was in some slight degree pleasing, since it seemed to bring them nearer the *Day Dream*.

“How is your head?” Gil asked, when they had walked a short distance in silence.

“It doesn’t feel particularly comfortable; but I reckon it’ll be all right after a while.”

“If we could bathe it, you would look better. That bloody handkerchief and the matted hair gives you the appearance of a veritable pirate.”

“I don’t feel like one, at all events,” Mr. Jenkins replied, with a laugh. “Just now I’m more of a cannibal than anything else, for it seems as if I could eat a donkey and then look over my shoulder for the rider.”

“Do you suppose they intend to starve us?”

“That’s a hard question to answer. It isn’t likely they’ll take any too good care of us, and we stand a chance of going hungry for some time to come.”

“Such a thing wouldn’t trouble me, providing I could see a way out of this scrape,” Nelse said, with a long-drawn sigh. “If the yacht can’t come to an anchor while the wind is so strong, we needn’t expect help to-day.”

“There’ll be a change in the weather when the sun sets,” the mate replied, encouragingly; but at the same time he did not believe his own statement.

The very old negro was evidently the chief of the party, and he led them through a narrow path, cut amid the dense tangle of foliage, until they arrived at the very spot where the prisoners had witnessed the dance around the pot while hidden among the trees.

Here they were met by the two aged and highly-decorated blacks, who had acted as masters of the ceremony on the previous evening.

All the repulsive-looking crowd evidently understood that they were in no immediate danger of being hunted out by those interested in the prisoners, for they moved with the utmost deliberation.

“The scoundrels know our shipmates can’t get here to-day, and are going to make the most out of the performance, whatever it may be,” Jenkins said, angrily, as two of the men began to lash him securely to a tree in such a manner that he could do no more than turn his head from side to side.

The boys were fastened in the same fashion, and so near together that it was possible for them to hear each other when speaking in a low tone of voice.

After the prisoners were thus disposed of, the blacks began to prepare breakfast by roasting over a bed of coals fifteen or twenty small animals, which resembled rabbits, the three leaders retiring to the depths of the thicket as if for consultation while this work was being done.

The cooks had not even taken the trouble to dress the game; but the odor of the roasting flesh was so appetizing, and the prisoners were so hungry, that all three waited with the liveliest impatience for the meal to be made ready.

“I’m certain I can eat a whole rabbit; but I don’t suppose we’ll be allowed to have as much as we want,” Nelse said, watching the operations eagerly.

“We had better not count on regularly filling ourselves up,” Jenkins replied, grimly, as a very unpleasant suspicion began to creep into his mind.

When the feast was prepared, the old men were summoned, the remainder of the party standing at a respectful distance until they had satisfied their hunger, and then all hands set about devouring the food in a literally savage fashion.

Holding it in their hands and smearing themselves with fat and blood, until their black faces looked even more hideous than before, the men gorged themselves, crunching the smaller bones as dogs would have done, and only when the last morsel had disappeared did they cease.

Meanwhile, the prisoners could do no more than gaze at the revolting spectacle, which, fortunately, partially caused them to forget their hunger,

and not a word was spoken until Jenkins, seeing that his companions were rapidly giving way to despair, tried to arouse them.

“It’s no very great hardship to go hungry for twenty-four, or even forty-eight hours,” he said, cheerily. “If we think of eating, it’ll only make matters worse, so let’s sheer off on some other tack.”

“That is not so easily done,” Nelse replied, gloomily.

“I don’t know about it. Look around and see what an odd sort of a forest this is, compared to such as we have at home.”

“We’ve had time to be pretty well acquainted with it since landing yesterday. There doesn’t seem to be anything strange here, except it is the big palm tree near where the old scoundrels are sitting. That——”

Gil would have started to his feet in surprise, had it not been for the bonds, as he cried:

“It is the very tree we were hunting for! There are none others as tall, and it’s surely old enough to have served as a landmark when our chart was made.”

“I believe you are right, my boy,” the mate said, after a short pause. “It would be strange if these villains have shown us just what we wanted to find.”

“I can’t see that it will do us any good, even if we knew a big pile of gold was absolutely buried in the immediate vicinity,” Nelse replied, grumblingly; but at the same time he continued to gaze at the palm, and it could be seen that, for the moment, the pangs of hunger were forgotten.

The possibility of their having finally arrived at the desired place, through no inclination or volition of their own, was sufficient to furnish them with a fruitful topic of conversation, and but little attention was paid to the blacks until the departure of several of the younger men caused Gil to ask:

“Where do you suppose they are going?”

“Most likely to watch out for the yacht. It isn’t certain your father won’t make an attempt to put in here in search of us, although I don’t think one of our boats could land, and they want to make sure of not being interrupted.”

During the next half-hour the negroes remained idle, lounging near the scene of the feast, and then the messengers returned.

Whatever report they made must have been satisfactory, for immediately the fire was rebuilt, the pot slung on two crotched sticks, and the old fellows took up their station nearby, as if to repeat the mummary of the previous evening.

Now the prisoners understood that they were to take some part in the ceremony, for three of the men stood directly in front of them, while the priests began once more the doleful chant.

“They are going to kill us,” Nelse cried, in alarm, but forced to remain motionless before the blacks, each of whom held a short-bladed knife in his hands.

Mr. Jenkins no longer attempted to cheer his companions. He believed, as Nelse did, and with good reason.

While the old men sang, those who had evidently been selected as executioners advanced slowly, brandishing their weapons, and making gestures, while the remainder of the party stood nearby, gazing intently, as if at some fascinating spectacle.

Neither of the prisoners spoke. Death seemed so close at hand that the numbness of despair was upon them, and each watched the gleaming circles of steel as the knives came slowly toward them.

When the three men were not more than five feet away from him, Gil fancied he heard a slight noise directly in the rear, as if some one was lighting a match; but since none of the blacks paid any attention to it, he fancied he was mistaken, and tried to prepare himself in some slight degree for the supreme moment.

Now the circle of spectators grew smaller; the old men forced their way through, that they also might witness what was possibly one of their fiendish rites, and the gleaming steel almost touched the victims.

The two boys closed their eyes that they should not see the deadly blow when it was delivered, and Jenkins believed he had not many seconds to live, when a singular, hissing noise was heard directly behind the helpless ones.

Instantly it seemed that a shaft of fire came from the foliage, with a scream as of some living creature.

Opening their eyes suddenly, the boys saw this thing of flame tear its way through the crowd, throwing sparks right and left, and striking two of the blacks with sufficient force to hurl them to the ground.

The negroes fled with loud yells of terror, as the “thing,” apparently caught by the foliage, continued to send forth showers of flame, and before the last man disappeared, both Gil and Nelse had fainted.

The strain upon them had been too great, and over-taxed nature gave way beneath it.

---

## CHAPTER XVI.

### ANDY.

At this particular time Jenkins paid but little attention to the boys. He fancied the sudden appearance of the stream of fire was simply a portion of the horrible ceremonies, and believed the negroes' terror to be only simulated.

When the last black disappeared in the foliage, a noise directly behind him caused him to look for their return from that quarter, and his surprise can be better imagined than described when he saw Andy standing in front of him, his wide mouth open to its fullest extent in silent enjoyment of the complete rout.

"Where in the name of all that's wonderful did you come from?" he cried, and would have followed this with other questions, had not the cook whispered hurriedly:

"Dere ain't no time ter tork now, kase we's boun' ter be outer dis yere place before dem debbils cum back. Don' speak a word."

With remarkable celerity, Andy cut the bonds of vines, and while Jenkins was rubbing his arms and legs to restore the circulation, the cook released the boys.

It was as if the sudden change of position served to restore them to consciousness, and by the time the cook had made his arrangements for flight, they were aware of the rescue.

Gil would have followed Jenkins' example, and overwhelmed the negro with questions; but the mate whispered:

"Keep quiet, now; we can hear all about it later."

Andy's first care was to gather up the rope-like vines and throw them on the fire, after which he ran into the thicket, returning a few seconds later with a large package wrapped in sailcloth.

"I'se gwine erhead, an' you'se mus' cum erlong mighty fas' ef yer don' wan' ter see dem imps ergin."



Without waiting for a reply, he started toward the coast to the westward, running so rapidly, laden though he was, that the others had quite as much as they could do to keep pace with him.

During fully half an hour the flight was continued, and just when Nelse was on the point of saying that he could hold out no longer, however great might be the danger, Andy halted in the midst of a palmetto thicket.

“We’s gwine ter stay hyar fur erwhile,” he said, speaking with difficulty, because of his heavy breathing; “but dere mus’ be a mighty snug watch kept, kase dem debbils are boun’ ter fin’ out wha’s been ergoin’ on.”

“Tell us how you happen to be here, and where the yacht is?” Gil asked, as soon as it was possible to speak.

Andy’s story, interspersed as it was with threats against and commentaries upon the voodooos, would require too great a space to be related in his own words; but the substance was as follows:

After the boat had returned to the yacht, and the sailors reported they could find no trace of the missing ones, Captain Mansfield was utterly at a loss to account for the singular disappearance. He knew there were no wild beasts on the island that could have attacked and killed the entire party, therefore it seemed positive the mate and the boys were detained by human beings.

To search for them in the darkness would have been useless, therefore he intended to wait until morning, when he proposed going on shore himself; but the coming of the gale prevented this plan from being carried into effect.

It was absolutely necessary the yacht should be gotten under way, and, in the absence of the mate, equally essential for the safety of all on board, that the captain should remain in command.

Knowing they might be obliged to remain away two or three days, and distressed at the thought of leaving the missing ones to the mercy of those who had probably captured them, Captain Mansfield called for some of the crew to volunteer to go on shore and prosecute a search during his absence.

None of the sailors cared to venture, and then it was that Andy offered his services, which were accepted the more eagerly because of all on board, he

could probably accomplish more, owing to the partial acquaintance he had with the natives of this and the adjoining islands.

He took a small amount of food with him, and, in addition, a number of signal rockets with which to make his whereabouts known as soon as it should be possible for the yacht to come in shore again. A revolver and a dozen cartridges, together with a canteen of water, made up the full list of his stores.

It was only after the greatest difficulty that the sailors succeeded in setting him ashore, for the sea began to run high immediately the wind sprang up, and he remained in the thicket near the beach until sunrise, when, almost before he was ready to commence the search, the voodooes' chant told him where the prisoners were likely to be found.

Creeping cautiously up to where a view of the party could be had, he realized that it would be the height of folly to make an attack single-handed, and remained inactive, fully believing the prisoners were to be killed, until he chanced to think of the signal rockets.

It was a poor experiment upon which to depend as a means of saving the lives of three people; but, fortunately, it succeeded admirably, and there was no question but that the blacks fancied the sparks of fire had been produced by some supernatural agency.

"How did it happen that you dared venture on shore?" Gil asked, when the story was ended. "You said nothing could tempt you to run the risk of meeting the voodooes, and there can be no mistake about the men who came so near killing us."

"I'se dun gone got er charm, an' when de sailors wouldn't cum ershore, dere was nuffin lef' but fur me ter do my level bes'."

"And it couldn't be improved upon," Jenkins said, as he patted the old fellow's woolly head.

"It was mos'ly de charm," Andy replied, modestly.

"That had precious little to do with it," the mate said, emphatically. "The rocket and the man behind it did the business, and a thousand charms wouldn't have frightened those villains away so quickly."

“What made you spend so much time burning the vines with which we were tied?” Nelse asked. “They couldn’t have been used again.”

“I wasn’ erfeared ob dat, honey; but we wanter make dem debbils t’ink dat de ghostes dun took you off, ropes an’ all.”

“And it was a good idea, Andy,” Jenkins said. “Now, if we can only keep them at a proper distance until the yacht heaves in sight, we shall be all right.”

“I’se gwine ter dribe de whole bilin’ offer dis yere island,” the old man said, decidedly, much as if he was proposing a very simple piece of business.

“How do you count on doing that?” Gil asked. “You said they could do no end of mischief, even when hundreds of miles away?”

“I’se got de charm, honey, an’ I’se got de rockets. Ef we kin creep up on ’em once, I’ll start annudder fiery sarpent what’ll make de voodooos t’ink de las’ day hab cum.”

“If that could be done, we would have a chance to find out whether the pirates’ treasure is hidden near the old palm tree,” Nelse cried, excitedly.

“Now, honey, don’ you’se go ter speckerlatin’ erbout dat any mo’. It’s wha’s got us all in dis yere trubble, an we’se gwine ter keep clear ob it, ef I’se got a vote in de bizness.”

“There’s plenty of time to talk about that,” Jenkins interrupted. “The villains are here yet; it isn’t any sure thing they can be frightened away, and while they remain, we shan’t be able to do much of anything but keep ourselves out of sight.”

“Isn’t it about time we thought of eating something?” Nelse asked, suddenly. “Andy said he brought food from the yacht, and I would like to have a bite.”

“Take it all, honey, de ole man ain’ wantin’ any now,” and the cook unstrapped a well-filled haversack from his shoulders. “I’se had what’ll do me fur de nex’ four days.”

“We’ll make an equal division whether there is any chance of your growing hungry or not,” Gil said, as he began to distribute the food. “It is necessary

that we husband it as much as possible, unless we can count on seeing father pretty soon.”

“He won’t be able to make this portion of the coast until the wind blows itself out,” the mate replied, “and I advise that we go on short rations to-day.”

This remark was hardly necessary, since the amount of provisions Andy had brought did not suffice to make one satisfactory meal for the party, and every crumb was devoured before the hunger of either was more than half satisfied.

When the haversack of canvas had been emptied, the cook said, as he examined the wound on Jenkins’ head:

“I’se gwine ter fix yer up a little, Marse Jenkins, an’ den we’d better light out ob dis yere place, kase dere’s no tellin’ when dat crowd’s cumin’ back ter see wha’ made de sparks fly.”

The mate would have objected to Andy’s spending any time on what he considered a trifling matter; but the cook did not wait for remonstrances. Using the water in the canteen, regardless of whether his companions were thirsty, he first bathed the wound, and then bandaged it properly with strips torn from Gil’s shirt, after which he said, with an air of pride:

“I ’lows you’se gwine ter git ober dat little scratch widout much trouble, an’ ef dere’s no objection, we oughter keep on till we light on a better place dan dis yere bunch ob trees.”

After the generalship he had shown, there was no reason why the cook should not take command of the party, and he assumed the leadership by setting out at a rapid pace toward the coast, the others following close behind him.

Not until they were within sight of the sea at a point two or three miles from where the boys and the mate were made prisoners did he halt, and then it was to say:

“I’se gwine ter skurmish roun’ fur ter see whar dem debbils am hidin’.”

“Why shouldn’t we go with you?” the mate asked.

“Kase dere’s no tellin’ how de charm’s gwine ter work fur all han’s, an’ de res’ ob de crowd had better stay hyar till de ole man gits back.”

“The boys can take care of themselves for a while, and I’ll keep you company,” Jenkins said, decidedly. “We can’t afford to run the chance of an accident just now.”

Andy did not fancy being obliged to take a protector with him; but the mate was determined to share all the danger, and the two plunged into the thicket, after impressing upon Gil and Nelse the necessity of remaining hidden during their absence.

---

## **CHAPTER XVII.**

### **A SUCCESSFUL SCHEME.**

When the mate and cook started out to ascertain the whereabouts of the natives, the former carried the revolver, and the latter had strapped to his back the bundle of signal rockets.

At the time their only idea was to learn what the blacks were doing, and to that end Andy led the way back toward the cave, circling around in such a manner as would permit an approach from the south.

After traveling at a rapid pace for twenty minutes or more, the cook came to a halt, exclaiming as he did so:

“Dere’s no use tuckerin’ our legs all out at de start, kase dere’s plenty ob time.”

“How is it that you know this island so well? You move around as if you had always lived here.”

Andy tried to evade the question by speaking of the weather and the possibility that the yacht could approach the northern coast by the following morning; but Jenkins insisted on an answer, and finally the old fellow said:

“I mought jes’ as well tell de trufe; but I don’ hanker after habin’ de capt’in know erbout it.”

“Have you ever taken a hand in this voodoo business?” Jenkins asked, sternly, as he watched the old man’s face closely.

“Nebber! Nebber! I’s done gone bin in a good many scrapes, but nuffin like dat. Six or ten years ago, when I was young an’ flighty like, annuder colored man an’ me runned away frum a brig what we’d shipped in, an’ hid hyar. De voodoos cum mighty nigh killin’ us erfore we got took off, an’ dat’s how I’s sich a pertic’lar ’quaintance wid de island.”

“Then you have seen these fellows before?”

“Ef dey ain’ jes’ de same, dey looks a drefful sight like em.”

“And you knew where the cave was before I said anything about it?”

“Deed I didn’t, fo’ a fac’. I nebber seen it; but I reckon it was ’cause we kept mighty near de beach all de time watchin’ fur a vessel.”

“What did you find to eat?”

“Dere’s plenty ob oysters ’roun’ de shore, an’ it’s a prime place fur turtles. Dere ain’t no danger ob goin’ hungry ef de *Day Dream* don’ come back fur a week.”

“I’m glad to hear that, for the yacht may be away some time—I don’t see any signs that this wind will haul around very soon—and the food supply promises to become serious to us. If you are rested, let’s push on; the boys may grow frightened if we stay too long.”

Andy acted upon this suggestion at once, and the two did not halt again until they had reached a point from which a view of the entrance to the cave could be had, while they were screened by the foliage.

From the first glance it appeared as if the blacks had not returned to their underground hiding-place; but after waiting five minutes, a woolly head was seen at the entrance for an instant, and then drawn back very quickly, as if its owner did not dare to expose any portion of his precious body very long at a time.

“I’s gwine ter plump one ob dese yere rockets right inter dat hole,” Andy whispered, as he began to unwrap the package.

“Don’t do anything so foolish,” the mate replied in the same cautious tone. “They would then see the stick, and know it wasn’t the work of supernatural beings. Besides, we can use them to better advantage by waiting until the whole gang come outside.”

“Wha’ you’s mean by dat?”

“Some of them have still got the revolvers taken from the boys an’ me. If we could manage to put our hands on them it wouldn’t be much of a job to hold the crowd in check for as long as we wanted to stay.”

“But how’s we gwine ter do dat wid de rockets?”

“I don’t know; we’ll wait a while, and perhaps something may turn up in our favor.”

Andy was eager to continue his work of terrifying the blacks, but he managed to restrain his impatience, as Jenkins requested, and during the next hour the two remained silent and almost motionless, watching intently for the appearance of their enemies.

During this time two or three of the party had peeped out several times, without showing any more of their bodies than was absolutely necessary, and Andy had begun to grumble because of the delay, when the entire crowd emerged.

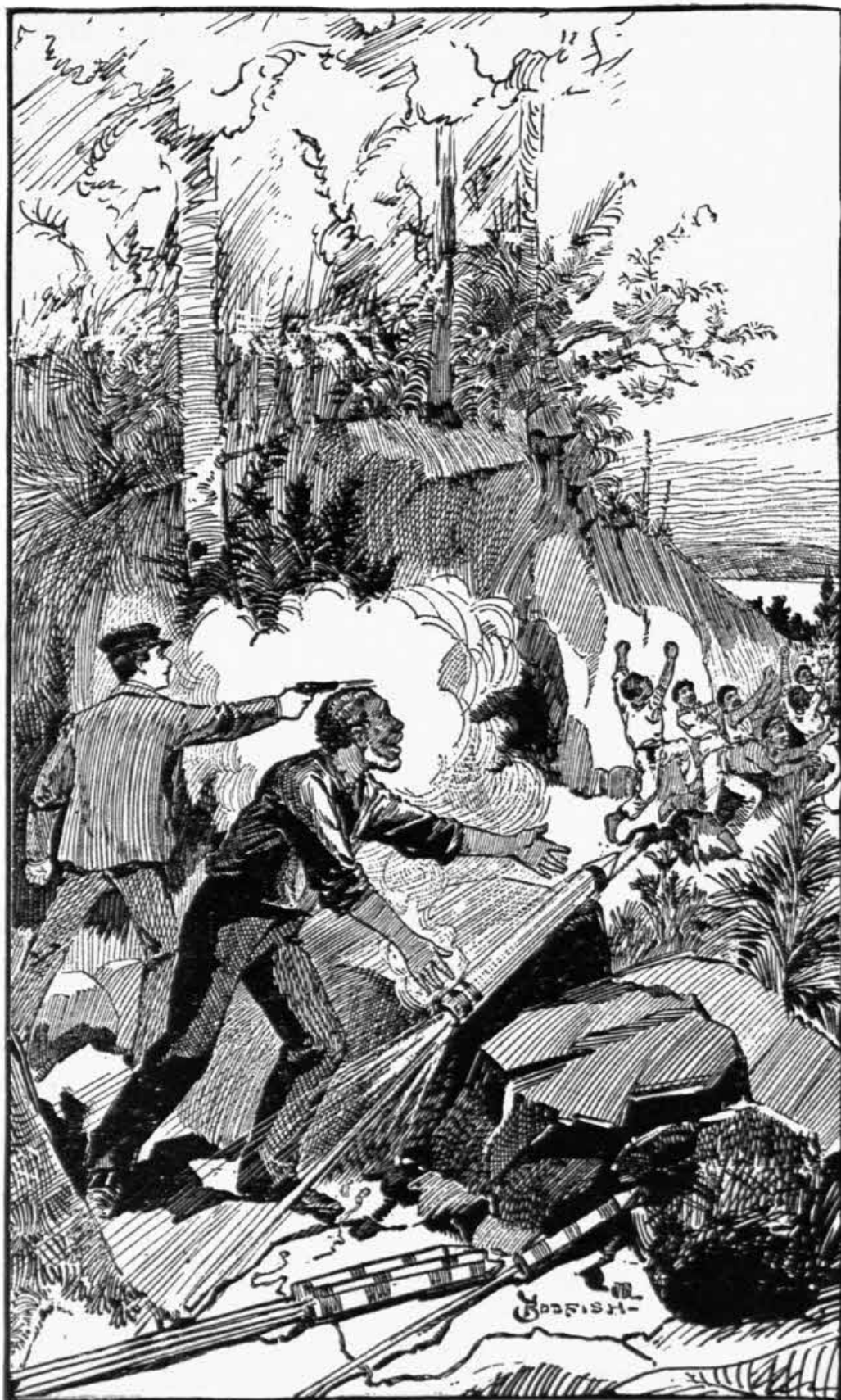
They were walking in couples, with the old fellows, who had put on a yet larger supply of paint, leading the way, and, from the look of anxiety on their faces, it was plainly seen that even the alleged priests felt very uncomfortable in mind.

Andy held one of the rockets at such an angle as would send it in the midst of the party when it was fired, resting the base against a tree to avoid the recoil; but Jenkins prevented him from lighting the match until the crowd were a dozen yards beyond the entrance to the cave.

“Now give me your revolver,” the mate whispered, “and be sure to take good aim. If you miss, all that has been done will be wasted.”

The old darky, probably remembering when he had been chased by this or a similar gang, adjusted the rocket very carefully, and then ignited the fuse. At the same instant Jenkins discharged every barrel of the revolver, aiming low to avoid killing any outright, and this portion of the scheme was a perfect success.





**“Andy adjusted the rocket and ignited the fuse.” [See page 136.](#)**

The rocket plowed its way through the entire line from the rear, as if it had come out of the cave, and no less than five were thrown to the ground, while it could be seen that two of the others had received the attention of bullets.

Those who were uninjured fled at the utmost speed into the thicket, screaming with terror, and heeding not the cries of their companions, who were begging for assistance.

The leaders yelled louder than their followers, and thought only of their own safety, while all hands dropped everything which might impede their flight.

In the foliage a short distance from where the overturned ones were lying, the rocket, caught among the branches, hissed and sparkled, causing the most intense desire on the part of those remaining to leave that particular portion of the island as quickly as possible.

While scrambling to their feet they did not cease to scream at the full strength of their lungs, and once they were in a condition to run, every man sought the shelter of the bushes.

“Now is our time,” Jenkins said, hurriedly. “You rush out there and hunt for the weapons—I fancy some of them were dropped during the scramble—while I see what there is in the cave that we might want.”

Andy ran like a deer in one direction, while Jenkins went in another, and five minutes later the two returned laden with the spoils.

The old darky brought into the thicket two revolvers with one ammunition belt, four freshly-killed animals, such as the blacks had roasted for breakfast, and three murderous-looking knives.

Jenkins found two knives, a couple of hatchets, a small bag filled with yams, and a spade, he saying, as he held up the last-mentioned implement for Andy’s inspection:

“I don’t know what we want of such a thing, but I was determined to bring away as much as possible, and it may come in handy before we leave.”

“We’s e boun’ ter make ’em pay fur de rockets, an’ de spade will count on de bill. Hadn’ we better mosey ’long to de boys? Dey’ll be erbout wild ef we don’ cum mighty soon.”

“Lead the way, and I’ll follow; but be careful, for it won’t do to let those fellows have a glimpse of us.”

Andy understood only too well that their safety depended upon remaining under cover, and he conducted the mate back to the place where the boys had been left, by a circuitous route toward the east.

“I’s e ’lowin’ dat dem debbils hab all gone ober to the souf shore, kase it’s frum dere dey kin strike across to de big island, so all we has ter do is keep on our end, ef we don’ wan’ ter see ’em.”

When the two were with the boys again nearly five hours had elapsed since the time of their departure, and both Gil and Nelse were decidedly disturbed in mind.

“I had just decided that we ought to go out in search of you,” the former said, as the cook and Jenkins threw themselves on the ground nearly exhausted by the long, rapid tramp.

“That would have been a foolish proceeding, even if we had got into trouble,” the mate said, with a laugh. “If the scoundrels could down us, it is safe to say you’d hardly been able to render any assistance. It’s all right, though, an’ we can count on being left to ourselves until morning at the earliest.”

Then Jenkins told the boys of what had been done, and once more Nelse and Gil began to have hopes that a search might be made for the supposed treasure.

“Can we have something to eat now?” Nelse asked.

“Wait till dark, honey, an’ den I’s e gwine ter git up a reg’lar jubelee feast. We kin build a fire, an’ dey can’t see de smoke.”

“The flames will show more plainly.”

“Dey won’t, kase I’s e de boy what knows how ter fix sich t’ings.”

They were well aware that Andy understood best what should be done, and both tried to wait patiently until the time when their hunger could be

appeased without too great danger.

When the sun set the strength of the wind seemed to increase, and Jenkins stated as his opinion that another twenty-four hours must elapse before the yacht could be brought to the old anchorage.

“It don’t make so much difference, now that the blacks are frightened, and we can defend ourselves in reasonably good shape,” he said, cheerily. “Unless they contrive to surprise us, I’ll answer for it that we will hold our own against twice the number.”

“At the same time I’d rather be on board the yacht until we know they have left the island,” Nelse said, with a feeble attempt at a smile.

“So had I; but since it is necessary to wait, we might just as well look on the bright side of the affair. How long before you are going to dish up some of those rabbits, Andy?”

“I’s ready ter make a start now, an’ dat spade is gwine ter come in mighty handy. Ef you’ll dig a hole, I’ll mosey ’roun’ fur wood.”

It was dark, not so much as a star appearing in the inky blackness of the clouds, and the little party could safely move to and fro at will, provided they were careful not to make a noise.

All hands assisted the cook, whose fireplace was so far beneath the surface that the flames could easily be screened from view by bushes, and never had the boys sat down to a more thoroughly enjoyable meal than this one of roasted rabbits—more properly speaking, agoutis—and yams.

---

## CHAPTER XVIII.

### TREASURE HUNTING.

In this world, when one desire has been satisfied another springs up, as the boys learned after eating a hearty supper, for as soon as their hunger was appeased both felt the necessity of slumber.

“It seems as if I hadn’t been to sleep for a week,” Nelse said, with a yawn, as he stretched himself out at full length where the bushes would screen him from the wind.

“There is nothing to prevent your getting all you want now,” the mate replied. “So scoop in a full supply.”

“Don’t you think it is necessary to stand watch?” Gil asked.

“Andy and I will attend to that business.”

“But we ought to do our share.”

“If we are here to-morrow night, you shall take your turn at it; but just at this time it is important to keep a sharp lookout, and, tired as you boys are, I wouldn’t like to trust the matter in your hands.”

“You needn’t be afraid of our going to sleep when it is necessary to keep awake.”

“There are some things a fellow can’t prevent, no matter how good his intentions may be, so we won’t waste any more time in a discussion.”

Jenkins spoke in such a decided tone that the boys understood it would be useless to continue the conversation, and in a very few moments both were sleeping soundly, while the mate and Andy stood most vigilant guard.

Several times during the night the rustling of the leaves or sighing of the wind caused the watchers to make short excursions from the camping-place to learn if the enemy were in the vicinity; but nothing of an alarming nature was discovered, and when Gil and Nelse awakened the general condition of affairs was such as to give them renewed courage.

The windstorm had cleared away, the sun was shining brightly in an unclouded sky, and the morning breeze was sufficiently strong to admit of the yacht's working her way up the coast.

"Father should be here before sunset!" cried Gil, as he sprang to his feet.

"You are right, my boy," the mate said, cheerily. "I allow that she'll be at the old anchorage, if the breeze holds, before three o'clock."

"Have you seen anything of the voodooos?"

"Not so much as a hair. Andy's just about starting off now to learn if they have gone back to the cave."

The old darky, who was standing near making his preparations for the journey, did not speak. The expression on his face told how grave and dangerous he considered the mission to be, and at such a time he evidently believed it beneath his dignity to enter into conversation.

The precious rockets he was fastening over his shoulder were to be used in case of a great emergency, and the boys noticed that he frequently pressed the bosom of his shirt, as if to assure himself of the safety of some object.

"I'll bet he has got his charm there," Nelse whispered to Gil. "I've noticed that he keeps his hand over that portion of his shirt more than half the time."

"We'll make him show it to us when we get on board the yacht once more."

"Be careful of yourself," Jenkins said, in a low tone, as Andy turned to leave the camping-place. "Don't use the rockets unless it is absolutely necessary, and come back as soon as possible."

"Dere ain' much danger ob my lingerin' 'roun' whar dat crowd is," the old man replied, as he disappeared among the foliage.

"Now, boys, I'm going to skirmish for some oysters," Jenkins said, when they were alone. "Here is one of the revolvers, and in case of any trouble, fire two shots; but don't expose yourself by leaving this thicket."

"Haven't we got enough for breakfast without your leaving us?" Nelse asked.

“No; our appetites were too good last night for anything to be left over from the small amount we managed to get from the niggers. We can——”

“Bress de Lawd!” Andy shouted, in a loud tone, from a distance, and, as the little party ran in the direction indicated, they heard him cry:

“De hull bilin’ ob dem debbils am makin’ fur de odder islan’ as fas’ as dey kin row. De rockets done gone did it!” Hardly daring to believe the good news, Jenkins and the boys kept on at full speed until they were at the beach, where a view of the sea to the westward could be had, and then their excitement was little less than that displayed by the old darky.

Far away on the water were three boats, one of them probably the *Day Dream*’s tender, loaded with men, who were working at the oars vigorously, and there was no longer any question but that their enemies had been literally frightened away.

“De fiery sarpents was too much for dem!” Andy cried, triumphantly, as he went through with a series of contortions, evidently intended as a dance of joy. “We’s done gone got de hull islan’ fur ourselbes.”

“It isn’t well to show them that we are nothing more than men,” Jenkins said, as he pulled the old darky into the thicket. “If they get an idea it was only a trick, we may have our hands full before the yacht can come up the coast. The boys and I will go for something to eat, while you keep them in sight until they land on Hayti. Keep just inside the thicket so you can’t be seen.”

Andy threw off the burden, for the rockets were useless, now the blacks had abandoned the island, and obeyed the order given, while the others went toward the northern coast, where they would be screened from view of those in the boats.

Here plenty of shell fish were found, and before the old darky returned a most appetizing breakfast had been cooked.

His report was decidedly encouraging. He had seen the blacks land on the adjoining island, and watched the boats sufficiently long to assure himself that there was no danger of an immediate return.

“Dey’s done gone runned off fur erwhile,” he said, in a tone of satisfaction, “an’ we’s gwine ter lebe dis yere place erfore dey wants ter cum back.”

“Did you see anything of the yacht?” Jenkins asked.

“Not a hooter; I reckon she’s done gone ’round de udder side ob de islan’, an’ we’s gwine ter see her when she’s lettin’ go de cable.”

“I reckon you’re right, Andy, and since there’s nothing more to fear, we can spend the time as we choose.”

“If that is the case,” Gil said, in a serious tone, “Nelse and I want to make one search for the treasure.”

All Andy’s fears were aroused at this mention of the pirates’ gold, as could be told by his face; but he made no other protest than to say:

“We’s bin in all dis yere trubble jes’ on ’count ob dat, an’ it stands to reason we oughter lebe it go.”

“But what harm will be done, if we spend the time while waiting for the yacht in searching for it? When she arrives we shall go on board, whether anything has been found or not, and there can surely no trouble come of that.”

The old darky made no reply, but he shook his head in an ominous manner while his hand rested on his shirt, under which the boys believed the famous “charm” was hidden.

“Have you got the chart?” Jenkins asked. For reply, Gil took the piece of paper and strip of wood from his jacket, saying, as he handed them to the mate:

“The blacks didn’t think these were of sufficient value to steal, otherwise we might have been obliged to give up the search almost before it was begun.”

“An’ dat would er bin a mighty good t’ing,” Andy muttered, without so much as turning his head.

For at least the twentieth time the mate pored over the document, and then he said:

“Suppose we have one try for it. That can surely do no harm, and it will serve to occupy our time while waiting for the yacht.”



As may be supposed, the boys were more than willing to act on this suggestion, and Jenkins immediately began making preparations for moving the small amount of stores to the place where they had so nearly met their death.

Andy assisted in the removal, but it could be seen that he was far from being pleased with the proposition, and nothing but a wholesome fear of the mate prevented him from giving words to that which was in his mind.

“I take it that the letters ‘F’ and ‘S’ are the initials of the man’s name who drew this thing,” Jenkins said, when they were at the old palm. “We’ll allow that, at all events, an’ try for the course as marked out—18—8 North, and 5 West from the tree.”

“Will you take it in feet or fathoms?” Nelse asked.

“Feet, as a starter, an’ if the yacht hasn’t hove in sight after we’ve dug at that spot, it won’t do any harm to try fathoms.”

“But without a compass you can’t be positive as to the direction.”

“It’s so early in the morning that the sun will serve us for that, I reckon, an’ we can verify the course after your father comes.”

Andy had thrown himself on the ground in the shade of the foliage, his hand clutching the mysterious something under his shirt, as if to show he did not take part in the dangerous investigation; but the others paid no attention to him, and Jenkins paced off the supposed distance in the gravest manner possible.

“I’sse boun’ ter warn you dat we’sse gwine ter hab trubble, ef you’sse hunts fur de gol’,” Andy said, solemnly. “Better lebe it alone, an’ wait fur de yacht.”

“Don’t be a fool,” Jenkins replied, petulantly. “We can’t afford to lose so good a chance as this.”

“Den I ain’ in it,” and the old darky closed his eyes, as if to shut out even the movements of his companions.

As nearly as he could judge from the position of the sun, the mate measured the distance, and then designated the spot where the boys should begin to dig.

“It’s likely to be pretty far down,” he said, as Gil seized the spade, “an’ we’ll take turns. You boys work till you’re tired, an’ then I’ll do my trick.”

Gil set about the task in the firm belief that but a few moments would be necessary to unearth the treasure, and Nelse watched eagerly every turn of the earth.

Twenty minutes of such exercise under a hot sun was enough for the treasure hunter, and then his companion relieved him, Jenkins waiting until both should be tired, when he would wield the spade.

Meanwhile Andy had wandered toward the beach, as if afraid even to remain in the locality, and just at the moment when Nelse was ready to give up in favor of the mate, the old darky shouted:

“Hyar comes two boats, an’ dey looks like de *Day Dream*’s tenders!”

---

## CHAPTER XIX.

### THE WRECK.

When Andy made this startling announcement the treasure seekers abandoned their work to run with all speed to the beach where the statement could be verified by the evidence of their own senses.

Two boats were coming up the western shore of the island, both loaded nearly to the gunwales, and evidently heading for the place where the little party was standing.

“There’s no question about those being the *Day Dream*’s tenders,” Jenkins said, after a long scrutiny. “White boats with gilt ribbons are not so plentiful in these waters that there can be more than two sets near here.”

“I suppose father has anchored further down the coast, and is coming up to look for us,” Gil said, in a tone of satisfaction.

The mate made no reply, but a troubled look came over his face, and this deepened into positive dismay as Andy said:

“It beats me why dey’s done gone anchored wid a fine breeze what would bring de yacht up hyar like a race hoss.”

“Perhaps they saw the blacks when the other boats left the island, and want to keep them in sight,” Nelse suggested.

This was not a very reasonable proposition, but Gil accepted it, since he could think of nothing better, and Jenkins stood silent and motionless until the occupants of the crafts could be distinguished. Then he muttered half to himself:

“If they have left the craft at anchor, not one has remained behind to look out for her, because the whole crew is here.”

Gil was about to ask what he meant, when they were hailed by Captain Mansfield from the leading craft.

“Ahoy on shore!”

“Ay, ay, sir!” the mate replied.

“Are the boys all right?”

“Sound and hearty, sir, and none the worse for havin’ stopped ashore a little too long. Where is the yacht?”

“Off Pearl Point in forty fathoms of water.”

“Is she wrecked?” Gil asked in dismay.

“I’ll give you the particulars when we get ashore,” Captain Mansfield replied. “It’s too hard work to tell much of a story while it is necessary to shout.”

“De voodooos done gone did it,” Andy said, in a low tone. “I ’lowed dis yere was gwine ter happen when I brung de charm ashore, but de captain ’sisted on some ob de crew cumin’, an’ it had ter be done.”

“I won’t lay it on the voodooos,” Gil replied, mournfully, “but it is certainly true that we’ve had nothing but bad luck from the moment we decided to hunt for the pirates’ treasure.”

“An’ you’s gwine ter hab wuss ef dis yere diggin’ is kep’ up. It’s a pow’ful bad plan ter fool ’round’ whar dem debbils hang out.”

The boys were not in the humor to discuss this phase of the affair at this moment. Both felt as if they were personally responsible for the disaster, because of having urged Captain Mansfield to allow them to spend a certain length of time on the island, and the knowledge that all hands would now be forced to remain at this place was far from cheering.

These gloomy thoughts were in their minds when the bows of the boats were run up on the sand, and after the first hearty greetings had been exchanged the brief story of the wreck was told.

After leaving her anchorage the *Day Dream* was headed down the coast for the purpose of running into Gonaive, where a commodious and safe harbor would be found.

The night was dark, the gale so furious that the little craft could not look up to it as she should have done, and a miscalculation as to the distance run caused her to be brought around just in time to strike the reefs west of Pearl Point.

By what, at that moment, was believed to be a rare piece of good fortune, she slipped off into deep water after the first shock, but the sharp coral had rent and torn her timbers so cruelly that all efforts to keep her afloat were useless.

It was possible to work her under the lee of the land, where she was sheltered, to a certain degree, from the angry blast, and the crew took to the boats, with such supplies as could be gotten at in the hurry and excitement of the moment, the jaunty little craft going to the bottom before they had had time to row more than a dozen yards from her side.

“When the gale partially abated we started for this island to satisfy ourselves that you were safe, and now I propose to make Cuba in one of the boats, taking with me a couple of men,” Captain Mansfield said, when his story was concluded. “We have got canvas enough for a small sail, and once at Havana there will be no trouble about chartering a craft to run over here.”

“Is it safe to go so far in the tender?” Gil asked, in alarm.

“The distance to the coast of Cuba is only seventy miles, and, with a fair wind, we should be able to make that in less than twenty-four hours.”

“But why not take all hands?”

“I would like to if our boats were large enough, but with these cockle-shells it couldn’t be done. The only question to be considered is whether you will be safe here. Tell me what happened after you landed?”

Gil gave his father a detailed account of their adventures, Jenkins and Andy adding to the story from time to time, and when it was concluded Captain Mansfield said:

“Andy’s idea of using the rockets was a capital one, and I don’t think we need have any fear the blacks will return for some time, but if they should, your crowd is large enough to resist an ordinary attack. I don’t expect to be away more than four days, and you can surely hold out as long as that.”

“Am I to go with you, sir?” Jenkins asked.

“No; you must stay here in charge of the party, and the boys are to obey your orders as they would mine. Now we will see what can be done toward getting breakfast, and then set about making ready for the voyage.”

Andy immediately took up the duties as cook, and while he and the boys went for a supply of shell fish, Jenkins and one of the sailors started in search of water, for, now that the party was so large, a greater amount of the precious liquid would be needed.

Captain Mansfield lost no time in making his preparations. He was desirous of taking advantage of the first fair wind, and therefore everything was done on this day. Even the water and provisions were put on board the tender, so that it would be only necessary to launch her when the proper moment should arrive.

It was yet quite early in the afternoon when the work was finished, and Gil urged his father to go with him and Nelse to the old palm.

“If we are to stay here three or four days there is no reason why we shouldn’t continue to hunt for the treasure, since it will serve to occupy the time, but Andy believes something terrible will happen if we do such a thing.”

“If you find any pleasure in digging, keep at it, by all means,” Captain Mansfield said, laughingly, “but I don’t care to walk even a dozen yards for the purpose of seeing an old tree. Andy’s foolish talk needn’t trouble you, for it is merest nonsense to think a voodoo can do more than any other person.”

Gil wanted to get his father’s advice as to the best method of testing the correctness of the chart, but all pleadings were in vain.

The captain refused to make any suggestion whatever, and the subject was soon dropped, as the coming voyage was brought up for discussion.

During the afternoon one of the sailors walked several miles along the eastern and southern coast to make certain the blacks were not returning, and in the hope of sighting some sail, but both these missions resulted in the same manner.

No craft of any kind could be seen, and at an early hour all hands “turned in” on the sand, it being thought unnecessary to stand watch.

It was not yet daylight when the boys were awakened by Jenkins, who said, as they opened their eyes:

“The wind has come around from the south’ard an’ east’ard, and the captain is ready to start.”

The little tender had already been launched, and it was only necessary for the voyagers to step aboard.

At the last moment Captain Mansfield had decided to take but one of the sailors with him, in order that as large a force as possible might be left behind in case the blacks should return bent on mischief, and the remainder of the party stood on the beach to say good-by.

“We won’t go very strong on the parting business,” the captain said, as he saw by the faces of Gil and Nelse that they were considerably distressed because of his leaving. “With this wind we shall be on shore again by sunset, and the trip will be nothing more than child’s play. Keep together as much as possible, and remember that Mr. Jenkins is in command.”

Then he took his seat at the helm, the tiny sail was hoisted, and in a few seconds the little craft was lost to view amid the gloom.

Those who had been left behind set about getting breakfast, for the voyagers preferred to eat theirs in the boat rather than lose time by waiting on shore until a meal could be cooked, and when this very important portion of the day’s duties was finished the question arose as to what should first be done.

Jenkins sent Andy down the coast to watch lest the blacks should return unobserved, and then the boys proposed that they be allowed to continue the search for the supposed treasure.

To this the mate agreed after some slight hesitation, and once more the work of digging was begun, but on this occasion fathoms instead of feet were measured off, according to the suggestion of the sailor, who said:

“It don’t stand to reason that any decent pirates would put down figgers ’cordin’ to shore lingo. It’s fathoms, or I’m a duffer.”

Whether or no he was a “duffer,” both Gil and Nelse were willing to try the experiment, more especially since the first attempt resulted in such a signal failure, and when the bearings had been taken—this time accurately with one of the compasses saved from the *Day Dream*—the boys went to work in good earnest, assisted now and then by the men.

During an hour they labored industriously without having seen anything to give encouragement, and just as Gil was on the point of saying that he had had enough of digging for supposititious gold, the spade struck something which gave forth a metallic sound.

“There’s more than earth down here!” he exclaimed, triumphantly, plying the tool with renewed vigor, and Jenkins leaped into the excavation as he cried:

“Upon my word, lad, I believe there’s something in that chart after all. Give me the spade until we see what’s below here!”

Now all hands were literally trembling with excitement, as the mate threw out the loose sand in a perfect shower, and when several fragments of decayed wood were disclosed each one believed the desired discovery was about to be made.

---



## CHAPTER XX.

### THE UNDERGROUND PASSAGE.

The treasure seekers were not kept long in suspense after the first evidence that there was some foreign substance beneath the surface.

In less than ten minutes Jenkins cleared the sand away, exposing to view an iron-bound hatch, which presented the appearance of having been taken from a small vessel. It showed every sign of age. The iron was so eaten with rust as to be nothing more than thin ribbons of metal, and the wood had been bored by insects or worms until it looked like a gigantic sieve.

“If there’s any treasure on this island here’s where we shall find it,” the mate said, as he paused to wipe the perspiration from his face. “It don’t stand to reason that men would spend their time burying a thing like this, and then make a chart to show exactly the spot, unless there was something valuable underneath.”

“Of course there’s plenty of gold down there, and perhaps we shall find a lot of diamonds and jewelry,” Gil cried, excitedly. “Why don’t you lift it up?”

“That’s more than can be done from below here, unless the hole is made at least twice as large, which will be too much work to suit me. There are some pieces of rope on the beach that were left over after we finished riggin’ the boat. Get them, an’ we’ll soon have a purchase that’ll raise this ’ere cover mighty easy.”

Both the boys started for the shore at full speed. They were too much excited to be able to converse about the matter, and, without saying a single word, gathered up the desired articles, returning to the scene of the discovery in a wonderfully short space of time.

When they arrived Andy had come up from the beach to report that no craft of any kind was in sight, and he stood looking at the ancient hatch in silent horror.

“You see the chart we found meant something after all!” Nelse cried, triumphantly, as Jenkins set about rigging a rude purchase to a tree which

stood near by.

“It meant dat we wus boun’ ter git inter de biggest kin’ ob trubble,” the old darky replied, after a short pause. “You hear me, chillun, dis yere is a mighty bad bizness. Ef you’s e ain’ hankerin’ arter de wuss scrape you’s e ebber heard ob, kiver dat hol’ up right smart.”

“But what is the matter with your charm?” Nelse asked. “It worked well since the voodooos got hold of us, and why should it fail now?”

“It ain’ strong enuf fur dis kin’ ob fussin’—nuffin would stan’ dat,” Andy replied, moodily.

“Now don’t begin your croaking again,” Jenkins said, with a laugh, the apparent certainty of finding treasure causing him to feel very happy. “We’ve pulled through so far, an’ I reckon there won’t be anything startling happen before we can get a peep of what is underneath this hatch.”

“How’s you’s e bin pullin’ trou’?” the old darky asked, angrily. “Didn’t you’s e cum widin a han’s bref ob bein’ killed?”

“But we wasn’t, and the rockets instead of your charm did the business for us.”

“Has yer done forget when de men set us driftin’ ’roun’ in de little boat?”

“We got our own jest the same, and didn’t have to undergo many hardships.”

“Kin yer git de yacht ag’in? Ain’ she dun bin sunk by de voodooos?”

“She is sunk, for a fact, but the fellows on this island didn’t have anything to do with it.”

“Who tole yer so?”

“My own common sense.”

“Den let yer common sense show yer how ter git outer de scrape what you’s e hankerin’ fur now,” and Andy stalked solemnly away, not so much as turning his head when the boys begged of him to wait until the hatch should be raised.

At that moment, when they were all so happy at the apparently successful result of their labors, the old darky’s anger seemed very comical, and no

one tried to restrain his mirth, until Jenkins said:

“This won’t do if we want to find out how much treasure the pirates have buried here. All hands tail onto the rope, and we’ll soon have gold enough to tassel our handkerchiefs in great shape.”

It required considerable labor to raise the cumbersome mass of wood and iron, but it was finally accomplished, and, as the hatch swung above the surface each member of the party rushed to the edge of the excavation excitedly.

Instead of seeing a vast amount of valuable plunder such as pirates are supposed to hide, nothing more startling than a deep hole or shaft met their gaze.

“The stuff must be at the bottom,” Gil said, after all had looked in silence for several moments.

“It’s a shaft of some kind,” Jenkins added, half to himself, “and I reckon we’ve had our labor for our pains. Old Andy knew what he was about when he refused to have anything to do with the scheme.”

“It isn’t certain that we’ve worked for nothing,” Nelse replied. “I can see what appear to be steps cut in the side, and as likely as not we shall find all we want at the bottom.”

“Seeing there’s nothin’ better to do, we might as well find out the whole story. Lay hold of that rope an’ lower me down.”

In another instant the mate was descending. His companions were able to perform their portion of the task with but little difficulty because he found a foothold here and there by which he could aid himself.

At least twenty feet of the rope had been payed out, when he shouted:

“I’m at the bottom, and there is a tunnel which runs on the level. Lower something for a torch, and I’ll keep on.”

“Why can’t we all come down?” Gil asked.

“There’s nothin’ to prevent. Throw some light wood in first, and then make the rope fast to a tree. You can come hand over hand without any trouble.”

After gathering what would be sufficient to supply the party with torches for several hours, Jenkins' orders were obeyed, and the boys and the sailors were soon with the mate in a tunnel leading at right angles from the shaft, of sufficient height for one to walk upright. The passage looked as if it had been hewn from the solid coral, and, although evidently not used for many years, the air was pure as if it had never been closed.

Some little difficulty was experienced in lighting the wood, but when that had been done, Jenkins marched on, holding the torch as high as possible, that all might see this underground path which was supposed to lead to the valuable deposit.

"It's certain this tunnel wasn't dug for nothing," Gil said, after they had walked at an ordinary pace for at least twenty minutes without having seen anything but the coral walls. "People wouldn't spend much time on such work simply for fun, and it must have required many days to hew out such an amount of rock."

"I reckon we've come to the end," Jenkins replied, as the passage began to trend upward at a very decided inclination, and a moment later he stopped at what appeared to be the termination of the tunnel.

Before them was apparently a solid wall, but, as the light was thrown on it, Gil could see a crevice, very narrow and nearly filled with dust, at the side and bottom.

"It's a door!" he cried, "and behind it is the gold!"

Jenkins handed the torch to Nelse, and threw his whole weight against the rock.

It yielded slightly, giving an opening not more than half an inch wide, through which warm air and a glow as of a fire entered the tunnel.

Quickly, and without speaking, the mate extinguished the torch, and, to the astonishment of all, the sound of voices could be heard, indistinctly, it is true, but sufficiently to make it positive human beings were conversing at no very great distance from the aperture.

This was a conclusion to the tour of discovery upon which the explorers had not reckoned, and for several moments all stood in silent dismay, not knowing what course to pursue.

Then Jenkins tried to close the stone door, but in vain. It was perfectly smooth, and he could gain no hold upon it.

But few seconds were spent on the useless work.

Whispering softly, the mate directed his companions to retrace their steps with as little noise as possible, and all hands crept back through the now dark tunnel to the foot of the shaft which they had entered.

“What are we to do now?” Gil asked, impatiently.

“That’s just what we must decide upon,” Jenkins replied, “an’ it isn’t going to be an easy question to answer.”

“Who do you suppose the men are?” Nelse asked. “I thought it was certain all the blacks had left the island.”

“It seems that we made a mistake in coming to that conclusion. I’ve an idea the tunnel leads straight back to the cave where we had the pleasure of spending one night.”

“Then the apparent mystery can be explained if we make a search there,” Gil suggested.

“You are right, but it will be a good idea to hunt mighty cautiously, or we may find ourselves in a worse scrape than before. You stay here while I take a short trip in that direction, and at the same time warn Andy of what has been discovered.”

Both of the boys were unwilling the party should separate. Strength of numbers seemed to be their only protection, and the loss of one would be very serious.

Jenkins, however, was positive his plan offered the only chance of safety, and after some discussion the others agreed to it.

“I’ll take one of the revolvers, and you fellows will have the other. It is likely that I shall be away some time, therefore you mustn’t get nervous if I stay nearly all day. You had better get in the tunnel half-a-dozen yards from the shaft, so your voices won’t be heard if anybody happens to come this way.”

“But what about Andy?”

“I’ll try to make him come down here, for it isn’t safe to remain where those people, whoever they are, may find an opportunity of getting hold of him.”

After giving these orders, Jenkins swarmed up the rope hand over hand, and, without so much as an “adieu,” disappeared from the view of those in the shaft.

The three waited in almost perfect silence during fully half-an-hour, and then, as a slight rustling was heard from above, the cook’s head could be seen at the edge of the excavation.

His black face was literally gray with terror, and one would have said his eyeballs protruded very much more than usual as he asked, in a hoarse whisper:

“Am it er fac’ dat you chillun reckon on stayin’ hyar wid de whole crowd ob voodooos so nigh at han’?”

“What else can we do?”

“Come out an’ hide whar dere’s a chance to gib de debbils de slip ef dey begin’ cuttin’ up shines.”

---

## CHAPTER XXI.

### A TRAP.

The sailors, superstitious as are nearly all their class, believed the wisest course would be to follow the old darky's advice, arguing that since he knew more about the island and the ways of the repulsive beings who had been found upon it, than any one else, it was reasonable to suppose he could best extricate them from their uncomfortable situation.

Both Gil and Nelse, however, were determined to stay where they were until Jenkins returned, and to this end the former said to Andy:

"Come down here until you know what has been found. There can be no danger, since you've got your charm with you, and we are now positive that all the blacks have not left the island."

"I dun seed 'em go wif my own eyes."

"You saw three boats; but I tell you there are more not far from here, and, what is worse, it's the old ones who have been left behind."

Andy appeared incredulous until the sailors joined with Gil in the statement, and then, looking around suspiciously, as if expecting to see his enemies near at hand ready to spring upon him, the cook prepared to descend by first clutching firmly the mysterious "something" which was concealed beneath the bosom of his shirt.

On reaching the bottom of the shaft he went through a series of gestures, probably intended for the purpose of warding off danger, and then whispered, cautiously:

"Wha' hab you seen, honey? Don't try to fool wid de ole man, kase dis yere am no kinder time ter play pranks when de wustes' sort ob trubble am cummin'."

"I don't want to fool you," Gil replied, impatiently, "but it is necessary you should know that there are people in a sort of cave, perhaps the very one where we were kept prisoners, and their voices can be heard distinctly if you listen at the end of this tunnel, where it looks as if a wall of solid rock

rose right up before you. Go on, and try to make out what they are talking about.”

While speaking, the boy had seized the old darky by the arm, as if to force him onward, and the latter shrank back with every show of terror.

“I wouldn’t go dere fur a millyon dollars, an’ dat’s eh fac’,” Andy said, with a long-drawn sigh. “Af it’s de ole debbils wha’ hab been lef behin’, de odders are skinnin’ roun’ fur ter get a crowd ober hyar to ketch us all.”

“Why would so much trouble be necessary, when they outnumber us at least three to one?” Nelse asked.

“Dat’s jes’ wha’ dey don’ know, honey. De fiery sarpints hab done made ’em t’ink we’s er hard gang, an’ dey’s gwine ter bring more ob dem ole fellers ter help erlong wid de hoodoo.”

Upon this point Andy appeared to be so positive that it would have been only a waste of time to argue the matter, and Gil urged him to follow up the tunnel in the hope of learning by the conversation who the men were in the subterranean chamber.

This was a most signal failure, however, for the old darky not only refused to take a single step in the desired direction, but would not so much as look into the opening.

“I’s done gone had enuf ob sich t’ings,” he said, solemnly, “an’ now I’m gwine ter keep my ole head outer trubble whar dar’s a chance. Dere’s a boat hyar what b’longs ter de captain, an’ de bes’ t’ing we kin do is ter git ’way frum dis yere islan’ afore de witches ’gin ter take a han’ in de muss.”

“We are willing to risk it a while longer, and your charm should be sufficient to make you stay while the rest of the party are here,” Nelse said, with a nervous laugh which had very little mirth in it.

“I’s got frou takin’ chances, no matter ef I had er hun’red charms,” the old darky replied, clutching yet tighter that which was suspended from his neck. “We wants ter mosey outer dis yere place, nebber min’ wha’ Job Jenkins says erbout it, kase I tells yer, chillun, it am mighty onhealthy when dem debbils begin for to git in dere work.”

Then Andy started to his feet as if on the point of swarming up the rope again, but before he could do so the mate appeared at the opening above,



saying in a whisper, as he began to descend:

“Take care, below there, for the sun blinds my eyes so I can’t see where I’m going.”

In another instant he was in the midst of the anxious group, all of whom, with the exception of Andy, began to overwhelm him with questions.

“It won’t take long for me to tell the story,” Jenkins said, as he seated himself on the ground. “There is no question but that this passage leads to the big cave. I went there, and hunted around quite a while before finding any signs of another outlet. Things were just as when I saw them last, an’ I could ’a’ taken my oath the whole crowd skipped out after the second dose of signal rockets, until I ran across what appeared to be a door cut in a piece of coral.”

“Did you open it?” Gil asked, eagerly.

“Of course. What would ’a’ been the use of lookin’ if I didn’t do the thing in proper shape? I pried the stone open till I could see a narrow passage that led in this direction, an’ then I stopped, for there was no reason of pokin’ my nose into danger. I reckon we’d better take to the boat, if we can manage to stow into the one we’ve got, for if that crowd comes back, as I feel certain they’re bound to do, we’ll be in hot water.”

“Now you’s torkin’ sense,” Andy said quickly. “When a man shoves his head inter de lion’s mout’ once, dat may be a mistake; but ef he does it de secon’ time, dat shows how big er fool he kin make ob hisself.”

The sailors were also eager to get away from such a dangerous locality, and against this preponderance of opinion neither Gil nor Nelse thought he should make any objections, although both believed the safest plan would be to take the chances and await Captain Mansfield’s return.

Now that the mate shared his opinion in regard to leaving the island, Andy was in a perfect fever to get away, and, without waiting for the others, he swarmed up the rope to the surface, the remainder of the party following a few seconds later, urged to what seemed foolish haste by his description of the dangers which threatened.

“Don’t stay down dar torkin’ ’bout nuffin,” he said instantly, on gaining the surface. “I’s been right yere afore, an’ knows how dese images kin skip

'roun' when dey has bizness. We'se boun' to mosey erlong like er flea, 'less we wants ter be cotched ergin."

"Now don't run the risk of carryin' away your spars by crackin' on too much sail," said Jenkins, with a laugh. "I allow the fellers won't be back for two or three days, an' we can take things easy."

The old darky was most vehement against delay, and did not cease to repeat what the blacks were able to do, until all the party were out of the tunnel. Then he would have started toward the shore without even waiting to gather up the small store of goods they had left on the surface if Jenkins had not peremptorily ordered him to stop until they were in proper marching order.

When the necessary arrangements had finally been made, Andy darted through the underbrush at such speed that the others were obliged to exert themselves to the utmost in order to keep pace with him, and the heat rendered rapid traveling both painful and exhausting.

"Let him go ahead," Jenkins said, impatiently, after five minutes passed, during which the whole party had been running rather than walking. "He's worse than an old woman when he gets frightened, an' we couldn't move faster than we're doin' now if the whole crowd were at our heels."

"There's no reason why we shouldn't take our time," and Gil halted for a comfortable breath. "It will be better to start after dark, anyway, for no one could row very long in this heat."

Having thus allayed their own nervousness, the little party proceeded toward the beach in a most leisurely fashion, until the sound of the surf told that they were very near the sea, when Andy burst through the underbrush at a faster gait than he had departed.

His black face was of an ashen hue, and his eyes open and staring as he said, in a hoarse whisper:

"De boat's dun gone!"

"What do you mean, you fool?" the mate asked, angrily.

"She's gone, an' dat's a fac'. Dem ole debbils knowed wha' we was er tryin' ter do, an' dey've hoodooed her outer sight!"

"Probably you didn't go within half-a-mile of where we left her."

“Dere’s de tree we hitched her to, an’ you kin see whar dem as took her off walked ’roun’ huntin’ for us.”

“Then what you mean is that the crowd have come back, an’ we’re cut off again,” Jenkins replied, in a tone of relief, despite his oft-repeated assertion that he did not believe in what Andy called “cunjurin’.”

“Dat am de fac’.”

“I thought you said the old men had hoodooed her?” Nelse added, and the old darky said, with considerable show of spirit:

“Ob course dey did, else how could dem wuffless trash know where to fin’ her?”

“It wouldn’t be a bad idea to have a look at the beach,” Jenkins said, as he took a revolver from his pocket. “Just as likely as not Andy has made a mistake.”

The others pressed forward, but the cook refused to move a single step. He declared that no earthly power could force him to leave the shelter of the trees, and was so vehement in his protestations that even the boys began to think perhaps it would be as well to exercise a little caution.

“Don’t rush right out in the open, for fear those who stole the boat may see you,” Gil said to the mate. “Perhaps the best way would be for us to stay here while you have a look around.”

“All right, keep under cover, an’ I’ll soon be back,” Mr. Jenkins said, as he disappeared from view amid the foliage, and the remainder of the party waited in silence for his return.

They were not to be kept very long in suspense. Five minutes later the mate returned looking very serious, and Nelse asked, eagerly:

“What did you see?”

“Enough to make me wish your father had waited one day longer. From the appearances I should say a regular mob of men had been around where we left the boat, and there is little doubt but that they are the same kind of a crowd we saw dancin’ near the fire. They’ve made off with our craft, an’ now count on huntin’ us down at their leisure.”

Although this information was no more alarming than what Andy had predicted, the old darky seemed to be literally paralyzed with fear. He remained silent and motionless, staring at Mr. Jenkins as if in the latter's face he could read even more terrible intelligence than had already been imparted.

---

## CHAPTER XXII.

### RUN TO COVER.

Andy was not the only one who felt as if an unkind fortune had dealt the crowning blow in a series of disasters, and that it would be useless to struggle longer against such overwhelming odds.

It is true the little party were armed, after a certain fashion, and could act on the defensive for a short time in a creditable manner; but the supply of ammunition was woefully small, and when the last cartridge should have been fired they had only two knives and two hatchets with which to hold their own against a party of perhaps forty.

To each one these thoughts came much as if they had been presented for consideration, and, after five minutes or more had been spent in mournful reflections, Jenkins said, with a feeble attempt at cheerfulness:

“It’s worse than foolish for us to sit here moonin’ over what we’ve got to meet like men. It’ll be strange if we can’t hold our own against such a crowd as is on this island; but we sha’n’t make any headway by suckin’ our thumbs.”

“You are the leader, and we are waiting to hear what you propose doing,” Gil replied, forcing himself to speak firmly and even carelessly, because of the effect he knew his words would have upon the others.

“That’s what I haven’t had time to decide on,” Jenkins said, deliberately. “Suppose we try to cook up some plan between us? What is your opinion, Andy?”

The old darky shook his head, but made no reply. He was without hope, and could do no more than clutch the charm which was covered by his shirt; but even his faith in this seemed to have been shaken by the news that the main body of the enemy had returned to the island.

Jenkins waited a few seconds for some one to speak, and, as all remained silent, he said, in a thoughtful tone:

“It stands to reason we’ve only got to hold our own a few days at the outside, for the captain is bound to be back before long, and then all the

trouble will be at an end. It is now so near night that I reckon we can count on bein' left alone till mornin', an', with so much time before us, we ought to be able to make considerable headway takin' care of ourselves. The first thing is to find a hidin'-place, an' Andy knows more about this island than any one else, so he must attend to that portion of the work."

"It can't be did," the old fellow said, in a whisper. "Dem brack debbils done gone know ebbry spot on dis yere islan' whar a skeeter could poke his nose, an' dey's boun' to hab us out 'fore ter-morrer mornin'."

"That remains to be seen," Gil replied. "It is certain they'll get hold of us if we sit here doing nothing, but it must be possible to hide during the short time father will be gone."

"You are right, Gil, an' if we don't lose our pluck, things is sure to come out all right," Jenkins said, approvingly. "It won't do to trust to the shelter of the trees, for those fellows can track us down; so I go in for hittin' on some spot where we can hold out against them till the captain comes."

"Yes, but where'll we find such a place?" Nelse asked.

"That is what we must hunt for, an' there's no time to lose, because it'll soon be too dark to travel around much."

Jenkins looked toward Andy as he spoke, but the old darky did not so much as move an eyelid. He acted as if all hope had fled, and he was trying to resign himself to the inevitable.

"I should think it would be a good idea to hunt around for food before we go into hiding," Nelse said, after a pause. "We may be obliged to keep under cover quite a while, and, according to the experience I have had on this island, it isn't always convenient to go whenever a fellow feels so disposed."

"You are right, my boy, and I'll hunt for a hiding-place if the rest will act on your suggestion. We can meet here any time between now an' sunset, so there'll be no danger of losing each other. Andy, show them where the shell fish can be found easiest."

The cook, who had thrown himself on the ground as if in such despair that his legs could no longer be depended upon to do their duty, rose slowly and silently, which was sufficient intimation that he would so far oblige,

however unnecessary he might think it to provide for a party who were doomed to death.

“Bring in everything eatable you can find,” Jenkins said, and then started through the underbrush to perform his portion of the work.

Gil was forced to speak quite sharply to Andy before the latter would lead the way toward the beach, but after the old fellow once started he did his best to procure the provisions in the shortest possible space of time.

When the party left the shelter of the trees, and walked cautiously out on the sands, where the gentle swell of the sea was rolling up in tinkling measures, not a sign of the enemy could be seen. It was as if they were alone on the island, and, while this apparent security caused the others to feel considerably more confident than at any time since it had been discovered the boat was stolen, it filled Andy with the gravest apprehensions.

“I’s done been hyar afore,” he said, with a solemn shake of the head, “an’ I tell yer, honey, we’s gwine ter hab a power ob trubble.”

“There don’t seem to be any signs of it around here,” Nelse replied, with a laugh.

“Dat’s kase yer don’t know wha’ kin’ ob folks dese yere imps be, honey. Dey’s layin’ low like now; but look out fur ’em, look out, I say, an’ don’ trus’ de snake jes’ kase he ain’ in de humor fur bitin’. Dey’s done got dere eyes on us now, an’ when de right time comes we’s gwine to fin’ it out.”

“If they don’t do any more than keep their eyes on us for the next hour we shall stand a good chance of laying in a stock of provisions, for the oysters appear to be plentiful on this part of the beach.”

Andy contented himself with simply shaking his head, as if to say he could tell a great deal more if he felt disposed, and then all hands began industriously gathering the shell fish, which were to be seen just above the low water mark in enormous beds.

It was hard work to detach them from the seaweed and rocks, but the little party were literally laboring for life, and before an hour had passed a heavy load for each member was secured.

“There’s no need of taking more than we can lug comfortably,” Gil said, when the tide had covered the largest beds, “and now comes the question of

how they may be carried to the place where we agreed to meet Jenkins.”

“I reckon my mate an’ me can rig up somethin’ that’ll answer for baskets,” one of the sailors replied, as he began gathering a quantity of vines, and in this labor Andy assisted without being especially requested so to do.

Under the skillful fingers of the three men the vines soon assumed shape, and the sun was yet above the horizon when five rude receptacles had been woven.

After these were filled with oysters it was found that each one had as much of a load as could comfortably be carried on his back, and, laden heavily, all hands started for the rendezvous, arriving there just as the mate returned, looking tired and disappointed.

“We’ve done our portion of the work,” Gil said, cheerily, “and what have you accomplished?”

“Nothin’, so far as a hidin’-place is concerned. It won’t do to go so far into the interior of the island that we stand a chance of gettin’ lost while tryin’ to find our way back to the beach, an’ I can’t find a spot where anything bigger than a rabbit could hide himself this side of the cave.”

“Did you see anything of the blacks?”

“Yes, the whole crowd are near the entrance, an’ from the appearance of things they have got over the scare we gave ’em.”

“How many are there?”

“Thirty at the lowest calculation, without countin’ them as were hidin’ in the cave. All hands are loafin’ around the entrance, as if not carin’ whether we saw them or not, an’ I reckon they’ve sized us up mighty nigh right.”

“But what are we to do to-night?” Nelse asked, his voice betraying the uneasiness he felt.

“There is only one plan I can think of, which is to get into the tunnel we found.”

“Why, that would be putting ourselves directly in their power!” Nelse cried, and Andy looked at Jenkins as if fancying the mate had suddenly lost his reason.



“When it comes to dots, we are in their power already, and without much chance to defend ourselves, if they should surround us in this thick underbrush. There we could hold our own for a while, at any rate, because not more than one could attack us at a time, an’ our revolvers would keep ’em back a good many hours.”

The boys immediately recognized the force of the argument, as did both the sailors, but Andy was literally beside himself with impatience because such a scheme had been proposed.

“I’s done gone got enuff ob dis yere crowd,” he said, angrily. “When you cotch de old man runnin’ his nose inter de hornet’s nes’ jes’ tell him he’s makin’ a mighty big fool outer hisself. We’s bad enuff hyar widout makin’ it wuss.”

“But, Andy, it really seems to be the best thing we can do,” Gil said, persuasively. “It is as Mr. Jenkins says—we shall at least have a chance of defending ourselves there, and it’s only necessary to hold out until father gets back before the trouble will be at an end. Then we can show these scoundrels a trick or two at hunting which perhaps they won’t appreciate so well.”

“I ’preciate dis yere scrape, an’ ain’ gwine ter put my nose in any mo’,” the old fellow replied, doggedly. “Ef you is boun’ dar, go ahead, an’ Andy’ll kinder grub ’roun’ fur hisself.”

“But we mustn’t separate, you obstinate old man! Can’t you see that there’s a chance, with all this food, of holding our own a good many hours?”

“Whar’s de water? Bymby somebody’s gwine ter want er drink, an’ den whar’ll de debbils be?”

“I hadn’t thought of that,” Gil exclaimed, in dismay, and Jenkins added, quickly:

“We must try to lay in a stock to-night. I’ll run the risk of snoopin’ round a bit after dark, an’ it’ll be hard lines if I can’t bring in a little. At any rate, it’s better to be in the tunnel, where we’ve got a show for our lives, an’ be thirsty, than stay out here where all hands can be surrounded by daylight. If Andy won’t go with us I don’t see any other way than let him paddle his own canoe.”

The sailors decided in favor of the mate, and Gil and Nelse could do no less than agree with the more experienced and less timid portion of the party.

“We’ll go to the tunnel,” Gil decided, after a pause, “and if Andy wants to stay outside it can’t be helped.”

“I’se gwine ter look arter myself,” the cook replied, doggedly, and, without further conversation, he disappeared among the underbrush.

---

## CHAPTER XXIII.

### SECRET OF THE CAVE.

The cook hurried away so quickly that his companions had no time to persuade him to a different course, even provided they wished to do so, and when he was out of sight Jenkins said, as he took up the load of oysters which Andy brought:

“It won’t do any good for us to stay here talkin’ about what the old fool has done, for we must get under cover before it is too dark to admit of seeing our way through the woods. His pig-headedness may cost him his life, but we are not to blame. It only remains for us to take care of ourselves.”

“Do you propose to go directly there, or shall we circle around so they can’t track us easily?” Nelse asked.

“It’ll be as well to drive ahead, I reckon; they’ll find us out anyhow, for we can’t hide the trail any better than these woods will do it for us.”

Then Jenkins signified that he was ready, and the little party, each carrying a quantity of oysters, followed at his heels in perfect silence.

The mate had the bearings of the old palm well in mind, and went directly toward it without swerving to the right or the left, coming to a halt only when he reached the spot where, a few hours previous, the boys had been so certain a large amount of treasure was about to be found.

Although he had said that the blacks would be certain to discover their hiding-place, he took good care not to make any more noise than was absolutely necessary.

“Swarm down there,” he whispered, cautiously, “and the last man shall pull the rope after him, for it won’t do to let those blacks have a chance to steal it.”

“If we do that, how will it be possible for us to come up again?” Gil asked. “We can’t make the rope fast above while all hands are below.”

“I have thought of that. We must take the chances of climbin’ up the sides by diggin’ small holes where the sand is hardest. At all events, I’ll guarantee

we get back here again, if they leave enough of us.”

One of the sailors obeyed the motions made by the mate, and began to slip slowly down the rope. When he was at the bottom of the shaft first one and then another of the bags were lowered, until all had disappeared, and then the second sailor followed his comrade.

“Now remember to pull the rope after you, an’ don’t show yourselves again till you hear me speak,” Jenkins said, as he urged Gil toward the mouth of the shaft.

“What do you mean? Don’t you intend to come with us?”

“Not just yet. We’ve got to have water, an’ I’m goin’ for some.”

“You’ve nothing to bring it in, no matter how much you should find.”

“I’ve got a scheme for attendin’ to that part of the business, an’ want to leave as soon as possible, so don’t make me stay here chinning.”

Gil realized that it was not the time to ask many questions, and he obeyed without another word, after Nelse had let himself down the opening.

In less than five minutes from the time the second sailor joined the first all hands except Jenkins were crouching in the tunnel, with the rope coiled up beside them, and already had the shades of night gathered so densely that it was impossible to distinguish each other, save by the tones of the voices.

Now they had reached what seemed a desirable hiding-place while the matter was under discussion, it no longer appeared either safe or comfortable, and the prospect of being besieged while in such cramped quarters was anything rather than pleasant.

“I’m beginnin’ to think Andy had more sense than the rest of us,” one of the sailors said, as he tried to find a spot where he could stretch out at full length. “It’ll be mighty hard lines after them imps shut us in here like rats in a trap, an’, when the captain comes back, I’d like to know how he’s goin’ to find us if there are fifteen or twenty blacks standin’ around the openin’ up there ready to kill the first who shows himself long enough to hail them as may be huntin’ for us.”

This was a phase of the case which neither Gil nor Nelse had taken into consideration, and they began to feel very uncomfortable in mind.

“What should we do if we heard father and couldn’t let him know where we were?” he asked, in a whisper.

“I’m sure I don’t know,” Nelse replied, with a long-drawn sigh. “It is certain we couldn’t make our whereabouts known, and I’m inclined to think we’ve been more than foolish to come here.”

“We might leave now, and take our chances in the woods as Andy is doing.”

“How would you contrive to get out?”

“Gracious! I’d forgotten that we’re shut in here already,” Nelse exclaimed, and then he relapsed into silence, while Gil tried in vain to see some cheerful ray in the very disagreeable situation.

During the next half-hour nothing was said, and then one of the sailors spoke:

“Never mind what’s goin’ to happen, there’s no call for us to be hungry while there are so many oysters waitin’ to be invited to supper. Here goes for a couple of dozen. Can you boys open them?”

“I never tried, but this seems like a good time to begin,” Gil said, with a vain attempt to laugh.

“You’d make a poor fist if you’re green at the business. Set close, both of you, an’ I’ll engage to fill you up before startin’ in for myself.”

Speaking about food had caused the boys to remember that they were very hungry, and they accepted the generous proposition without delay.

It is certain that trouble seems less when viewed by one whose stomach is full, as Gil and Nelse soon learned. When the satisfactory meal was ended both ceased to think the situation so very desperate, and actually began to plan what steps should be taken to continue the search for the supposed treasure as soon as Captain Mansfield returned.

That Jenkins did not come back, although the night had fully shut in, gave them no uneasiness, for all believed he would play the spy once more before joining them, and it would not be surprising if he were absent until past midnight.

It was dull work sitting there in the darkness after the conversation regarding their movements when they should be free was exhausted, and it

seemed as if they must have been in the tunnel several hours, when Gil said, with a yawn:

“Of course, somebody must keep awake so’s to hear Jenkins when he wants the rope passed up to him, but that’s no reason why all hands of us should sit here nodding.”

“You’re right, lad. Turn in, an’ me an’ my mate will ’tend to the rest of the business.”

“But you must have some sleep.”

“We’ll have a chance to get plenty before leavin’ this ’ere hole, so don’t trouble your head about us.”

“We’ll crawl back a short piece, and try to find a place where we can stretch out at full length,” Gil suggested, and Nelse replied:

“Go ahead; I’ll follow close enough to keep hold of your coat.”

Gil proceeded on his hands and knees to avoid a possible fall, and at least twenty yards had been traversed when his companion asked:

“Don’t you think we’ve gone about far enough? It isn’t safe to get too near that door at the end, for there’s no knowing when the blacks may come down this way.”

“Up to this point a fellow would have had to double himself into a bowknot in order to lay down, and we’re not so very far from the shaft. I’ll go on a little further, and then if it hasn’t widened we might as well rejoin the others, because——”

The sentence was never finished, for at that instant Nelse felt the earth sink beneath him, and Gil’s coat was torn from his grasp as its owner plunged forward.

For a few seconds Nelse remained motionless, unable to understand what had happened, and then he realized that his companion must have been precipitated into a cavity of some kind, although the floor of the tunnel appeared firm when the whole party traversed it a few hours previously.

“Gil! Gil!” he called, and it seemed almost an endless while before the reply came:

“I’m all right, but I must have fallen twenty feet or more, and the breath was pretty nearly shaken out of my body.”

“What can I do to help you?”

“Get the rope and pull me out, for I don’t fancy staying here all night.”

“It doesn’t sound as if you were buried very deep.”

“I’m not buried at all, but simply in a big hole, which I don’t care to explore for fear of getting into worse trouble.”

By this time Nelse had collected his partially scattered senses, and at once made his way back to the shaft with all speed, startling the sailors into something very nearly resembling fear, as he hurriedly told what had befallen Gil.

“This ’ere is gettin’ too hot to suit me,” one of the men said, in a tone of apprehension. “Who knows but that them black scoundrels have got a way to let the whole bottom drop out of the tunnel, an’ that’s why we’ve been allowed to crawl in here.”

“Of course such a thing couldn’t be, because they had no idea we should find the shaft—perhaps don’t know where we are.”

“That may be, but I’m beginnin’ to think a good deal as Andy does about the island’s bein’ bewitched.”

“It wouldn’t do any good just now if you were positive that such a state of affairs existed. Gil is in the hole, and it doesn’t seem fair to leave him there while we talk nonsense.”

“You’re right, lad, an’ I’m an old fool. Here’s the rope; heave ahead an’ we’ll foller, but be careful not to tumble into the same place.”

“Some one should stay here in case Jenkins comes back,” Nelse suggested, as he began to retrace his steps, and one of the sailors said, as he lighted his pipe:

“I’ll hang around. You two can ’tend to him, I reckon.”

It was not an easy matter to find the cavity without falling in, and Nelse moved forward slowly, calling to Gil from time to time until the latter answered, thus guiding him to the proper place.

“Where’s the rope?” he asked, and, instead of replying, the sailor lighted a match, saying as he did so:

“I’d like to have a squint around before we do very much, for it ain’t sure \_\_\_\_\_”

“Have you got the rope?” Gil cried, impatiently.

“It’s here, an’ we’ll soon have you out.”

“Can’t you send down some kind of a light? I’ve fallen on what I truly believe is the decaying fragments of a chest, and unless I’m very much mistaken in regard to what I’ve got in my hand, we’ve struck the treasure at last.”

---



## **CHAPTER XXIV.**

### **THE TREASURE CHAMBER.**

Strange as it may seem, Gil's announcement caused Nelse to forget entirely the danger by which they were surrounded, and, regardless of the fact that none of the party were certain of ever leaving the tunnel alive, his only desire now was to gain possession of the supposed hoard.

The sailor was not one whit less excited; he had a stock of matches in his pockets, but could not find them until after a search of several seconds, owing to extreme agitation caused by Gil's announcement.

"Do hurry!" Nelse cried, impatiently, as the man fumbled about his clothing. "Something may happen to prevent us from seeing the treasure if you spend so much time doing nothing."

"I'm trying to find another match, an' then, perhaps, we can rig up somethin' that'll answer for a torch, but it seems as if my fingers were all thumbs jest now."

"Don't keep me waiting here all day, for I want to know what I've struck," Gil cried, and after a few seconds more a tiny flame told that the sailor had finally succeeded in finding that which was wanted so badly just at that moment.

Nelse seized the first opportunity to search with his eyes for something which would serve as a torch, but the floor of the tunnel was as clean as though swept with a broom, and he said to Gil:

"There isn't so much as a twig here, but I reckon we can afford to use a few matches so's you can find out what you've got. Send it up, an' I'll soon see if it is the article we've been hunting for."

"Lower the rope, and I'll bring it."

"How far down are you?" the sailor asked, as, the match having been consumed, he crept toward the aperture.

"I can't tell, but it seemed as if I fell a long distance. We'll soon find out if you'll give me the chance."

Nelse paid out on the rope until he was certain not less than fifteen feet had been lowered into what he hoped would prove to be a veritable treasure chamber, and then Gil shouted:

“Hold on, I’ve got enough. You’ll have to pull me up, for I want to come with both hands full.”

“Make it fast under your arms, and I reckon we’ll be able to manage the rest.”

This portion of the work was quickly accomplished, and when Gil stood beside his companions the sailor would have lighted another match if the boys had not prevented him.

“Wait until we are at the entrance, and then, perhaps, the same light will show us materials for a torch,” Nelse said, as he seized Gil’s arm, hurrying him toward the shaft.

The man who was on watch had heard all the conversation, and his excitement was quite as great as that of the others.

“I’ve got a piece of paper here, an’ we’ll use it to help out with the matches.”

As he and his mate twisted this firmly to prevent it from burning too quickly, and then ignited one end, Gil held forth the supposed treasure, and loud exclamations of joy and surprise burst from the lips of all, as they saw what at first glance seemed to be a mass of sparkling fire in the boy’s hand.

“They’re diamonds!” Gil cried, with yet greater excitement. “A whole string of them, and there must be more that’s valuable where these came from.”

Not until the paper had been entirely consumed did either member of the party cease to gaze at the wondrously brilliant gems, and then all realized that they had neglected to look for wood with which to make a torch.

“We must use more matches,” Nelse said, breathlessly, “and if we can’t find wood here, one must venture out, for we’re bound to know what is in that hole before morning.”

“I reckon we’ll stay right in this spot till Jenkins comes back, seein’s how we’re prisoners so long as the rope is at the bottom of the shaft,” Gil

replied, grimly; “but it won’t be so very hard to wait, now we know the treasure has been found. I wonder how much more there is?”

“Did you feel anything else?”

“It seemed as if there were a lot of packages, done up in rotten sail-cloth as these were. I felt around some, but didn’t dare to move very much, for fear of getting another fall.”

“Was the place a regular cave, or only a hole?”

“I think it’s a room built to hide things in, for there seemed to be a floor of rock, though, of course, a good deal of earth fell in with me, and made it appear as if filled nearly full; but I could take several steps in half-a-dozen directions.”

During this conversation the sailors had ignited another of the precious matches, and learned to their great disappointment that there was nothing in the shaft out of which a torch might be made.

“We can afford to wait,” Gil said, philosophically, and he had hardly ceased speaking when a low hail from the surface caused all hands to spring to their feet.

“Hello below! Everything goin’ on ship-shape?”

“Who’s there?” one of the sailors asked, cautiously.

“Me—Jenkins. I only came to see if anything had gone wrong, an’ now I know you’re all right I’ll do a little more skirmishin’. I haven’t found anything to bring the water in yet.”

“Come down first!” Gil whispered. “We’ve found a lot of diamonds!”

“What?”

“We’ve got fifteen or twenty big diamonds——”

“Pass up the rope, an’ be quick about it!”

The sailors did in a few seconds what might have taken the boys a long while to do, and Jenkins came down with the greatest possible speed.

As a matter of course, it was necessary to use more matches in order to show him the treasure, and he literally gasped with surprise when the

glittering gems were held before his eyes.

“Talk about luck, boys!” he cried, in delight. “Why, sich a sight as that makes up for the scrape we’re in, an’ if it was twice as bad I wouldn’t have it changed, providin’ we could get as much more out of the business. That old picture amounted to somethin’ after all, didn’t it; but we might never have read the thing right, an’ it’s mighty fortunate them imps forced us to cover.”

Again Gil was forced to repeat his story, and when it was concluded the mate insisted on making an examination of the excavation at once.

“There’s plenty of time to look for water after we know how much you’ve found. I’d rather see diamonds than drink the best stuff these old pirates ever took on board.”

“Get the torch, an’ we’ll all go,” Gil said, with a laugh, for he felt very jolly, despite the enemies who would soon hunt him down, now the location of the treasure had been discovered.

Jenkins climbed to the mouth of the shaft as nimbly as a cat, returning a few moments later, after having thrown down inflammable material sufficient to provide the party with light for many hours.

Binding together several pieces of fatty wood, and coiling the rope on his arm, the mate led the way into the tunnel a short distance, where the torch was ignited, and the work of searching for the pirates’ wealth began.

There was no difficulty in finding the place where Gil had sunk through the bottom of the passage. The earth had given way at one side of the tunnel, until a hole fully a yard square was formed, and, peering into this, the excited ones could see a small chamber, which was evidently hewn from the solid rock.

The size or shape could not be determined, but that made little difference just then, so eager were all to know what was concealed beneath.

“You two wait to help us up,” Jenkins said to the sailors, “and after we’ve had a squint at the place you shall have a chance.”

“Will stayin’ here keep us out of a share of the stuff?” one of the men asked, as if doubtful whether he would be dealt with fairly.

“Not a bit of it,” Gil replied, quickly. “I suppose you will be satisfied to have father make a division of everything that’s found, and what he says is fair you shall have.”

“We’re ready to trust to the captain’s way of sizin’ the thing up.”

“I reckon you’ll have to be,” Jenkins growled, “for when it comes down to what is square, neither of us are entitled to anything. The picture belonged to the boys, an’ we come here in the captain’s employ, drawin’ good wages, so the profits of the voyage oughter go to him the same as if the *Day Dream* had got these diamonds for freightin’ a cargo.”

“But this ain’t the same thing as freightin’, by a long shot,” was the sulky reply. “We’re on land now, an’ the yacht is at the bottom, consequently we’re our own masters.”

“You won’t say that when it comes to a question of drawin’ wages.”

“It ain’t any sure thing that we’ll be paid for this kind of work.”

“Now see here,” Gil said, in a tone of authority, “we won’t have any quarreling. Whatever treasure may be found shall benefit all hands in such proportion as father may think best, though, of course, it wouldn’t be right to divide it into even shares.”

“We don’t expect as much as he gets, but want a fair divvy,” the second man said, sulkily, and the boys understood that the finding of the diamonds had but given them a new cause for anxiety, since the sailors, made greedy by the sight of the gems, might prove worse enemies even than the blacks.

“You heard the promise that Gil made, which was more than reasonable, considerin’ they’re entitled to everything if the matter should go inter a court of law, an’ now hold your tongues,” Jenkins said, angrily. “We’re standin’ here fightin’ when at least one of us should be in the shaft to know if anything is goin’ on wrong outside, an’ there’ll be plenty of time to settle the division part when we’ve found all that’s below.”

“You are takin’ up more time chinnin’ than we did,” the older of the men replied, insolently, and Gil began to regret having made the discovery so soon.

Jenkins remained silent a moment as if trying to decide what should be done to check the apparent mutiny before it assumed dangerous

proportions, and Gil whispered:

“Don’t pay any attention to what they say. Neither of them will be dissatisfied after father comes, no matter how much we may find.”

“I was wonderin’ whether we hadn’t better stop the whole thing right here, an’ let the captain——”

He ceased speaking very suddenly, for at that instant a shrill cry was heard from the direction of the shaft, and Nelse said, as he ran forward:

“That was Andy! The blacks have got hold of him!”

---

## CHAPTER XXV.

### TO THE RESCUE.

As the boys started down the tunnel in response to the continued cries for help, Jenkins extinguished the torch and caught up the rope.

He understood that the old cook must have been very near the shaft when he made the frenzied appeal, otherwise his voice could not have been heard so distinctly, and there was no necessity of letting it be known any one else was in the vicinity.

Even the sailors, eager though they were to share the treasure, did not hesitate at first to rush to the rescue and, for the time being, everything save Andy's danger was forgotten.

On arriving at the shaft, Nelse prudently halted until his companions could join him, and Jenkins, who arrived a second later, whispered:

"Don't even breathe loud. There's no tellin' where some of them imps may be, an' as likely as not half-a-dozen are above there waiting to find out if we are here."

This injunction was obeyed implicitly until a few moments later, when another scream was heard, and this time the listeners could hear distinctly the words:

"Gil! Nelse! Fur de lub ob heaben help de ole man! De debbils has done cotched me, an' I'se boun' ter be sarved like you'se——"

This prayer for aid ended in a smothered groan or shriek, as if the speaker's mouth had suddenly been closed against his will, and Gil whispered to the mate:

"We mustn't stand still here and let them kill him."

"There's nothin' we can do in the darkness, an' while the whole crowd are most likely layin' low in the hope that we'll rush out."

"But remember what he did for us! If he hadn't taken some chances then we should have been murdered, and it is better for us to run every risk now, rather than stay here idle at such a time."

Jenkins remained silent and motionless for several moments, as if studying the situation, and then he said, speaking slowly and thoughtfully:

“I’ll try my hand at helpin’ the old man, providin’ you boys agree not to leave this place if the blacks succeed in getting hold of me.”

“We’ll do nothing of the kind,” Gil replied, indignantly. “It’s not likely you’ll be able to accomplish very much alone, but with all hands we may manage to get the old fellow out of their clutches. Surely with the weapons we can make a rush they can’t stand.”

“That might work if it was daylight, but in the night we have no means of knowin’ where to find the scoundrels.”

“But we can’t wait until morning,” Nelse nodded. “They’ll kill him before that time.”

“An’ we shall share the same fate, I’m afraid,” Jenkins replied, in hopeless tone.

The sailors had not joined in the conversation, but stood a short distance inside the tunnel, discussing, as the boys believed, the situation in cautious whispers.

Neither Gil nor Nelse proposed to remain idle while one member of the party was in peril, even though he had brought the trouble on himself by refusing to remain with the others, and the former insisted most peremptorily that the mate decide upon some plan of action in which all could join.

“If you don’t, we shall go alone, for we won’t have it to think of that the poor fellow was killed because we refused to help him.”

“It’ll take half-an-hour to get out of here, now the rope has been pulled down,” Jenkins said, as if on the point of yielding to their demands.

“Then so much the more reason why we should begin without delay. Come on, Nelse, we’ll do all that is possible, and let the others join us or stay here as they choose.”

As he spoke, Gil began to grope around the sides of the shaft in order to select that portion where the earth was packed solidly, for the task of cutting



his way upward, and had dug with his knife a hole for one of his feet, when Jenkins approached.

“Now see here, boys, I’m willin’ to do all I can, so there’s no use in startin’ off before you’re ready. Besides, you’ll never get out by working in that way.”

“Go ahead, then; show us how, and we’ll do our share.”

Calling the sailors to him, Jenkins mounted on their shoulders, which brought his hands within a short distance of the surface, and there he stood some moments listening.

No sound betokened the presence of any of the enemy, although there was every reason to suppose one or more might be waiting for just such a move on the part of the white men, and then, digging his hands and feet into the loose earth, the agile mate succeeded in clambering to the top.

“Pass up the rope,” he whispered, and when this was done he directed the boys to tie one end under their arms.

“I’ll pull you two up, an’ the others can look out for themselves. Bring the revolvers, knives, an’ hatchets, for I reckon we shall need everything we’ve got in the way of weapons.”

The sailors helped the boys secure the rope under their arms, and assisted in gathering the articles of defense; but when the two had been drawn to the surface the men made no move toward joining them.

“Why don’t you come up?” Jenkins whispered, impatiently.

“’Cause we’ve concluded to stay here. This ain’t no scrape of ours, an’, seein’s we’re only ’foremast hands, it’s better manners to stay where we are.”

“They intend to hunt for the treasure,” Nelse whispered, and Gil replied, in the same cautious tone:

“That’s a fact; but I don’t see how we can help ourselves. It’s better to let them get away with everything than for us to stop here guarding whatever may be in the underground chamber while poor old Andy is being murdered.”

“I reckon they won’t get very far off if they should try to play us a scurvy trick,” Jenkins said, thus showing that he also was thinking the sailors meditated treachery. “We’ll pass back the rope, an’ make it a reasonably hard job for ’em to crawl out.”

“Then you think they stayed behind to have a look at the place I found?” Gil said, interrogatively.

“Of course; why else would they refuse to go with us? I knowed trouble was brewin’ from the way they talked about dividin’ the stuff, an’ perhaps we’ll be gettin’ out cheap if they take all that’s left. Have you got the diamonds?”

“They are in my breastpocket.”

“Then let ’em go ahead, an’ it ain’t no dead certain thing that we won’t overhaul ’em before your father comes back. We’ve got all the weapons, an’ they’ll be in a tight place if the blacks want to make a rush through the tunnel. Now, that’s enough for them, an’ we’ll turn our attention to huntin’ for Andy. Foller me, an’ I’ll guarantee to find him; but whether it’ll be possible to do the poor fellow any good is another matter.”

Each of the little party had a revolver, and the total number of cartridges was sixteen, therefore they could make quite a spirited fight, provided it was not prolonged. This fact served to give the boys no slight degree of courage, and as Jenkins led the way through the underbrush, where it was so dark that one could not see objects twenty inches in advance, both felt positive the cook would be rescued in time.

Although Jenkins appeared to be walking at random, he was in reality pursuing the most direct course possible for the cave, since it was more than probable the prisoner had been taken to that stronghold.

After half-an-hour’s rapid traveling the mate halted, and, parting the branches in front of him, pointed to the reflection of a fire about fifty yards away.

“That’s where we’ll find cookee, or I’m a Dutchman. These cattle don’t seem to be able to do anything without havin’ a big blaze to work by, an’ we’ve only got to crawl up there in order to see him.”

“Go ahead quickly, or we may be too late.”

“I reckon they’ll take plenty of time to carve him up. It seems they’re countin’ on catchin’ the whole of us without much trouble, or else some of ’em would have been hangin’ around the entrance to the shaft waitin’ for us to come out.”

“Perhaps they didn’t know we were there. It isn’t safe to trust to chances, and we ought to end matters as soon as possible.”

Jenkins did not wait to argue further, but continued the advance cautiously, his companions remaining close behind him, until they were where it was possible to see the main body of the enemy.

The number of the blacks had at least been doubled since the boys saw them last, and that they felt perfectly secure from an attack could be told by the fact that all were gathered around an enormous fire, without having taken the precaution to post sentinels.

At the mouth of the big cave, tied hand and foot, was poor old Andy. On either side stood a burly black man, whose body was covered with grotesque ornaments, and the entire party were waiting in silence for the coming of the old mummers, or, at least, so the boys judged from the expectant manner in which all gazed toward the entrance.

“If we had a hundred rounds of ammunition, I wouldn’t be afraid to open fire on the crowd this minute, an’ it’s ten to one that they’d be cleaned out in twenty minutes, or made to take to their boats.”

“But we haven’t got that number of cartridges, and it seems to me we had better begin operations mighty soon, for it’ll be harder after the old fellows are there to urge the rest on,” Gil suggested, and Nelse expressed the same opinion by saying:

“Suppose we make a rush? We can fire half-a-dozen shots at short range, and jump in on them while they are in confusion.”

“It’s takin’ a big risk,” Jenkins replied, thoughtfully.

“Of course it is, but we’ve got to run the chances, or give up all hopes of doing anything.”

It was only natural for Jenkins to hesitate, knowing, as he did, that Captain Mansfield would hold him responsible if anything happened to the boys while they were thus virtually under his charge, but both were so persistent

and impatient that he was forced to act upon their suggestion or see them start off alone.

“We’ll try it,” he said, with a long-drawn breath; “but remember, if anything goes wrong, that I advised ag’in a battle where we’re outnumbered at least ten to one.”

“I’ll take it on myself to say you shan’t be blamed, no matter how badly we are beaten,” Gil replied. “Now are you ready?”

“Yes; have your revolvers in hand. We’ll creep up as near as we can, an’ when I give the signal each must shoot as fast as he can till we’ve given ’em three shots apiece; then make a rush for Andy, an’ if we get hold of him, make the best time for the shaft. That’ll draw the whole crowd down on us, an’ we haven’t any water; but he’ll be safe for a while.”

“Go ahead; we’ll follow. Move quick, for it don’t improve a fellow’s courage to stand here thinking about what’s to be done.”

---

## CHAPTER XXVI.

### A PITCHED BATTLE.

It was not necessary for the boys to advise Jenkins to move quickly, since he was quite as eager as they to have the desperate affair settled.

That he should feel nervous was not to be wondered at, for he realized fully how many chances there were against success, and in case of a triumph, bought at the expense of a dangerous wound to one or the other of the boys, the mate knew only too well that Captain Mansfield would bring him to a rigid accounting.

“This is where I’m bound to get the worst of it anyhow,” he muttered to himself as he crept forward to a cleared spot, where it would be possible to use the revolver to advantage, “an’ I don’t know as it makes much difference how the thing turns out. If we get the best of it here, we’ve got to settle with the sailors, who, if any amount of treasure has been found, will be ripe for mischief.”

Then, as if in desperation, he leveled his weapon, gave the signal for all to be ready, and fired three shots in rapid succession.

The boys followed his example, except, perhaps, that they did not take as careful aim, for the idea of shooting, with intent to kill, at a human being, was, despite the gravity of the situation, something at which their better nature revolted.

The reports of the weapons rang out in a scattering fashion, causing it to sound as if ten instead of three men were firing, and, as the smoke arose, preventing any view of the enemy, Jenkins shouted:

“Now for it, boys!”

The little party dashed across the cleared space without knowing what effect the bullets had had.

A cheer went up from Gil as the greater number of the enemy were seen fleeing into the cave, each man so determined to gain a place of safety first that the entrance was literally choked, and those who were prevented from entering could do no less than turn at bay.

“We’ve frightened ’em too much!” Jenkins cried as he dashed toward Andy, hoping to sever his bonds while the blacks were yet panic-stricken, and the words were hardly spoken when he found his progress barred by two burly fellows who had come to a halt at the mouth of the cavern where their companions were packed so closely that it was impossible for them to take another step forward.

“Look out for Andy!” Jenkins cried, as he raised his hatchet to ward off a blow aimed at him by a heavy ax. “I can hold my own here if you’ll attend to him.”

The boys were so excited that they hardly heard the words, but, since both were aiming for the same object, the command was involuntarily obeyed.

Lying prostrate on the ground where he had been overturned by the first frenzied rush, the old man was holding up his hands that the bonds might be severed, and with one slash of his knife Gil succeeded in cutting the ropes of grass.

Nelse had fallen over a wounded black as he reached the prisoner’s side, but he managed to scramble to his feet and sever the remaining bonds before Gil could do anything more, and the cook leaped up, and seized a huge club from a pile of wood near the fire, thus adding one more to the small numbers of the attacking party.

The boys’ first impulse was to escape with the rescued man, but a glance toward Jenkins told that he was in sore need of assistance, and both darted to his side.

The enemy were so active that the mate had not been able to deal a single blow with any effect, and pressed him so hotly that he did not have an opportunity to draw his revolver.

“Shoot that biggest imp!” he shouted, as his friends gained his side. “I’ll attend to the other!”

Gil aimed directly at the fellow’s head, for it was no time to hesitate about shedding blood, but before he could discharge the weapon Andy came to the rescue.

With one swinging blow of his huge club he sent both the blacks sprawling on the ground, and Jenkins shouted, as he leaped back:

“Save all your cartridges now, an’ make a dash for the bushes!”

It was quite time the white party beat a retreat, for the panic-stricken ones had been turned, probably by the old men in the cave, and were now returning to the fight. When they should realize how few were those who made the attack it would hardly be possible to check them, and Jenkins’ only hope was to gain a shelter before this fact was known.

So far as could be ascertained in this brief interval of time, none of the blacks had been killed, but several were wounded, and these lay on the ground where, unless their fear was too great, they could see the whites as they ran toward the bushes.

One of the boldest of those who were returning to the fray ran after the retreating party with an uplifted ax, but Jenkins put a bullet through his arm, and he fled once more, screaming as if in mortal agony, toward the cave, thus checking the pursuit momentarily.

It was hardly more than three minutes from the time the first shot was fired before those who had made the brave charge were within shelter of the foliage, waiting to regain their breath, and the mate said, in a tone of deepest relief:

“We’ve come out of that mighty lucky, and now if we can get to the shaft before they gather their wits, there’s a chance of pullin’ through all right; but I allow, Andy, that you’re willin’ to stay with us after this.”

“I’s e boun’ to do dat; but I’s e gwine ter hol’ to it dat dere’s no use in stoppin’ whar de hoodoo is mighty strong.”

“It wasn’t strong enough to prevent us from getting you clear after they had you trussed up like a chicken ready for roasting,” Gil said, grimly, panting so hard that he could speak only with difficulty.

“Dat’s a fac’, honey; but de charm was wha’ did de mos’ ob it.”

“You was left alone with your charm, and would have been killed if we hadn’t followed at risk of our own lives, so I don’t want to hear any more about that thing,” Nelse replied, sharply. “If it were of the same power you seem to think, there would have been no need of us.”

“Dere’s some tings it carn’t do, ob course; but when you sees it I’s e suah you’s e gwine ter fall right down in ’sprise.”

“Then why didn’t you show it to those fellows when they caught you, an’ saved us all this trouble.”

“I hadn’t de time, honey. Dey done cum so quick I couldn’t mo’n wink afore de ropes was woun’ all ober me.”

“You managed to make considerable noise, just the same.”

“Dat’s wha’ I’s e boun’ ter do so’s you’s e would hyar me.”

“There’s no use arguin’ with the old fool,” Jenkins said, impatiently. “We’ve got to get back to the shaft, an’ if we don’t move mighty lively the whole crowd will be down on us.”

Even in the face of their danger the boys had allowed their thoughts to be occupied with the cook to the exclusion of everything else, and now, as they gazed toward the fire, it could be seen that the blacks were making ready for a regular battle.

The repulsive-looking old men had come from the cave, and were now addressing their followers, probably for the purpose of inciting them to fight, and the more courageous had already advanced toward the thicket, as if ready to wreak vengeance.

Four were receiving considerable attention as their companions bound up the wounds inflicted by the revolvers; but none were in such a dangerous condition but that they could give a good account of themselves in the chase which would probably ensue, and Jenkins said, regretfully:

“We oughter been more careful. What they want is a good lesson, an’ if we’d succeeded in killin’ half a dozen, the rest wouldn’t be so bold.”

“We’ve done mischief enough,” Gil said, with a shudder, “and if we can get back to the tunnel it is to be hoped they’ll leave us alone.”

“That’s exactly what they don’t intend to do, my boy. See! they are after us hot foot already!”

It was as Jenkins had said. The entire crowd were beginning to move down the slope from the cave, and there was no longer any hope of being allowed to retire peacefully.

“It has turned into a runnin’ fight,” the mate said, as he examined his revolver. “You fellows must start, an’ I’ll try to hold ’em in check a little.



Then I'll join you, an' we'll work the same game over again. Andy, can you lead the way to the shaft?"

"I'se able ter do dat much."

"Then go, and don't wait for me until I've fired three times. After that I shall come on the best I know how."

The old man started through the underbrush after assuring himself that the boys were close behind, and during the next five minutes the three traveled at a rapid pace without hearing the slightest sound from the rear.

Then came two shots in succession, and Gil would have stopped but that the old darky reminded him they should hear another before coming to a halt, and in less than a minute the third rang out so near at hand that it seemed as if Jenkins must have been standing close beside them when he fired.

"Where are you?" Nelse cried, and the mate replied:

"Don't speak so loud. They are right behind, and our only hope is to throw them off the scent, or we may not be able to get under cover."

"Even if we gain the shaft it is only a question of being starved out."

"Very true; but we can stand considerable hunger an' thirst before we'll come out to be killed."

Now it was Jenkins who led the way, and he traveled at full speed until the footsteps of the pursuers could be heard close in the rear, when he halted.

"Go on, boys; I'll try to stop 'em once more, an' on the next tack we must sight the shaft, or give up all hope of gettin' back there."

"Come on, chillun! Don't stop now when dem debbils are so nigh!" Andy shouted, and in another instant a cry of terror burst from his lips as he ran almost into the arms of a black man.

The devotees of voodooism were not so dumb as the mate had fancied, and instead of following behind, a portion had circled around the party, thus cutting off the line of the proposed retreat.

"Why don't you go on?" Jenkins cried, angrily.

"Because they have succeeded in surrounding us," Gil replied, but by no means calmly. "It's a question of fighting, now, whether we want to or not."

“Then be careful that every shot tells,” the mate cried, taking no heed of the fact that in the intense darkness it was impossible to do more than fire at random.

---

## CHAPTER XXVII.

### UNDER COVER.

In an instant every one of the fugitives realized that perfect silence was of the utmost importance in aiding them to ascertain the location of the enemy, and not one moved or spoke during the minute which followed the alarming discovery.

Then could be heard the stealthy footsteps of those who were tracking them to the death, and Jenkins fancied he saw a way out of the dangerous situation.

Pressing the hand of Nelse, who was nearest, he intimated that the boy was to follow him, and the latter, in turn, communicated the command by the same means to Gil and Andy.

The mate's purpose was to steal off at an angle, and thus avoid the enemy, who was steadily closing in on them, for a hand-to-hand conflict was not to be thought of for a single instant, and that was what must come in a very short time, unless the pursued could escape the net which was being drawn tighter each moment.

Stealthily the four crept toward the left, advancing slowly but surely each instant until, just when all began to fancy the plan might be a success, it was Jenkins' turn to run plump into the arms of one of the enemy.

During a few seconds neither of his companions understood why he halted so suddenly, nor what caused the unusual rustling among the foliage, and then Gil realized, more by the sense of touch than of sight, that the mate was putting forth all his strength in a struggle for the mastery, the loser of which might expect only death.

For an instant it seemed singular that the black did not summon others to his aid, and then Gil learned that the sailor had grasped his adversary by the throat, thus preventing him from making any outcry.

Once this discovery had been made, the only question was as to how the mate might be assisted, and Gil could think of no way, except to seize the man by the legs, which he did with such suddenness and strength that the

fellow was hurled to the ground, his head striking an uncovered root a resounding thump that deprived him of consciousness.

Now was the time to continue the flight, for every second was precious, and the little party pushed on through the underbrush at a rate of speed that promised to give them a decided advantage over possible pursuers.

At the best pace each ran, Jenkins leading the way, the others following in single file, each grasping the clothing of the one in advance that they might not be separated. The blows received by coming in contact with the low-hanging branches were not noticed in this race for life, nor did any heed the dangers that might be encountered by a misstep, or a mistake as to the course; but all pressed on literally for dear life, and when twenty minutes had passed Jenkins paused at the mouth of the shaft.

Not a sound could be heard to betoken that the enemy were in pursuit, and the mate was on the point of whispering to the sailors to pass up the rope, when Gil said:

“Here it is, made fast to the tree as when we left.”

“And they were so crazy about the treasure that it wasn’t thought worth while to look out for safety. It would have been a nice mess, if those imps had come here ahead of us, an’ taken a notion to find the meaning of such a ladder.”

“Never mind that now,” Gil said, soothingly, as he saw that the mate was likely to linger too long over this neglect of duty. “Let’s get below first, and talk about what should have been done afterward.”

“Go down; I’ll wait until you are at the bottom, so’s to make sure the black villains haven’t yet discovered our hiding-place.”

Gil swung himself over the edge, and allowed the rope to slip slowly through his hands until he reached the bottom.

Neither of the two men came to ask the result of the foray, and he thought with surprise that they must be sleeping.

It was necessary every member of the party should be on the alert, and he went into the tunnel to awaken them, feeling around with his hands.

Nothing could be found. It was as if the place had been abandoned. Pressing farther in he continued the blind search, but without success, and finally the truth of the matter flashed upon him. Running to the shaft, arriving there just as Jenkins descended, the others having reached the bottom in safety, he said, excitedly:

“The sailors have gone to help us, and now I suppose we ought to start out to find them, though it seems like advertising our whereabouts to the enemy.”

“Do you mean that neither of the fellows are here?” Jenkins asked, in surprise.

“Not unless they are in the treasure chamber. I went up the tunnel as far as I dared without a light, and found it empty. I suppose they thought we were getting the worst of it when the firing was heard, and wanted to help.”

“Not a bit of it,” the mate said, angrily. “They’ve been overhaulin’ the treasure; taken all they could find, an’ now propose to give us the slip.”

“It doesn’t seem reasonable they would run so many risks just for a little money.”

“The chances are that they’ve found a good deal, and rather than divide, or be contented with what the captain might choose to give them, have parted company with us.”

“That seems like suicide, for they can’t show themselves when father arrives without giving up what has been carried away.”

“Most likely they count on stealin’ a boat from the blacks, an’ gettin’ to the mainland; but they’ll find that a mighty slim chance. I wish I had hold of the sneaks for a minute, I’d show them what it means to play such a trick.”

“Don’t bother your head about it. We are well rid of men who will act like that.”

“But they’ve made way with all the treasure you discovered, most likely,” and in his anger Jenkins spoke incautiously loud.

“What of it? The chances are neither they nor we can leave the island with it, and our lives are more precious than all the pirates’ hoards that were ever buried.”

The mate failed to look at the matter in such a philosophical light, and he would have continued to give way to his anger in unmeasured terms, if a noise from the entrance had not warned him to be silent.

Animated by the same thought, each member of the party crept to the edge of the shaft, and there the hum of voices proclaimed that the secret of their hiding-place had been discovered.

“We’re under cover now, for a fact,” Jenkins said, grimly, as the sound of footsteps told that the enemy were moving to and fro, evidently for the purpose of examining the surroundings, “and the worst of it is that we’re reg’larly shut in till the captain comes back, for I’ll guarantee that crowd don’t leave while we are down here alive.”

“Then the sailors are better off than we, and have a good chance to get hold of the boats.”

“It ain’t likely these imps are so careless as to leave the crafts where anybody can get them, an’ we shall have to wait till mornin’ before knowin’ who’s in the best condition. We’ll have a few oysters, an’ then try to get a little sleep, for there’s no danger of an attack between now an’ daylight.”

“I couldn’t close my eyes a single minute while that crowd is waiting around to kill us,” Nelse said, with a shudder.

“Don’t be so sure, lad; you’ll get used to it in a little while, an’ the need for sleep will come mighty strong before morning.”

Nelse was positive Jenkins spoke at random, and he also thought he couldn’t eat anything under the circumstances; but when his companions attacked the oysters he succeeded in swallowing quite as many as did Gil, and even Andy made a hearty supper.

It was no longer possible to hear any noise from around the mouth of the shaft; but the besieged knew beyond a doubt that the enemy were still there, and, acting upon the mate’s suggestion, all hands moved a short distance inside the tunnel, where they could talk without danger of being overheard.

As a matter of course, every one was anxious to hear the story of Andy’s adventures, and he was able to tell it in a very few words.

After refusing to enter the tunnel with the remainder of the party, the old man had made his way toward the interior of the island, hoping to find a

hiding-place in some of the trees, and succeeded only in losing his way.

After walking nearly an hour, he found himself in sight of the big cave where the blacks were assembled in full force, and this so frightened him that he thought only of trying to find his comrades. To that end he struck out in the direction where he supposed the shaft to be located, and was within a few yards of the desired spot when he was seized by five men.

From that moment until the revolvers were discharged, Andy had no hope anything could be done to aid him, and, losing faith for the first time in his mysterious charm, prepared for death.

It was evident from the manner of telling the story that he did not care to go into the details, after having brought the trouble all on himself, and a remark made by Gil relative to the treasure-chamber gave him a good excuse for changing the topic of conversation.

“Am it sure dem men took all de gol’ dere was in de hole?” he asked, and Nelse said, with some slight show of enthusiasm:

“What’s to prevent us from finding out exactly the condition of affairs? We’ve got to stay here, and an examination of the place will serve to make the time pass more quickly.”

“Perhaps we might be needed here suddenly,” Gil suggested; but Jenkins said, decidedly:

“I’ll guarantee there’ll be nothin’ goin’ on in this part of the island till sunrise, so if you feel disposed to have a look at the place after them scoundrels have got away with the treasure, there’s nothing to prevent.”

“Somebody will have to help us down. I wouldn’t want to try to lower Nelse alone.”

“Andy can attend to that part of the business. Let him stand by the rope, an’, in case anything should happen which ain’t probable, I can pass the word to him.”

“Is yer gwine ter keep right on lookin’ fur de pirates’ gol’?” the old man asked, in evident alarm.

“Yes, we want to see if the men have left any.”

“Den I stays right hyar. We’s done had trubble enuff ’bout dat ar’ money, an’ I wants ter keep ’way frum it.”

It was in vain that the boys and Jenkins alternately coaxed and scolded; the old fellow positively refused to so much as take a single step into the tunnel, and it seemed as if the investigations would necessarily be postponed until a more convenient season.

---



## CHAPTER XXVIII.

### A SECOND ALARM.

The old darky's superstitious fears sometimes resembled stubbornness, as in this particular case, and Gil, after exhausting his powers of persuasion without effect, said impatiently:

"It's mighty strange that you're always afraid when there's something on hand in the shape of work."

"Cummin' to dis yere islan' wasn' none ob my fixin', an' ef de captin would er lef' me I'd done been gone outer de yacht afore she got pas' New York Harbor, kase I knowed wha' was goin' ter happen," and then Andy relapsed into moody silence.

The fact that they could not examine the treasure-chamber caused the boys the most intense desire to do so, and finally Nelse suggested that they try it alone.

"I'll contrive to lower you down, Gil, an' Mr. Jenkins can come into the tunnel long enough to help pull you out."

"I've got a better plan than that," the mate said, suddenly, as a happy thought occurred to him. "Andy shall stay here to listen for the blacks, an' I'll bear a hand. After you've been there long enough I can come after you."

"I'se willin' to stan' watch ef all hands wants ter go," Andy added, gruffly, and thus the matter was settled, although it would be necessary for Jenkins to remain in the tunnel.

The old darky seated himself with his back against the side of the shaft, a very dangerous position if any of the enemy should descend quickly, and the others commenced operations.

The torches were found in the tunnel where they had been dropped when Andy's cry for help was heard, and, as he ignited one, Jenkins said:

"Now have a good look around, boys, an' make sure them thieves didn't leave anything behind."

"Perhaps there was nothing but the diamonds in the hole," Nelse suggested.

“I don’t allow pirates would go to the trouble of diggin’ sich a place for the sake of hidin’ a little thing like that. Have you still got them safe, Gil?”

“Trust me for that. Even while we were stealing up on the enemy, I kept feeling in my pocket to make sure they couldn’t get lost.”

“I allow there’s more than enough in them ’ere stones to pay for the *Day Dream*, an’ leave some over to tassel our handkerchiefs with. Now, are you ready?”

While they were speaking, Jenkins had been uncoiling the rope, and began to fasten one end under Gil’s arms as he spoke.

Then, lifting the boy clear from the ground, he let him drop slowly to the bottom with the torch in his hand.

The same operation was repeated with Nelse, and the two had ample opportunity to examine the subterranean chamber.

It had been built with exceeding care. The sides, which were cut in a coral ledge, as was the entire excavation, had been chiseled smooth, an operation which must have required no slight amount of time, and in the roof were what appeared to be two small apertures for the escape of air.

These details, however, were not noted by the boys until they had been in the cavern some time. Their first, and, in fact, only thought was of the supposed treasure.

The large amount of earth which had fallen when Gil was precipitated into the chamber, covered one end of the apartment entirely, and the fact of this having been thrown around considerably told that it had been overhauled to a considerable extent since Gil was drawn up, while the fragments of what he believed to be a box were scattered in every direction.

“There’s no question but that the men have been here,” Nelse said, sufficiently loud for Jenkins, who was lying over the aperture in such a manner that he could both hear and see, to distinguish the words.

“Of course they have,” the mate replied, angrily, “an’ that’s why they wouldn’t come with us to help Andy. Do you see anything?”

“Nothing more than this pile of dirt,” Gil replied. “If the spade is in the shaft we might throw it all over, an’ make sure they got everything.”

“That’s a good idea. Wait a minute an’ I’ll fetch it.”

Jenkins’ face disappeared from the aperture, and while he was absent the boys had a good opportunity to survey the singular place. In addition to what has already been spoken of, they noted with no small degree of surprise, that the remains of a stone stairway occupied one corner of the chamber, and immediately above it was a portion of a wooden hatch or trapdoor set in the earth by iron bands.

It was directly in the center of this, where the wood had decayed, that Gil fell, and the wonder was that he did not strike on the steps, in which case the mishap might have had a more unpleasant ending.

“All I can say is that the pirates must have had a lot of spare time on their hands, if they went to all the trouble necessary to make a place like this just to bury their treasure, when it would have been safer buried in the earth where a fellow couldn’t fall through by mistake, as you did,” Nelse said, laughingly. “It looks as if some one had the idea of living here.”

Before Gil could reply Jenkins arrived with the spade, and he said, as the implement was dropped on the loose earth:

“Better make a thorough search, boys, an’ if you think the work is likely to be too hard, come back, an’ I’ll go down.”

“We’ll attend to it. It can’t take such a very long time to get at the bottom,” Gil replied, as he began the task.

During five minutes of rapid work nothing was disclosed; but at the end of that time Gil unearthed a bench which had been crushed by the falling earth, and after that the discoveries came thick and fast.

Fragments of chairs, a mass of decaying matter which appeared to have been wearing apparel, rusty cooking implements, and, finally, in one corner, a low writing desk was found.

As the last-mentioned article was unearthed the boys gave vent to a cry of triumph, and Gil shouted excitedly:

“Here’s where we shall find the gold that the sailors overlooked.”

“I reckon you’re makin’ a mistake about that, my boy,” Jenkins replied, in a thoughtful tone. “It looks to me as if this place was used to live in, an’ most

likely what treasure the people had who built the place was in the chest you fell on. If there were diamonds in it, the gold was there to a dead certainty, an' we shan't see anything more in the way of valuables."

"It won't take long to find out what is in here," and Gil struck the ancient desk a heavy blow with the spade, causing it to fall in fragments.

At this instant the torch was extinguished, the wood having been consumed, and the eager explorers were forced to wait until Jenkins could make and send down another.

Now they searched carefully among the fragments, and the first article found was a metal casket covered with rust, and securely locked.

"Here's what we want!" Gil cried, triumphantly, as he held it above his head that the mate might have a full view. "When this is opened we shall see a pile of gold!"

"It doesn't appear to be very heavy."

"You're right. I never thought of that," was the reply, in a tone of disappointment, and Gil tried in vain to open the box by striking it with the spade.

"Use this!" and Jenkins threw down one of the hatchets.

Even with such an effective implement it was not an easy matter to break the casket; but the metal finally yielded after repeated blows, and the boys gazed at the exposed contents in dismay.

Instead of treasure, they had unearthed nothing more than a lot of time-stained documents and Gil was about to throw them away when Jenkins called sharply:

"Pass them up here. We'll have a look at the writin' first, an' then'll be plenty of time to say they are worth nothing. What else was there in the desk?"

Again the boys resumed the search; but it seemed as if all the important contents of the chamber had been exposed to view.

Several tiny vials; some curious instruments, which might once have belonged to a surgeon, and a package of quills for pens, comprised the entire list of articles.

The loose earth had been examined thoroughly, and Gil said with a sigh of disappointment:

“There’s no reason why we should stay here any longer. It’s too hot down here for comfort, and we can look at the papers up above where there’s more air.”

“All right, here’s the rope. Send the iron box first, an’ then I’ll pull you out.”

Five minutes later the boys were in the tunnel, and since there could be no question but that the sailors had succeeded in getting the greater portion of the treasure, the contents of the casket attracted considerable attention.

“Let’s go up a long bit where there’s no danger the light of the torch can be noticed from the shaft, an’ see what’s written on all that paper,” Gil suggested, and Jenkins ran back to tell Andy of the change of position before following the boys to a point within twenty or thirty feet from the stone door which had been discovered some time previous.

Here the three seated themselves on the ground, and the mate was about to take the yellow documents from their long resting-place, when the torch was suddenly extinguished without apparent cause.

Nelse was on the point of making some laughing remark, when he felt the mate’s hand pressed firmly over his mouth, and at the same instant a draught of air swept down the passage as if a vent had suddenly been opened.

Motioning for the boys to follow his example, Jenkins rose to his feet, and as he did so it was possible to see a tiny thread of light from the end of the tunnel, where, a moment previous, had been only the most profound darkness.

There was no need now to speculate as to why the torch had been extinguished.

The blacks had discovered, even if they did not know it before, that the cave communicated with the tunnel, and were about to creep upon the white party, hoping to take them by surprise.

The supreme moment had come, and the three who stood in that gloomy place listening for the sounds which should tell that the enemy was

advancing, knew it was to be a struggle to the finish.



## CHAPTER XXIX.

### IN THE TUNNEL.

During several moments Jenkins remained motionless, as if trying to decide what course to pursue, and the boys bent forward in their efforts to hear the first sound which should come from the direction of that ray of light; but nothing broke the almost profound silence, save their own labored breathing.

“They are goin’ to take plenty of time about it, an’ we’ll do the same,” Jenkins whispered, cautiously, with his mouth close to Gil’s ear. “The idiots think the light don’t show through, an’ are tryin’ to find out if we’re in the tunnel.”

“Well, what’s to be done? We can’t stand here till they come.”

“Take off your shoes, an’ we’ll steal down to the shaft. We mustn’t make a stand here, for it ain’t certain a lot of ’em won’t come in from the outside at the same time.”

In their stockinged feet the three crept softly down the passage, hugging the left side to avoid being precipitated into the excavation, until they arrived at the point where Andy, clutching firmly the “charm” on his bosom, was keeping watch.

In reply to Jenkins’ whispered questions, he declared that nothing larger than a night bird had moved in the vicinity, and on being told of what was occurring at the opposite end of the tunnel, would have leaped to his feet with a cry of alarm but for the firm hold the mate had upon him.

“Sit still, an keep your wits about you while I creep back a short distance,” the latter whispered. “If you make a noise, or try to kick up any bobbery because you don’t like our way of managin’ things, I’ll shoot you as quick as I would one of them voodoo-dancin’ black men.”

This threat was sufficient to reduce Andy to a state of complete submission; but it destroyed his usefulness as a watcher, for he was no longer in a frame of mind where he could distinguish between a genuine noise and his own imagination.

“Be ready to shoot the first heathen who shows his head,” the mate said to Gil, and then he disappeared in the tunnel.

It was useless to expect any assistance from Andy, and the boys stood at the foot of the shaft listening intently, with their revolvers ready for use; but nothing save the sighing of the night wind among the foliage came to their ears.

The mate moved as noiselessly as a shadow, and the silence was almost terrifying.

The minutes passed like hours, fearing as the boys did that each instant would come the sounds of conflict, proclaiming that they must begin the struggle for life, and fully half-an-hour had passed before Jenkins appeared, saying in a low, hurried tone, as he stood beside Gil and Nelse:

“They have started. I counted six before the door was closed, an’ they’ll be here in about five minutes. Our best plan is to hug the wall of the shaft close by the entrance to the tunnel, an’ wait till they are at close range, when every shot will count.”

“We’ll do whatever you think best,” Gil replied, nervously, and the mate continued:

“We can’t fight very long with the small number of cartridges, so each one must bring down a man. If the fellows from the top join in, as I reckon they’re bound to do, keep far enough inside to prevent them from seeing the flash of the powder, an’ take to your hatchets when the last shot has been fired. It’s better to die here fightin’ than allow ourselves to be taken prisoners for their pleasure.”

“We’ll do our share,” Gil said, “and now I shan’t hesitate to try to kill a human being.”

“It’s your life or theirs, an’ you’d be foolish to have any scruples now. I’ve brought the iron box here in case there should be a chance of gettin’ out of this place; but I don’t s’pose we’ll have any call for it, because there are too many blacks for us to get the best of in a fair fight.”

Jenkins ceased speaking very suddenly, for at that moment a rustling of the leaves was heard from the top of the shaft, and all expected the onslaught would be made at once.



Even Andy understood it was a question of fighting, and that his charm would not avail him at such a time, therefore he joined the defenders, although he had no weapon.

One, two, three minutes passed, and to the boys it seemed as if every drop of blood in their bodies was literally boiling with excitement. Their mouths became parched, and each tried in vain to moisten his burning lips, as he mentally braced himself for the coming struggle.

The suspense was worse than reality, and only with the greatest difficulty could Gil prevent himself from shrieking to break the awful silence. Five minutes more passed, and it seemed as if fully half-an-hour must have elapsed when the little party were absolutely electrified by hearing a blood-curdling cry from the forest, which was echoed and re-echoed by the trees until one could have sworn a hundred men were in their last agonies.

Almost at the same instant the sound of footsteps came from the tunnel, and before the boys could draw their weapons, it was succeeded by a cry of distress from a dozen throats.

Then all was still once more.

Nelse turned toward Jenkins as if to ask whether this had simply been a trick of the imagination, and then came a cry of terror from the tunnel, repeated again and again until the air was filled with the hideous noise.

What it could mean no one knew, and as Andy cowered in mortal terror against the side of the shaft, Jenkins saw a human form outlined upon the lighter darkness of the opening.

Raising his revolver he fired, and a heavy body fell to the ground almost at their feet.

“What is the matter?” Gil asked, unable longer to remain silent.

“I’m blest if I know. Anyhow, here’s one of the villains, an’, what’s worse, he ain’t dead.”

Again a tumult in the tunnel was heard, and Nelse cried:

“The fellows who were trying to surprise us have fallen into the underground chamber. So much is certain; but what’s the meaning of that?” and he stopped for an instant as the shrieks from the forest rang out again in

such a tone of agony there could no longer be any question that a human soul was being sent to its final account.

The terrifying cries died away in the distance, even as the little party listened, and once more silence reigned, save when the wounded mass of humanity gave vent to a groan.

Unless one believed in voodooism as did Andy, everything was incomprehensible, and even the old darky could think of no satisfactory explanation just at this moment, for he cowered close to the others, shaking like one in an ague fit, and clutching with the strength of despair at the mysterious “something” concealed beneath his shirt.

One, two, three minutes more passed, and then Jenkins said, with a long-drawn breath:

“I can’t stand this sort of thing any longer, boys. We’re bound to find out what’s been goin’ on, an’ the facts can’t be any worse than a fellow’s imagination as he stands here shiverin’.”

The boys would have followed him as he went into the tunnel, but he prevented them by saying:

“Stay here, an’ keep a mighty sharp watch. Nobody knows but that all this yellin’ was done to throw us off our guard.”

“I’m certain those noises couldn’t have been made for effect, an’ you’ll find a whole crowd in the place where the diamonds came from,” Nelse replied, in a decided tone.

“Then all the more reason why some one should be there to prevent them from crawlin’ out. I can take care of a good many, if they’re in that trap; but we are bound to watch out for all the chances.”

Jenkins was so reckless as to light a match before he was more than a dozen feet inside the tunnel, and a moment after the boys saw a glow, telling that he had ignited one of the torches.

From the outside not a sound came, and in a few seconds the boys heard the mate’s cheery cry:

“You were right, Nelse. The whole boilin’ of ’em are in here like rats, an’ believe I’m goin’ to kill ’em.”

“Can you see them?” Gil asked, in surprise.

“Of course I can, as well as if the whole lot were on exhibition in a dime museum. One of you come here and take a peep, for there’s no question now but that some of their plans have gone wrong.”

Nelse ran into the tunnel in response to this invitation, and on reaching the hole saw seven black forms crouching at the bottom in deepest terror, while Jenkins was amusing himself by walking around the edge of the excavation throwing the light on the huddling mass, and threatening the poor wretches with what he proposed doing when it should be convenient.

“Do you think it is just safe to stand here while more of the party can jump in on you by the same way these came?” Nelse asked, and this question put a very sudden end to the mate’s sport.

“Wait while I have a look around,” he said, as he handed the torch to the boy and disappeared in the darkness.

Before Nelse could explain the cause of his delay to Gil, the mate returned, saying, in a tone of satisfaction:

“They’ve shut the door tight, to keep us out in case these fellows failed, I reckon, an’ it won’t be a bad idea for me to keep watch there while you an’ Gil divide the work here. We must stop any nonsense at the beginnin’, an’ then they can’t get the upper hands of us.”

“Is there a real necessity of watching this crowd?”

“Of course; otherwise they could soon manage to wriggle out by climbin’ on each other’s shoulders. Stand by and shoot the first who rises to his feet,” Jenkins replied, and then he added, in a stern tone to the trembling blacks, as if believing they could understand him: “Don’t you so much as move, or we’ll kill the whole boilin’ the same as we would mosquitoes. Lay down, an’ the first one who raises his head shall serve as an example for the rest.”

It was evident that the fellows understood the purport of his words, for they crouched yet lower, and he added to Nelse:

“Don’t hesitate to shoot if they make any show of tryin’ to get out, for our lives depend upon holdin’ the whole crowd.”

“You ought to tell Gil where I am.”

“He’s got sense enough to know that at such a time as this he must remain at his post, so do as I tell you, an’ don’t take your eyes off the gang for a single minute.”

---

## CHAPTER XXX.

### THE STORY.

Nelse did as he was bidden; but while standing at the edge of the excavation holding the torch in one hand and his revolver in the other, he could not fail to realize how quickly the tables might be turned if the blacks should make a combined dash.

That which held them in subjection was the fact that the walls of the underground chamber were so high they could not gain the floor of the tunnel without climbing on each other's shoulders, and while this was being done the sentinel would have ample opportunity to shoot with reasonable accuracy of aim.

Meanwhile Gil was straining his ears for the repetition of that fearful noise which had literally caused the blood to chill in his veins, and Andy remained crouching within the shadow of the tunnel busily engaged in executing a series of wonderful contortions evidently intended as an incantation to weaken the power of the voodoo worshipers.

During fully half an hour matters remained in this condition, not a sound save the usual night noises of the forest breaking the silence, and then the old darky, his alleged spell having been wrought, came toward Gil as he said:

"I'se gwine ter take my trick at standin' watch, an' you'se kin fin' de odders."

"It won't take much hunting to do that, for I reckon they are guarding the other end of the tunnel; but, if you can attend to matters here for a while, I'll be glad to see how things are getting on."

"I'se done gone fixed myself," was the grave reply, and Gil naturally came to the conclusion that the "fixing" was neither more nor less than those wonderful contortions in which the old darky had been indulging.

Nelse was more than pleased at seeing his friend, for the mental strain of watching over so many of the enemy was beginning to tell upon him, and, what seemed more important, the torch was nearly consumed.

“Stand here a while and I’ll make another,” he said, glad of any excuse which should take him from the chamber, with its frightened, cowering occupants, and Gil readily agreed to shoulder the responsibility.

To recount all that took place on this eventful night would be tedious. It suffices to say that a strict watch was kept at each point from which danger might be anticipated, and when morning came every member of the party felt thoroughly worn out and exhausted.

Jenkins had but little fear an attack would be made during the day, except it might be from the farther end of the tunnel, and proposed to run the risk of this by withdrawing the sentinel from that point and stationing him at the underground chamber, where his duty would be to stand watch over the entire tunnel.

“In that way we shall all get a chance to sleep, which is what we’re needin’ mighty bad, an’ I’ll take the first trick. Andy shall stay near the shaft, an’ you boys are to have a good two-hour snooze.”

“It strikes me that the torches won’t hold out a great while longer,” Nelse said, as he looked ruefully at the small supply of wood, which had diminished rapidly since the blacks were caught in the trap.

“We won’t worry about that. Time enough when we’ve used the last one. The important thing is to get some rest, an’ I want you boys to begin without delay so’s Andy an’ I can have our turn.”

Despite the fact that they had thought it would be impossible to close their eyes in slumber, while in a situation of such peril, the boys had hardly stretched themselves out on the floor of the tunnel before they were sleeping soundly.

Not until three hours later did either awaken, and then the mate aroused them with a cheery cry of:

“All hands on deck!”

To their great surprise they saw the shaft comfortably full of black men, and Jenkins said, in reply to their questions:

“Andy an’ I did that while you were snoring. We found out that the fellows in the treasure-chamber could understand a kind of lingo he talks, an’ then we made ’em know what was wanted. We brought ’em up here one by one,

after tyin' the hands of each with that string-piece he wore around his waist, an' now they're quiet an' harmless as lambs. None of 'em dares to wink very hard, an' we can do all the watchin' at this place."

"Ain't you afraid they will make a sudden rush?" Nelse asked, thinking it anything rather than safe to allow the fellows so near.

"Not while their hands are tied, an' one of us manages to keep awake. They know what the result will be if any of 'em so much as moves his head the wrong way, an' I reckon they'll stay quiet enough."

"But what about the door at the other end of the tunnel?"

"I'm takin' my chances on that 'cause we've dug away the earth at the top of the treasure-chamber, an' it'll be a mighty smart darky who can crawl along there without tumblin' in, seein's they can't afford to bring a light with 'em. You see, this does away with the trouble about torches, an' I'll admit that I don't know how we could a-got more when these were used up. Now, I'm goin' to take about forty winks. Andy has been right there for the last hour, so you can turn him out for the next trick."

As he lay down, Jenkins motioned toward the mouth of the tunnel, where the cook was sleeping with his huge mouth opened to its widest extent, and it seemed to the boys as if the former had but just stretched himself out when he was aiding Andy in the snoring concert.

Some of the prisoners had so far recovered from their fears as to be able to indulge in slumber, and those who remained awake were doing their best to convince the watchers that their intentions were peaceable.

Although the situation was decidedly improved from what it had been when the boys lay down, it was yet far from being reassuring, and not until ten minutes or more had passed did they feel at all comfortable in mind.

Then Gil said, as he saw the iron casket lying near the entrance, where Jenkins had placed it for safe keeping:

"I think it's about time we examined those documents. You keep your eyes on the fellows, an' I'll find out what's written there."

"Go ahead; but I don't believe you'll have much luck, for most likely it's in French or Spanish, an' we ain't very well posted in those languages, although we might have been by studying a little harder."

“It’s English!” Gil exclaimed, in a tone of satisfaction, as he drew the stained documents from their long resting-place, and forced to use the greatest caution in opening them lest the paper, brittle with age, should be destroyed.

“If you read it, go on, an’ I’ll keep my eyes on this crowd of very interesting young gentlemen,” Nelse said, as he settled himself into a more comfortable position for listening, and displayed his revolver ostentatiously.

“The writing is plain enough, except in places where the ink has faded, and I reckon I can get through with it, so here goes for the first sheet.”

“How many are there?”

“Seven or eight; but the most of them appear to be memoranda of business transactions, for all except the first are covered with figures. It starts off like a will:

“I, Nissage Boyer, native of France, and adopted citizen of the United States, owner of the finest plantation on the island of Hayti, and lessee of the government forest containing the most valuable dye-wood, deposit here a memoranda of my possessions in case I should never succeed in leaving this place alive, hoping it may fall into the hands of my family, who, fortunately, are now safe in New York.

“During the past year I have done my best to keep out of political entanglements; but Soulouque, who capers like a crowned monkey under his borrowed name of Faustin I., has laid many traps, some of which I have fallen into, and, in order to retain possession of my property, and at the same time send my family to a place of safety, I bound myself to his falling fortunes. Now, in the year 1857 I find myself threatened both by the emperor and insurgents. Trying to serve two masters, I have fallen to the ground, and am a fugitive, trusting to the fidelity of my slaves, and seeking an opportunity to set sail for the United States.

“Condemned to death by both parties, I should have been executed several days ago but for some of my negroes, who aided me to reach this island, where I fitted up a place of refuge



in the year Soulouque declared himself emperor, knowing full well that the evil times would soon come, and hoping this might serve as a hiding-place for my dear ones. The shaft, the tunnel and the main cave were probably built by the buccaneers who settled here in 1702; but the voodoo worshipers have made the island their abiding-place so long that none of the negroes and few white men care to visit it.

“Protected by these same voodoo priests, who have always done all in their power to frighten their countrymen away from this place, I am awaiting the arrival of a fisherman’s vessel which should be here in a week at the outside, unless the situation at the capital becomes so grave that all the sailing crafts will be seized by the alleged emperor or the so-called insurgents. I have succeeded in bringing away the most valuable of my personal property, and, in addition, a necklace of diamonds for which I sold the contents of a warehouse, taking them in exchange, since gold is not readily gotten hold of without exciting suspicion that the owner wishes to leave the island.

“The stones, together with as much money as I have been able to secrete, will remain in this subterranean chamber——”

“Look here,” Nelse cried, interrupting Gil, “according to what you’ve been reading we haven’t found any pirates’ treasure, but something for which an owner may appear at any moment.”

“That’s just the size of it, and when we give up the diamonds we sha’n’t be able to account very satisfactorily for what the sailors stole. Our story will seem rather fishy, I’m afraid; but let’s find out the balance of this communication, and then we shall know better what must be done.”

“Are we to give up all hope of coming at the gold which is described by the chart?”

“I think we may as well own up that it is a failure; but we can tell after I \_\_\_\_\_”

The conversation was interrupted by a noise from the outside, and, springing to his feet, Gil went toward the edge of the shaft, arriving there just as a shower of missiles descended.

Standing near the edge of the shaft as he did, Gil escaped a blow; but the prisoners were hit freely, and they set up such an outcry as caused Jenkins and Andy to spring to their feet very suddenly.

---

## **CHAPTER XXXI.**

### **AN OPPORTUNE ARRIVAL.**

It was several seconds before the mate understood what had happened, and then, realizing that the enemy was making an attack, he shouted as he darted into the tunnel:

“Keep your eyes open, boys, for it’s certain they’ll try to take us from both sides at the same time.”

“I reckon you and I had better hold on here,” Gil said to Nelse. “There’s mighty little use rushing into a place where you can’t see a thing, and unless we look sharp the whole crowd will be in from this end.”

Andy remained motionless, and for this he could not be blamed very severely, since he had no weapons with which to defend himself; therefore he would only be in the way of the others in case a hand-to-hand fight ensued.

Stones, fragments of trees, and even earth were thrown in from the top of the shaft, the enemy remaining concealed from the view of those at the bottom meanwhile, until the prisoners succeeded in making their friends understand that no damage was being done to the white party, and then the attack ceased at this point.

From the tunnel the boys could hear a medley of sounds; but since there was no report of firearms they rightly concluded that the danger was not sufficiently great to warrant Jenkins in making his presence known.

“What is going on in there?” Gil shouted, after five minutes passed and the din had not subsided.

“The whole boilin’ of ’em have struck the trap, an’ are flounderin’ around in great style,” the mate replied. “Are you all right out there?”

“The blacks can’t do anything without inflicting the most damage on their friends, and since understanding that fact have been quiet. There’s nothing to fear here for a while, so if you need one of us I’ll come.”

“I reckon this end of the fight is takin’ care of itself; but we’re shut in now, an’ can count on starvin’ or surrender.”

Up to this moment the boys had been so interested in the manuscript found in the so-called treasure-chamber that they had forgotten both thirst and hunger; but now they began to realize there was nothing in the way of provisions, and, what was worse yet, not a drop of water had been procured.

“I wish he hadn’t said anything about it,” Nelse whispered, “for now I begin to feel as if I must have a drink.”

“You’ll have to take it out in feeling for a while, because it would be the height of folly to venture away from this place until father comes.”

“And that may not be for a week.”

“It can’t be helped, unless——”

“Unless what?” Nelse asked, eagerly, as Gil hesitated.

“I fancied for a minute that we might possibly make a trade with these fellows. How would it do to tell them they might go, if their friends would bring us water and food?”

“It isn’t probable they’d agree to it.”

“I reckon they are like almost everybody else, and would do a good deal to save their own lives.”

“That is true, and it couldn’t do any harm to try the scheme, although I don’t believe it will amount to anything; but it’s only fair Jenkins should know what we intend to do.”

“Go up the tunnel, and ask him what he thinks of the plan. I’ll stay here on watch, and if he agrees we can make Andy do the talking.”

Nelse ran into the passage, returning a few moments later, as he said:

“Mr. Jenkins is willing we should try to make the trade; but he don’t believe it can be done.”

“How are things in there?”

“The fellows tumbled into the hole; but there were so many that all but two managed to get out, and the chances are they’ll be more careful in the

future.”

“Does Jenkins think there will be another attack?”

“He says they’re bound to starve us out, for it must be known how easily that can be done.”

“Is he holding the two who are in the hole?”

“There’s no need for him to do anything, since the fellows can’t get out, an’ we’ve got such a small number of cartridges that it would be foolish to shoot at men who are unable to do any mischief.”

“Then there’s no reason why we shouldn’t try my plan. Here, Andy, talk to these fellows.”

The old darky came forward very unwillingly, and Gil explained the offer he wanted to make.

“I’s e boun’ to tell ’em, honey; but it won’t do the leastest mite ob good.”

“Go ahead, and we’ll soon find out what they think of it. At all events, there’ll be no great amount of harm done.”

Andy did as he was bidden, and after a long conversation, during which it seemed as if both the interpreter and the prisoners had considerable difficulty in understanding what was said, the blacks hailed those on the outside.

Then no slight amount of talking ensued, the men on the surface keeping themselves securely hidden, and at the close Andy was called upon once more to learn the result of the interview.

“Dey say how dey ain’ got anything to do dis yere bizziness,” the old man replied, after a painful effort to understand the prisoners; “but some ob de gang am gone to fin’ out ef it kin be fixed.”

“You won’t get any water, that I’ll guarantee,” Jenkins said, as he emerged from the tunnel. “They have gone to talk with the old men, an’ them fellers ain’t sich fools as not to know it’ll only be necessary to wait twenty-four hours before our jig is up.”

“Why did you leave the tunnel?” Gil asked, in surprise.

“Because there’s no use in staying there any longer. They’ve given up tryin’ to come in by that way, an’ in a few minutes the bosses of this ’ere fun will know jest how we’re situated.”

“Then you believe I did wrong in proposing to make the trade?”

“No, I don’t. It can make mighty little difference to us just now, an’ there was no harm to try.”

During the next five minutes the little party remained in almost perfect silence, each one thinking over the situation until all understood how futile would be their struggles unless Captain Mansfield returned very shortly, and then came a hail from the outside, which was answered by one of the prisoners.

A short conversation ensued, and when it was ended Andy stepped forward to act as interpreter.

One of the prisoners spoke at some length, and then the old darky said, hesitatingly:

“Dey says ef we’s willin’ for to come out as prisoners dey’ll gib us all we’s wants; but dere won’t be any water sent down hyar. Ef you’s gwine ter make any bargain, Marse Jenkins, don’ koun’ me in, kase I knows wha’ dese fellers am boun’ ter do, ef dey gits de chance.”

“Don’t you worry, Andy, we haven’t the slightest idea of acceptin’ any such temptin’ offer. Tell that feller to say to the others we’re goin’ to stay right where we are, an’ some of this crowd will be sorry before the row is ended.”

“Say that if any attack is made on us we shall feel obliged to defend ourselves by shooting the prisoners,” Gil added, hoping the threat might frighten the leaders; but by no means intending to carry it into execution.

The old darky did as he was bidden, and during the next five minutes a most exciting conversation followed between those above and the ones below; but it finally ceased, and Andy seated himself in the tunnel once more, this time taking good care to keep well out of range, as he said:

“Dat ends de tork, an’ now dey’s countin’ on windin’ dis yere bizziness up mighty quick.”

“Do you know what they mean to do?” Jenkins asked.

“Nebber a word; but one ob de rascals said dey’d hab us outer hyar right soon.”

“They had better begin now, for we shall need a pile of drivin’ before agreein’ to give ourselves up to sich a gang,” Jenkins said, as he flourished his revolver; but the look on his face belied the words, for he understood only too well how soon the struggle must be ended, and had no hope Captain Mansfield could return in time to aid them.

The hour which followed was passed almost in perfect silence. Each member of the party had bitter food for reflection, and all knew how soon they would be overpowered in case the enemy made a vigorous attack.

The one question which troubled them all was as to which quarter the next move might be expected from, and the boys were quite certain the blacks would confine themselves to the tunnel, since there they could at least enter without exposing themselves to the fire from the revolvers.

“I believe they’ll do——”

Gil ceased speaking very suddenly as a thin thread of blue smoke came curling down the passage, and his eyes involuntarily sought Jenkins’.

“That’s the size of it,” the mate exclaimed, as he leaped to his feet. “They’ve hit on a plan that’ll do us up in a little while without our bein’ able to stop it.”

“You mean they’re going to smoke us out?”

“Of course; can’t you see the plan has already been begun? We shall have to stay in the shaft, an’ from the top they’ll accomplish their work regardless of what we may do to the prisoners.”

Even while Jenkins was speaking the smoke increased in volume, and before five minutes passed all the party were standing at the entrance of the tunnel trying to free their eyes and lungs from the stifling vapor.

“There they come,” Nelse cried, and at that instant half-a-dozen spearlike clubs were thrown, two of them striking so near Jenkins that the sleeve of his coat was torn into shreds.

Without stopping to think that they might need the cartridges more at some future time, Gil discharged two barrels of his revolver at random, and in reply came more missiles, one of which knocked Andy senseless.

Both the boys would have sprung to his side, but that the mate restrained them, as he said, sharply:

“There’s no time to attend to him; we’ve got to look out for ourselves, an’ it’s time something——”

At that instant a loud cheer, unmistakably from the throats of white people, was heard, and Jenkins cried, excitedly:

“Here comes the captain! I know that shout; but I’m blest if I understand how he could have got here so quick. Now we shall see the imps take to their heels, an’ I’d like to have a chance to help them along.”

Before he could say anything more, Gil saw his father’s face peering over the edge of the shaft, and the revulsion of feeling from such a depth of despair to that of certainty his troubles were at an end, caused him to reel and relapse into a state of semi-unconsciousness, which was not very far removed from a veritable fainting spell.

---



## CHAPTER XXXII.

### THE DEPARTURE.

In the shortest possible space of time the entire situation was changed.

Captain Mansfield was accompanied by half-a-dozen men, all fully armed, and they at once proceeded to help the little party out of the shaft, Andy being the first who was sent to the surface.

The old darky revived before he was fairly drawn up, and the fact that he was no longer in any danger caused him to forget his injuries in the joyful knowledge.

“How did you get here so soon?” Jenkins asked, after the captain had welcomed the boys.

“We fell in with a trading schooner, and came directly back, for somehow I had an idea that you might be in trouble. But where are the rest of the party?”

Gil told in the fewest words possible of what had happened, and showed the diamonds in proof, Jenkins adding to the story:

“They’re hangin’ ’round here somewhere, an’ all I ask is the chance to have it out with them before we leave.”

“You shall have the opportunity, if we fall in with them; but I don’t propose to stay here any longer than is absolutely necessary. After you have had something to eat we’ll go on board the schooner, and read the remainder of the story.”

Gil insisted on releasing the prisoners before starting for the beach, and the poor wretches manifested the greatest surprise at being allowed to go free when they had fully expected to be killed. They stopped not on the order of their going; but rushed through the tunnel regardless of the smoke, and a few seconds later their outcries told that they had fallen into the underground chamber for the second time.

“Let them alone,” Jenkins said, with a laugh. “I’ll guarantee they manage to get out after we leave, an’ it won’t do ’em any harm to flounder ’round a

little while.”

Captain Mansfield was in too much of a hurry to allow the rescued party to linger very long near the scene of their misadventures; but hurried them away after the broken casket had been brought from the shaft, much to the delight of Andy, who said, gleefully, as he clutched firmly the mysterious “something” beneath his shirt:

“De cham hab done gone worked hissef out at las’ jes’ as I knowed it would; but dem debbils don’ ketch dis yere nigger ergin, kase I’s gwine ter stick mighty clus to de vessel arter dis.”

What a relief it was to find themselves in a stanch boat, manned by a full crew, and heading for a trim-looking schooner. It seemed to the boys as if the sky had never been so blue, the water so sparkling, nor the air so balmy as on this day while they were being rowed to the vessel Captain Mansfield had chartered.

Then how good the water tasted. At another time they might have found fault with the flavor; but now it seemed simply delicious, and the boys devoured the hard ship’s biscuit as if they were the lightest and sweetest of Andy’s productions.

When the little party had refreshed themselves, and were able to realize that they had really been saved from a horrible death, Captain Mansfield said, as he took the manuscript from the shattered casket:

“I will see if there is anything here which should be attended to before we leave, and if not, the schooner shall be gotten under way at once.”

“You promised to give me a chance at them thieves,” Jenkins said, quickly.

“You shall have it, never fear, providing the business can be settled before dark.”

Then the captain turned his attention to the manuscript, and read, in a low tone, after glancing over that portion which has already been given:

“The stones, together with as much money as I have been able to secrete, will remain in this subterranean chamber in case anything should happen to me, and I have no fear the blacks will betray the whereabouts of the hiding-place, since they are only too eager to invest every portion of the island with mystery.

“Whether this story will ever be read I know not; but, in case it is found, I implore whoever peruses it to cause search to be made for my family. The gold and plate will be sufficient to pay all necessary expenses, and I pray the diamonds may be given to my wife, together with the accompanying memoranda of the property I own in or near the capital.”

That completed the story. There was no name signed to it, neither were there any hints as to how the members of his family might be found; but Captain Mansfield said, as he assured himself there was nothing more connected with the unfortunate man’s history in the casket:

“If his wife or children are yet alive, we should be able to trace them by giving the outlines of this story to the different newspapers.”

“And we shall have no treasure after finding one,” Gil added, mournfully.

“It should be sufficient to pay you for all the labor and pain, that you will be able to relieve the wants of those who own the jewels, providing they are in distress. It is now quite important those sailors should be overhauled, for they must have carried away a reasonably large amount of gold, which must be recovered.”

“Shall I go ashore, sir?” Jenkins asked.

“Yes; but come back as soon as possible, for we want to sail while this wind holds.”

Neither the boys nor Andy cared to accompany the mate; but he had quite a large following in the crew of the schooner, all of whom were eager to join in the search.

It had been expected Jenkins would be absent a long while; but, to the surprise of all, he returned in less than an hour, bringing two packages in baskets of grass.

“Did you find the men?” Gil cried, impatient to learn the news, and not willing to wait until the boat came alongside.

“We found where they had been. The screams you heard last night while the blacks were coming through the tunnel, were their death cries.”

“Have they been killed?” Nelse asked, in tones of horror.

“We discovered their bodies not a hundred yards from the mouth of the shaft, and in the thicket near by was the stuff they had stolen.”

By this time the boat was alongside, and Jenkins passed over the rail the remainder of the treasure, consisting of silver plate and gold coin of considerable value.

“Did you meet any of the blacks?” Captain Mansfield asked.

“No, sir. I wanted to have one more brush with ’em; but you spoke about bein’ in a hurry, so I thought it wouldn’t pay.”

“And you did quite right. Swing the boat inboard, boys, and we will be off.”

Half-an-hour later the island looked to Gil and Nelse like nothing more than a small cloud on the surface of the water, and the venturesome cruise was really at an end, for before the sun rose again the schooner arrived at a Cuban port from which a freight steamer was on the eve of sailing for New York.

The journey home was decidedly uneventful after the many stirring adventures through which Gil and Nelse had passed, and it is well to bid them adieu as they greet the loved ones once more.

To-day, if they are reading this story, imperfectly told though it is, they will be able to verify all which is here set down, and can add for the information of those who may be interested, that the *Day Dream* is afloat. Not the one which was sunk off Pearl Point; but a new and even more speedy yacht, and she is commanded, as may be imagined, by Job Jenkins, while the captain of the galley is the same Andrew Jackson Washington Storts, who wore the mysterious charm which the boys were so eager to see, and which he still cherishes as something of the utmost value and power.

Was the real owner of the treasure ever found?

Indeed she was, and never was money more needed than by the unhappy man’s wife, who was in deepest distress when she chanced to see the advertisements Captain Mansfield had caused to be inserted in the daily papers.

The value of the diamonds was sufficient to place her beyond want, in a pecuniary sense, and both Gil and Nelse are more proud of the gold watches presented by the old lady in token of her gratitude, than they could possibly

have been, if the venturesome cruise had ended with the discovery of the buccaneers' treasure.



# THE BOYS' OWN LIBRARY

**Handsomely Bound in Cloth. Price, 75 cents per Volume**

This series contains the best boys' books written by the best authors for boys. It is pre-eminently a library for young people. The stories are of the bright and sparkling kind, full of adventure and not overburdened with lengthy descriptions—in fact, just the sort that must appeal to every healthy boy who is fond of thrilling exploits and deeds of heroism.

**Adventures of a Telegraph Boy.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Arthur Helmuth.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Battle and a Boy.** Blanche Willis Howard  
**Boy Boomers.** Gilbert Patten  
**Boy Cattle King.** Gilbert Patten  
**Boy From the West.** Gilbert Patten  
**Boys in the Forecastle.** George H. Coomer  
**Butcher of Cawnpore.** Wm. Murray Graydon  
**Cadet Kit Carey.** Lieut. Lounsberry  
**Captain Carey.** Lieut. Lounsberry  
**Centreboard Jim.** Henry Harrison Lewis  
**Chased Through Norway.** James Otis  
**Check Number 2134.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Commodore Junk.** George Manville Fenn  
**Cruise of the Snowbird.** Gordon Stables  
**Cryptogram.** William Murray Graydon  
**Catmur's Cave.** Richard Dowling  
**Dean Dunham.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Dick Chiverly.** W. H. G. Kingston  
**Dingo Boys.** George Manville Fenn  
**Don Kirk's Mine.** Gilbert Patten  
**Ensign Merrill.** Henry Harrison Lewis  
**Eric Dane.** Matthew White, Jr.  
**Erie Train Boy.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Five Hundred Dollar Check.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**From Canal Boy to President.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**From Farm Boy to Senator.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**From Lake to Wilderness.** William Murray Graydon  
**From Powder Monkey to Admiral.** W. H. G. Kingston  
**From Tent to White House.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Gay Dashleigh's Academy Days.** Arthur Sewell  
**Giant Islanders.** Brooks McCormick  
**Gold of Flat Top Mountain.** Frank H. Converse  
**Golden Magnet.** George Manville Fenn  
**Golden Rock.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Grand Chase.** George Manville Fenn

**Grand Chaco.** George Manville Fenn  
**Guy Hammersley.** Matthew White, Jr.  
**Happy-Go-Lucky Jack.** Frank H. Converse  
**Heir to a Million.** Frank H. Converse  
**How He Won.** Brooks McCormick  
**In Barracks and Wigwam.** William Murray Graydon  
**Inland Waterways.** James Otis  
**In Search of an Unknown Race.** Frank H. Converse  
**In Southern Seas.** Frank H. Converse  
**In the Sunk Lands.** Walter F. Bruns  
**James Braithwaite.** W. H. G. Kingston  
**Joe Nichols.** Alfred Oldfellow  
**Jud and Joe.** Gilbert Patten  
**Kit Carey's Protege.** Lieut. Lounsberry  
**Land of Mystery.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Lieut. Carey's Luck.** Lieut. Lounsberry  
**Mark Stanton.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Midshipman Merrill.** Henry Harrison Lewis  
**My Mysterious Fortune.** Matthew White, Jr.  
**Mystery of a Diamond.** Frank H. Converse  
**Nature's Young Noblemen.** Brooks McCormick  
**Ned Newton.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**New York Boy.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Old Man of the Mountain.** Geo. H. Coomer  
**On the Trail of Geronimo.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Perils of the Jungle.** Edward S. Ellis  
**Peter the Whaler.** W. H. G. Kingston  
**Pirate Island.** Harry Collingwood  
**Rajah's Fortress.** William Murray Graydon  
**Rival Battalions.** Brooks McCormick  
**Silver Ship.** Leon Lewis  
**Spectre Gold.** Headon Hill  
**That Treasure.** Frank H. Converse  
**Tiger Prince.** William Dalton  
**Tom Tracy.** Horatio Alger, Jr.  
**Tour of a Private Car.** Matthew White, Jr.  
**Uncle Nat.** Alfred Oldfellow



**Uncle Nat.** Alfred Oldfellow

**Unprovoked Mutiny.** James Otis

**Voyage to the Gold Coast.** Frank H. Converse

**Walter Griffith.** Horatio Alger, Jr.

**War Tiger.** William Dalton

**Way to Success.** Alfred Oldfellow

**Weathercock.** George Manville Fenn

**Wheeling for Fortune.** James Otis

**White Elephant.** William Dalton

**White King of Africa.** William Murray Graydon

**White Mustang.** Edward S. Ellis

**With Boer and Britisher.** William Murray Graydon

**Won at West Point.** Lieut. Lounsberry

**Young Acrobat.** Horatio Alger, Jr.

**Young Editor.** Matthew White, Jr.

**Young Vagabond.** Z. R. Bennett

Any volume sent, postpaid, upon receipt of price

STREET & SMITH, PUBLISHERS, NEW YORK

---

# **CAMP AND CANOE SERIES**

**By ST. GEORGE RATHBORNE**

## **“Canoe and Camp-Fire”**

In this, the first book in the series, the splendid setting of the story is in the woods of Maine. A grasping uncle waylays his nephew in the pine wilderness and endeavors to force him to part with his birthright. A sturdy chum comes to the rescue just in time, and joins hands in routing the thieving relative.

## **“Paddling Under Palmettos”**

The boys who play their parts in the second volume in this absorbing series, are manly, whole-hearted boys, knowing no fear, whether set upon at midnight while bivouacked around the camp-fire, or plying their paddles in treacherous currents and menaced by unseen foes on shore.

## **“The Rival Canoe Boys”**

Is the title of the third book in the “Camp and Canoe Series.” It is a story of mystery, ill-fortune, and perseverance. Two manly boys, of the lake region, are face to face with an unscrupulous specimen of the dude type and a villainous guide, who is open for any crime, provided there are enough dollars back of it.

**In Cloth: \$1.00 per Volume**

***STREET & SMITH*** *238 William Street*  
*NEW YORK*

---

# The Rockspur Athletic Series

*THE SIX BOOKS IN THIS SERIES ARE THE SORT  
THAT MUST APPEAL TO EVERY BOY WHO IS FOND  
OF OUTDOOR EXERCISE OF WHATEVER KIND*

## The Rockspur Nine

Is a base-ball tale of absorbing interest, which must be read not alone for its story—which is admirable—but also for its many hints on pitching, catching and batting, that will be found invaluable to the boy who wishes to shine in the base-ball world.

## The Rockspur Eleven

Is, appropriately enough, a story of foot-ball; and it is impossible to conceive a yarn more fascinating to the healthy boy who feels at his best in his foot-ball rig.

## The Rockspur Rivals

The scenes are those of winter, and most of the action takes place on the ice. Here, too, there is much useful information in a readable shape—this time about ice-boats, fancy skating, sleds and skis, and ice hockey.

**Three other books will be added to the Series later on. Their titles are: “The Rockspur Athletes,” “The Rockspur Crew,” and “The Rockspur Champions.”**

***ELEGANTLY BOUND IN CLOTH  
\$1.00 PER VOLUME***

Street & Smith, 238 William St., N. Y.

---



# Ranch and Range Series

*By St. GEORGE RATHBORNE*

**There are no more delightful characters in fiction than Karl, the young cowboy, and Cuthbert Lee, his tenderfoot "pard," whose strange adventures are chronicled in the three volumes which comprise this series.**

In "**Sunset Ranch**," which is the first volume in the "RANCH AND RANGE SERIES," Karl succeeds in saving from the clutches of a villainous gang, Cuthbert's long-lost cousin, a laughing-eyed maid who has spent most of her life on the prairie. Fascinating in the extreme are the descriptions of Cowboy life as it was in its most famous days; of the grand round-up, range-riding, night "wrangling," and Indian horse racing.

The scene changes to a lone dug-out in the pine woods in the second book of the Series, which is called, "**Chums of the Prairie**." There is trouble for the two boys right along from the first chapter, whether it be facing death in a bear's den, or brought to bay by the gray terror of the pine.

Third in the "RANCH AND RANGE SERIES" comes "**The Young Range Riders**," in which Karl and Cuthbert invade the land of the Montezumas, and find fresh adventure on a Mexican ranch.

**In Cloth,** <sup>at all</sup> <sub>booksellers,</sub> **\$1.00** <sup>per</sup> <sub>volume</sub>

Street & Smith, 238 William St., N. Y.

---

# THE FRANK MERRIWELL SERIES

## School Stories of Absorbing Interest



It is not necessary to introduce the now famous Frank Merriwell to the American boy. His name, associated as it is with the most marvelous exploits and heroic deeds, has been known and loved for years by countless youths on the western continent. This is the first time that the Frank Merriwell stories have appeared in cloth. The demand for them in this form grew so clamorous that it was no longer possible to delay publication. The edition is a handsome one, well illustrated, type good and large, and the covers are exceptionally fine.

## Frank Merriwell's School Days

This is the title of the first book in the series, and surely never were schooldays so crowded with fun and incident as those of Frank Merriwell. Right in the beginning he risks his own life to save a girl in a battle royal with a mad dog. But, as well as heroism, there is true sport, as any boy will say who reads about the great baseball game in which Frank figures.

## Frank Merriwell's Chums

In addition to the good fellows who make life pleasant for Frank Merriwell in the period covered by No. 1 of the series, we are here introduced to several others, who keep the ball rolling and distinguish themselves alongside their hero.

## Frank Merriwell's Foes

Even the best of fellows cannot help making enemies while jealousy continues to play its part in school life. Frank is all that is manly and candid, but there are enemies in camp, and he is frequently called upon to prove his mettle in this the third volume in the series.

***Bound in Cloth. One Dollar.***

STREET & SMITH, 238 WILLIAM ST., NEW YORK

---

## **Transcriber's Notes:**

Lt. James K. Orton was a pen name for James Otis Kaler.

Illustrations have been moved to paragraph breaks near where they are mentioned.

Punctuation has been made consistent.

Variations in spelling and hyphenation were retained as they appear in the original publication, except that obvious typographical errors have been corrected.



\*\*\* END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE SECRET  
CHART; OR, TREASURE HUNTING IN HAYTI \*\*\*

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

# THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at [www.gutenberg.org/license](http://www.gutenberg.org/license).

## **Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works**

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the

collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with

this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official

version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website ([www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org)), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.

- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

#### 1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES

EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a)

distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

## **Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg**

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

## **Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact



links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at [www.gutenberg.org/contact](http://www.gutenberg.org/contact)

## **Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

## **Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works**

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility: [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.